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Claudio Moreschini

A Christian in Toga

Boethius: Interpreter of Antiquity and Christian Theologian

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Foreword

The core of this book has its origin in the lectures I delivered at the University of Bremen in October 2011 during the annual graduate seminar "Christentum als antike Religion" organized by Christoph Auffarth, Marvin Doebler, and Ilinca Tanaseanu-Doebler. To them, and in particular to Professor Auffarth, for the warm and generous hospitality he extended to my wife and me, I wish to express my fondest gratitude. The original text has obviously been modified and enlarged (also thanks to the constructive observations by Marvin and Ilinca), even though I decided to keep the title of the lectures, "A Christian in Toga".

As it may be inferred from it, this book is neither an introduction, nor a general study on Boethius, but is meant to investigate the question of Boethius' Christianity, secular and at the same time theologically profound. Secular, because Boethius was a layman, who did not belong to the Church, and because he used almost exclusively the heritage of Greek (and partly Latin) Neo-Platonism together with those rational tools typical of a philosophical system. On the other hand, he was thoroughly interested in the issues of contemporary Christianity, starting from Augustine, whose legacy is perceivable even when not overtly mentioned. "The last of the Romans" (as Martin Grabman called Boethius, a designation that has generally become accepted) was therefore able to produce a synthesis, the validity of which was acknowledged throughout the Middle Ages until the rediscovery of Aristotle.

For his integration of philosophy and the kerygmatic tradition towards a theo-logy (a 'speaking of God not by faith but by reason')[1] Boethius paved the way with the works he dedicated to the *quadrivium*, and with an ambitious cultural project, which we hint at in the first chapter. Boethius did not abandon this idea (which we illustrate in the second chapter), even at the end of his life, when he composed the *Consolatio Philosophiae*. Notwithstanding the title, which emphasizes the importance of philosophy rather than that of religion (a fact that has often aroused wonderment and led to some new, though unconvincing, explanations), Boethius' last work, as we try to demonstrate in the third chapter, remained faithful to the main tenets of his philosophy, and explained the central questions of human life and of the universe by means of Neo-Platonism – a Christian Neo-Platonism.

Finally, I wish to thank my friend John Magee, of the University of Toronto, for having kindly translated into English the difficult passage of Boethius at p. 25, n. 52, and Dr. Cornelia Oefelein, who was extraordinarily attentive and

1 This is the key-word proposed by Tisserand (2008) 9 and passim.

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careful in correcting the English text, and showed great competence in arranging the final format for publication.

Pisa, September 2013 Claudio Moreschini

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1. Boethius' great cultural project

When examining Boethius' personality, our attention is usually drawn (when not studying his works on logic) to that composition which, since the Middle Ages, has been considered his most important one, the *Consolatio philosophiae*. The author's dramatic end and the nobility of the legacy of his message just before death have appeared so 'moving' that it is safe to say that Boethius is known especially for his final work.[1]

However, I would like to propose a different evaluation.

The *Consolatio* was written just shortly before the author's death, perhaps only months, or even weeks. In any case, this characteristic of having been written at the end of Boethius' life has influenced the opinion of critics regarding its author. It is quite logical to presume that when he embarked on his philosophical activity, Boethius could never have imagined the dramatic

1 The political, social, and economical condition of Italy during the reign of the Ostrogoths is still the object of thorough ongoing research and studies. Courcelle (1948) spoke of a cultural 'renaissance' under the rule of Theoderic. He insisted on this interpretation, which certainly had the merit of breaking down traditional stereotypes with which the presence of the Barbarians in the western part of the Empire was evaluated. But he did not investigate in depth – as this was not a problem within his scope – the historical and social aspect of that period, for which the most recent scholarship uses the term 'Roman-Barbaric kingdoms,' not simply 'Barbaric,' in order to underline the persistence of Roman tradition even in the years following the great invasions and the demise of the Western Empire. It is well known that Courcelle's views on the barbarian kingdoms (expressed in Courcelle (1964)) have been questioned by recent research. From the increasing amount of secondary literature on the subject see at least Goffart (1980), Thompson (2002), Cameron/Ward-Perkins/Whitby (eds.) (2000), Liebeschuetz (2006); Heather (2009) and (2010).
During the reign of Theoderic, Italy seems to have overcome its internal and external crisis, and to have entered upon a period, albeit short, of a new economical and cultural flowering in which, besides Boethius, other important men of letters, such as Cassiodorus, Arator, and Ennodius, were active. As is well known, the relative tranquility and stability that the king was able to establish in the first years of his reign had positive effects both on the political life and economy of Italy. One feature of this social and cultural situation was also the flourishing of schools, in which the members of aristocratic families were formed. The school, which continued to be organized in the traditional way, educated and prepared students for public office: it privileged the teaching of grammar, rhetoric, and law. Grammar was considered the foundation of eloquence, and continued to be studied with great interest. Generally speaking, this culture favored grandiloquent rhetoric and frequent displays of erudition, and in an excessive complication of form it became 'manner.' In spite of its brief vitality, ultimately it could not compensate for the growing lack of knowledge of the Greek language. As a consequence, contact with the very culture that had always nourished the Latin one, that is, philosophical and scientific culture, ceased. It is Boethius who opposed this process – and was the last to do so. Boethius, in fact, is the most significant contributor to this cultural renaissance. This is the context for his great plan to restore and preserve Greek philosophical and scientific culture, and to incorporate it into that of the Romans.

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end of his life. So how did he conceive of his project at the beginning of his philosophical activity? What was his aim? This is what our following observations on a 'Christian in toga' propose to expound.

One of the first endeavors of his youth (ca. 505 AD), was to deepen the study of the sciences of the quadrivium, interpreting them in a manner corresponding to Roman tradition. Soon after (ca. 510 AD), he began to critically reconsider Platonic – Aristotelian philosophy, translating and commenting Aristotle as his most compelling task. In his harmonization of both Plato and Aristotle, he may be considered a Neo-Platonic commentator, doing the very same work in Rome as Proclus in Athens or Ammonius in Alexandria. Boethius was without any doubt a follower of Proclus and Ammonius, whose doctrines (although not Christian) are essential to his philosophy.[2] During the years he composed the logical works he had occasion to discuss some questions regarding the Christian faith. He presented his interpretations in the *Opuscula theologica*, which he wrote in various moments and on different occasions, and which were compiled into one corpus during the Carolingian age. There he proposed a solution to controversies in Christology dividing Rome and Constantinople (ca. 510 AD), and Trinitarian theology, taking his stance when the question arose after the arrival of the so-called 'Scythian monks' in Rome (ca. 520 AD). The *Consolatio*, whose composition Boethius could logically not have foreseen, came last. It summarizes, of course, the previous studies, but Boethius himself could not consider it a work, which finally characterized his philosophical activity: he had always regarded himself a Neo-Platonist and a Christian.

Considered in its entirety, Boethius' opus adheres to the principle: "*Fidem, si poteris, rationemque coniunge.*" Its importance, asserted by Boethius himself at the end of one of his theological *Opuscula* (*Utrum Pater et Filius*, 185,67),[3] has been acknowledged in view of an evaluation of his theology, but not in its overall significance. Up to this period, in fact, Christians had been exhorted and admonished to separate faith from reason, not to connect one with the other. It is well known that events never occured according to the principles repeatedly asserted by Christian writers, namely that purity of faith should be preserved as it had been before, especially in Western Christianity. In Boethius' passage, *ratio* signifies philosophy, and rarely up to that time, especially in the Latin West, the method of joining reason with faith.[4] Pierre

2 The dependence of Boethius on Porphyry, on the one side, and on Proclus and Ammonius, on the other side, has been demonstrated by Courcelle (1948 and elsewhere), expanded by Obertello (1974, 476 – 544), and is now generally accepted, although it is not likely that Boethius traveled to Alexandria or to Athens to study Platonism. However, this possibility is not excluded by Chadwick (1981, 20).

3 We quote Boethius' *Consolatio* according to our own edition (^{2}2005).

4 See Tertullian's famous prescription (cf. *Praescr.* 7), which goes back to the passage in Col 2:8, exhorting Christians not to follow 'philosophy' and not to abandon themselves to curiosity. Tertullian's (or Paul's) prescription was constantly repeated by Christian writers in the West,

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Hadot denies such a definition (in our opinion too radically). He suggests with regard to an important section of the *Contra Eutychen et Nestorium* (c. 2 – 3), in which the problems of the person and the substance are discussed from a purely philosophical outlook, that, in general, Victorinus' and Boethius' endeavour to approach theological problems by means of a philosophical method failed, since their discussion is confined to a philosophical analysis.[5]

In addition, Boethius was a layman. Up until his time theology in the West had been the exclusive prerogative of the Church: in this respect, an antecedent may be found in Marius Victorinus. We will see, in fact, that Victorinus, theologian and philosopher, is significantly present in the works of Boethius. However, for Boethius, too, any theological study must develop from the fundamental principles of the Catholic Church, thus making it necessary to ascertain whether the results are consistent with it. The ultimate *auctoritas* on faith and philosophy was Augustine, whose renown had become fully acknowledged, despite the polemics directed against him during the fifth century AD (due mostly to his doctrine of free will). In the *De sancta Trinitate* (prol. 30 – 2) Boethius frankly asserts: "*Vobis tamen etiam illud inspiciendum est, an ex beati Augustini scriptis semina rationum aliquos in nos venientia fructus extulerint.*"[6] In Augustine Boethius encountered the same intermingling of (Neo-)Platonism and Christian faith, which he attempted to apply to his own studies. Lastly, such a divergence between *fides* and philosophy cannot be upheld for Boethius' works: as R. Crouse observed, "according to his classification of sciences, both the *Tractates* and the *Consolation* must belong to *theologia*, and seek to penetrate divine mysteries *intellectualiter.*"[7] Claudio Micaelli has provided an important discussion of this problem.[8] This intermingling will be examined briefly in the following pages, which are dedicated to the works on the quadrivium and on logic. For full discussions of these topics, the reader is requested to consult the definitive studies by Obertello, Chadwick, Marenbon, and Gruber.[9]

although actual practice did not necessarily conform to it. Augustine himself, who was a Neoplatonic philosopher and wrote philosophical dialogues before his conversion, allegedly abandoned philosophy after his baptism, and even more emphatically after his return to Africa. The final point of Augustine's change in opinion regarding philosophy and rationality is reached in the *Retractationes.*

5 P. Hadot (1968), 66 – 67.

6 "You must however examine whether the seeds of argument sown in my mind by St. Augustine's writings have borne fruit." We quote here and elsewhere, unless otherwise indicated, the translations of the *Consolatio* and the *Opuscula Theologica* by Tester (1978).

7 Crouse (1982), 417 – 21.

8 In the first chapter of his book (1995).

9 Cf. Obertello (1974), 172 – 96 and 451 – 75, Chadwick (1981), 71 – 107, Marenbon (2003b), 14 – 16, Gruber (2011), 14 – 25.

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1.1 Mathematics

Boethius provides a definition of mathematics in one of his opuscula theologica, the De sancta Trinitate (2,73 – 6), one of his latest works. Mathematics is a science situated between physics and theology. Physics, mathematics, and theology are *speculativae partes*, i. e. 'parts of the speculative science', of the θεωρητική (i. e. of contemplative philosophy), according to the division of sciences we find in the contemporary Neoplatonist Ammonius Hermeiou, whose lectures Boethius had presumably attended in Alexandria.[10] Mathematics is

sine motu inabstracta (*haec enim formas corporum speculatur sine materia ac per hoc sine motu: quae formae cum in materia sint, ab iis separari non possunt*).[11]

In the *Institutio arithmetica* Boethius repeatedly calls mathematics *mathesis* (*prooem.* 4; II 4,1 and 31,1). This meaning of *mathesis* is new, because at that time *mathesis* usually designated astrology.[12]

Being part of philosophy, and concerning themselves with the incorporeal forms, mathematical sciences have quite a close relationship with the Platonic tradition: the fourth book of the *Republic* expounds their theoretical function. Thanks to their power to develop the faculty of abstraction, mathematical sciences purify and awaken the soul's eye, currently obfuscated and distracted, but the only one able to perceive the truth, and lead it from sensual reality to the intelligible one, that is the object of philosophy.[13] Yet mathematics is not philosophy, as the Pythagoreans asserted. According to Plato (*resp.* 509e ff.), mathematical objects certainly are νοητά, but they are known by the διάνοια, not by the νοῦς. Therefore Boethius, in the passage of the *De sancta Trinitate*, assigned mathematics to philosophy, but did not identify them; he distinguished between mathematics and theology, which studies the objects *sine motu abstracta*, i. e. the νοητά, as Plato asserted of philosophy.[14]

Mathematics is divided into the sciences of the *quadrivium*. Boethius' treatises on them,[15] originally intending to produce a well-ordered corpus,[16]

10 Cf. Amm. Herm., *in Porphyr. Isag.* 13,10 – 15 Busse.

11 "Mathematics does not deal with motion and is not abstract, for it investigates forms of bodies apart from matter, and therefore apart from motion, which forms, however, being connected with matter, cannot be really separated from bodies." On this passage see also Heilmann (2007) 23 – 28.

12 To explain this modification of the meaning of *mathesis* Hadot pertinently quotes a passage of Aulus Gellius (*Noctes Atticae* I 9,6), where Gellius asserts that the Pythagoreans and the ancient Greeks called μαθήματα geometry, gnomonic, music and the noblest sciences, while in his time μαθήματα currently meant astrology and the astrologers were called μαθηματικοί. Cf. I. Hadot (^{2}2005), 170 n. 56.

13 On this topic see Heilmann (2007) 68 – 88 and 104 – 12.

14 For this distinction between mathematics and theology, we follow Guillaumin (1990) 122 – 25.

15 Certainly we cannot give an exhaustive bibliography on the problem of the quadrivium and its

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are most likely his very first works. Only those on arithmetic and music are extant; those on astronomy and geometry (mentioned by Cassiodorus)[17] are lost. Although arithmetic and music do not constitute a real propaedeutic to Platonism (they are, however, propaedeutic to philosophy[18]), Platonism appears to be an essential component of them:

Le *quadrivium* médiéval, le cycle des quatre arts mathématiques, a été conçu dans le contexte de la doctrine platonicienne. Aucune autre philosophie, et encore moins une réflexion purement pédagogique et didactique n'aurait pu imaginer que l'étude de ces quatre sciences pût être l'instrument nécessaire pour la connaissance des êtres. Cette vue des choses n'à été possible que sur un arrière-plan philosophique précis et à l'aide d'une doctrine qui attribuait à certains nombres des fonctions ontologiques."[19]

This statement appears to fit Boethius' philosophy perfectly, and his re-interpretation of Christian doctrine on the basis of Platonic tenets.

1.1.1 Arithmetic

The presence of Platonism already characterizes what is likely Boethius' first work, the *Institutio arithmetica*, whose contents depend heavily on the *Introductio arithmetica* (Ἀριθμητικὴ Εἰσαγωγή) by the Neopythagorean Nicomachus of Gerasa (first half of the second century AD).[20] The mingling

origin: for an idea of different opinions, we quote only Pizzani (1981) and I. Hadot (^{2}2005); for Augustine see also Shanzer (2005), against Hadot and in support of the hypothesis of a Varronian origin of the four disciplines.

16 According to Pizzani, it seems difficult to consider the works on arithmetic and on music as corresponding to an actual project. We do not have, he observes, any proof that Boethius intended to use them towards creating a kind of introduction to philosophy. Although he adopted the scheme of the mathematic disciplines proposed in the prooemium of the *Institutio arithmetica* from Nicomachus' introduction, yet he did not follow it when composing his own scientific treatises. The *De institutione musica* is not limited by a mathematic interpretation, and chronology does not provide any proof that Boethius composed the four treatises on the quadrivium in succession (on arithmetic, on music, on geometry and on astronomy). The *De institutione musica* could have been written long after the *De institutione arithmetica* and indubitably was conceived by Boethius as an autonomous work. Cf. Pizzani (1981), 211 – 26. I am not entirely convinced of Pizzani's argument. There are no difficulties in supposing that Boethius could have executed his project later, after having written on arithmetic and music, and not composing his works in immediate succession. The project was such that it could have required many years for its execution.

17 Cf. Cassiodorus, *Variae* I 45.

18 Cf. Bernard (1997) 67 – 69.

19 I. Hadot (^{2}2005) 99.

20 The *communis opinio* is that Boethius *translated* Nicomachus, but this must be corrected by a careful examination of many passages in both Nicomachus and Boethius. Boethius, as he himself asserts (*inst. arithm.*, *praef.* 3), modifies Nicomachus' work from the very introduction. Cf. Guillaumin (1989) 869: "paraphrase éclairée." On the importance of Nicomachus for the formation of the quadrivium cf. I. Hadot (^{2}2005), 63 – 69; for the Pythagorean and Platonic

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of Platonic doctrines in the so-called Neopythagorean works is evident at least since the beginning of the Imperial era.[21]

The *Institutio arithmetica* still displays a rather simple and traditional Platonism.[22] In the prologue, which he dedicated to his father-in-law, Symmachus, Boethius emphasizes the important function of science. Arithmetic is the first discipline of the quadrivium (praef. 4). Then Boethius asserts that, according to Pythagoras, it is not possible to reach the perfection of philosophical speculation without deepening the study of the sciences of the quadrivium, which constitute the necessary pathway for ascending from sensual realities to intellectual truths (I 1,5). Only these sciences, in fact, are able to enlighten our mind's eyes, which are now obfuscated by and submerged in corporeal senses, and direct them toward higher truths.

According to the well-known interpretation of the word, Pythagoras stated that philosophy is aspiration to wisdom (*Instit. Arithm.* I 1,1), a definition repeated by Boethius in the contemporary works, such as the *Institutio musica* (II 2) and the first commentary on the *Isagoge* by Porphyry (I 3, p. 7,12 – 23, Brandt); this definition is certainly traditional, and is found as well in Boethius' sources, Ammonius (p. 9,7 ss.) and Nicomachus (p. 1,5 – 2,5).[23] Philosophy as knowledge of the real and immutable being returns – expressed almost in the very same words – in a passage of *Instit. Mus.* II 2: Pythagoras considered philosophy as the science

eius rei […] *quae proprie vereque esse diceretur. Esse autem illa putabat, quae nec intentione crescerent nec deminutione decrescerent nec ullis accidentibus mutarentur. Haec autem esse formas magnitudines qualitates habitudines ceteraque quae per se speculata immutabilia sunt, iuncta vero corporibus permutantur et multimodis variationibus mutabilis rei cognatione vertuntur* (p. 227,21 – 228,2 Friedlein).[24]

origin of the four sciences of the quadrivium, not only the most exhaustive I. Hadot, but also Guillaumin (1990), 139 – 140 (Archytas: VS I, pp. 330 – 1; Plat., *resp.* 522c and 530d).

21 Pizzani (1981), 225 – 26.

22 An examination of the first chapter of the *Institutio arithmetica* is provided also by Heilmann (2007) 88 – 103.

23 Other *loci similes* in Boethius' and Ammonius' commentaries on the *Isagoge* are the division of philosophy into theoretical and practical philosophy and the variety of their species (Boethius p. 8,1 – 8; Ammonius, p. 11,6 – 21), as well as the threefold division of theoretical philosophy (Boethius p. 8,8 – 9,12; Ammonius, p. 11,21 – 12,6).

24 "[the science] of those things […] which properly and really exist. Those things, he asserted, neither increase by an enlargement nor diminish by a contraction nor change due to any accidents. They are the forms, the greatness, the qualities, the characters and all the peculiarities which, when considered per se, are unchangeable, but do change when they are united to matter and are subjected to multiple alteration caused by their union with a changeable thing."
This text (if it is sound) is not clear, because the true being is first presented in the singular (eius rei quae etc.), then in the plural (illa, quae nec crescerent etc.). We translated ad sensum, as Heilmann (2007, 117) did (without noting the difficulty).

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This means that wisdom is not the common knowledge of arts and of manual crafts (as, according to Ammonius, it was considered to be in early Greek times), but that wisdom "*quae nullius indigens, vivax mens et sola rerum primaeva ratio est.*"[25] (*comm. Isag.* I 3, p. 7,15 – 16 Brand).

Boethius then defines the true science to which he aspires.[26] The object of philosophy is knowledge of the immutable being:

est enim sapientia rerum quae proprie vereque sunt suique immutabilem substantiam sortiuntur comprehensio veritatis. Esse autem illa dicimus quae nec intentione crescunt nec retractione minuuntur nec variationibus permutantur, sed in propria semper vi suae se naturae subsidiis nixa custodiunt (*Instit. Arithm.* I 1,1),[27]

that is, knowledge of the forms of matter that have an immutable substance: "*Haec igitur quoniam, ut dictum est, natura immutabilem substantiam vimque sortita sunt, vere proprieque esse dicuntur*"(I 1,2).[28]

All this connects Boethius with the tradition of Platonism: "*quae vere proprieque sunt*" is a translation of the Platonic formula τὸ ἀεὶ ὡσαύτως ἔχον

25 " […] which needs nothing, is the intelligence in its best activity and the sole original rational explanation of things."

26 It is well known that the Latin world was quite deficient in science and especially mathematics. The Romans, who were more interested in practical questions on the application of mathematics, had never penetrated into the philosophical speculations concerning arithmetic. No Latin name is listed among the great mathematicians of the ancient world. According to the testimony of Cassiodorus, Nicomachus' Introduction to Arithmetic had already been translated by Apuleius of Madaura (cf. Cassiodorus, *Instit.* II 4,7), but no trace of this first Latin version remains, so that the Nicomachean Arithmetic could be known in the Middle Ages only through the translation by Boethius. Nicomachus' Introduction, even though it did not include any original material, gathered and collected in an organic work the main concepts of Pythagorean mathematics. It was essentially theoretical, not directed to practical applications or the solution of problems, but rather to the investigation of the properties of numbers, which was considered fundamental for the study of philosophy. So it was more a tractate of arithmetical – i. e. philosophical – nature rather than a mathematical one. Arithmetic, which is the first among the sciences of the quadrivium, reveals, in the speculative path delineated by Boethius, its tight connection with philosophy, and justifies the theoretical character of the tractate, which never descends to the level of practice. For this reason, it seems that Boethius' *Institutio arithmetica* was not used in medieval schools, although it was available in all scholastic libraries, as their catalogues attest. It seems, in fact, that arithmetic was studied on simpler and more elementary texts, such as the brief tractate included in the Etymologies by Isidore of Seville. The Nicomachean Arithmetic translated by Boethius remains in its field the most important and the main reference for scholars until the twelfth century, when the West acquires the legacy of Arabic mathematical science (Obertello, 1974 (451 – 4 and 473 – 4)). A well-informed study on the *Institutio arithmetica* is Bernard (1997): the *status quaestionis* (63 – 65), *multitudo* and *magnitudo* (67 – 73), other arithmological questions (73 ss.).

27 "Wisdom indeed is the intellection of the real nature of those things which properly and truly exist and possess an unchangeble existence. And we assert that really exist those things which neither enlarging increase nor contracting diminish nor varying change, but sustained by the help of their nature always maintain themselves in their energies."

28 "Since, as stated, these entities got by nature an unchangeable substance and energy, they are asserted to exist really and properly."

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(see for instance *Phaed.* 79de), quite common in the Platonic tradition. Nicomachus, too, asserts (p. 2, 8 – 11) that philosophy is the science of the immovable realities (ὄντα δὲ τὰ κατὰ τὰ αὐτὰ καὶ ὡσαύτως ἀεὶ διατελοῦντα, also p. 4,9 – 11). It is furthermore noteworthy that Boethius distinguishes between '*substantia*,' which is the true reality of a thing, and '*essentia*,' which is the pure being (cf. *CEN* 3, 250 – 252). *Essentiae* in the Platonic tradition are the ideas (Apuleius still employed both words as synonymous, *De Platone* I 6,193: "*et primae quidem substantiae vel essentiae*," shortly after asserting [ibid.]: "οὐσίας [i.e. *substantiae*], *quas essentias dicimus*").[29]

Then Boethius, following Nicomachus (p. 4,17 – 5,12), proceeds to create a precise order among the sciences on the basis of their object of competences (I 1,3). This object is being, which in the first instance can be continuous (dimension) or discontinuous (multiplicity). The discontinuous being, namely quantity, can in turn be absolute or relative. The continuous being, namely dimension, can be at rest or in motion. The absolute quantity, that is, the numbers, is the object of arithmetic; the relative quantity, that is, the relationships between numbers, which constitute the musical harmonies, is the object of music (I 1,4). The static dimension, namely the geometric figures, are the object of geometry, while the moving dimension is the object of astronomy, which studies the movements of heavenly bodies, based on mathematical laws as well. This reflection demonstrates the solidarity and compactness connecting the sciences of the quadrivium, which have their fulcrum in the number (I 1,4). The true philosopher is he who devotes himself to all four mathematical sciences, which are like stairs or bridges that raise human thought from sensual reality to the world of the intelligibles. In consequence, Boethius devotes a specific tractate to each science (I 1,5 and 7).

The science to be studied first, Boethius asserts, because it is a sort of root and mother of all others, is arithmetic, since the number, when considered absolutely, ontologically precedes the numeric relationship and the geometric dimensions.[30] But there is another important aspect establishing the anteriority of arithmetic: it is the model upon which God arranges the universe:

Haec (arithmetica) cunctis prior est, non modo quod hanc ille huius mundanae molis conditor deus primam suae habuit ratiocinationis exemplar et ad haec cuncta constituit quaecumque fabricante ratione per numeros adsignati ordinis invenere concordiam (I 1,8).[31]

29 "The first substances or essences […] substances, which we call 'essences'."

30 Cf. also Nicomachus, p. 9,5 ss.

31 "Arithmetic is the first of all sciences, not only because God, the excellent creator of this immense universe, had first arithmetic as a model of his reasoning and according to it created all the things which found a mutual accord through the numbers of the order they received by God thanks to His creating rationality." That arithmetic comes first in the quadrivium had been

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The same is repeated soon after (I 2,1), where Boethius states that "*omnia quaecumque a primaeva rerum natura constructa sunt, numerorum videntur ratione formata. Hoc enim fuit principale in animo conditoris exemplar*"[32] (cf. Nicomachus, p. 12,1 – 11). In these passages, two different theories seem to emerge: one that conceives numbers as the principle of things, the other perceiving things to be made in the likeness of numbers. The Middle and Neoplatonic definition of God's intelligence as the 'place of ideas' (e. g. Alcinous, *didask*. 9, p. 163,30 – 31 Hermann; Apuleius, *de Plat.* I 5,187) is still manifest in both passages. This doctrine seems to be characteristic of the 'scientific,' not of the 'theological' works.

Therefore numbers are the immanent causes of things and their substance (I 1,8). The idea of the conformity of things with numbers as their models leads to the vision of an orderly and harmonious world and to the thought that the only true knowledge is that of quantity, so that it may be essentially asserted that everything is number, in the sense that the universe is conceived in a quantitative manner. Everything is disposed in good order thanks to number: the movements of stars, the bodies, and the sounds are regulated by mathematical principles (I 1,9 – 11). On the one side, therefore, we have the divine number, the intelligible one, which exists in the intellect of God as primary archetypical model, on the other side, the quantitative number, which acts on the plane of the senses. As we have already observed, the assertion that such a paradigm is in the intellect of God seems to be an allusion to the doctrine of ideas as thoughts of God. God, in fact, creates all things and orders them according to the constitutive archetypes of His intellect: these archetypes, however, are not the ideas of the Platonic tradition, but the numbers. The numbers, therefore, seem to replace, in the divine intellect, the ideas: they are, in fact, located in the intellect of God and are described with the features traditionally attributed to the ideas: as archetypical models of all things, immutable and cause of stability for all things.

Arithmetic as such is not a purely theoretical science: arithmetical investigations have an ethical and metaphysical significance:

Magnus quippe in hac scientia fructus est, si quis non nesciat quod bonitas definita et sub scientiam cadens animoque semper imitabilis et perceptibilis prima natura est et suae substantiae decore perpetua, infinitum vero malitiae dedecus est, nullis propriis principiis nixum, sed natura semper errans […] *Hoc autem erit perspicuum, si intellegamus omnes inaequalitatis species ab aequalitatis crevisse primordiis* (*Instit. Arithm.* I 32,1 – 2).[33]

asserted by Boethius already in *prooem.* 4, to justify the decision to treat arithmetic at the beginning of his studies.

32 "Everything that has been created by nature at the origin appears to have been constructed by the rationality of numbers. Such rationality was the primeval model the Creator had in his intelligence."

33 "Great certainly is the profit which comes from this science, if we do not ignore that the definite

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As Chadwick remarks, "[T]he paragraph has the interest of being a piece that could as easily be found in the middle of the *Consolation of Philosophy*."[34]

Lastly, let us reconsider the passage of the *De sancta Trinitate* (2,73 – 6), which we quoted above (p. 12). Mathematics is "*sine motu inabstracta* (*haec enim formas corporum speculatur sine materia ac per hoc sine motu: quae formae cum in materia sint, ab iis separari non possunt*)".[35] This means that mathematics – thanks to the activity of arithmetic – observes those realities which are independent from material objects and their movement: the *formae* that are the object of mathematics are without matter, but do not possess subsistence of their own, are not independent from material bodies from which they "*separari non possunt*." This definition, proposed by Boethius in one of his late works, contradicts the Nicomachean theory, which we observed in the *Institutio arithmetica*, because for Nicomachus (and Boethius in his youth[36]) the *formae* already exist *per se* in the Creator's mind.

1.1.2 Music

After the 'translation' of the Nicomachean *Arithmetic*, Boethius devotes himself to the composition of a tractate on the second science of the quadrivium. Music is closely connected with arithmetic, since it is based on mathematical laws. Music had a fundamental significance in the ancient world and an extremely close relationship with philosophy, a connection which dates from the discovery attributed to Pythagoras that musical intervals are of mathematical nature. If this is the case, then also all other things and ultimately the entire universe must have the same rational structure. Aristotle (*Metaph*. 985b23 – 986a3) attributes the theory of cosmic harmony to the Pythagoreans. Pythagorean theory was resumed and particularly enhanced by Plato in the myth of Er at the end of the *Republic*, in which he expounds the famous doctrine of the harmony of the spheres, according to which revolving heavenly spheres emit a sound, and in the *Timaeus*, where the creation of the world soul is accomplished on the basis of harmonic relationships. This theory had a wide circulation and remained a fundamental element of the Pythagorean and Platonic tradition. At least since the third century AD,

excellence, which is the object of science and is always subject to imitation and perceptible, is the first nature, which perpetually remains in the honour of its substance; on the contrary, the ugliness of ill is infinite, not sustained by its foundations, but always modified by its nature […] This will clearly appear if we understand that all the genera of dissimilarities grew from the similarity, which is their foundation."

34 Chadwick (1981), 75 – 76.

35 "Mathematics does not deal with motion and is not abstract, for it investigates forms of bodies apart from matter, and therefore apart from motion, which forms, however, being connected with matter, cannot be really separated from body."

36 Cf. *Instit. Arithm.* I 1,8; 2,1.

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Neo-Pythagoreanism had evolved into a kind of Platonism. It appealed to Latin authors as well, like Macrobius, who composed a commentary on the *Somnium Scipionis.* Through Boethius' work (and that of Martianus Capella and Cassiodorus), this doctrine was transmitted to the Middle Ages. As in the case of the *Arithmetica*, Boethius becomes reconnected with an ancient and long Pythagorean and Platonic tradition, to which he was devoting himself in those early years.[37] Notwithstanding its technicality and its difficulty, the *Institutio musica* is important because Boethius appears to present himself as a follower of Augustine, who had also written a *De musica*, while at the same time remaining a Platonic philosopher dependent on the doctrine on music proposed by Plato's *Republic.* The importance of the harmonic number is reasserted by Boethius at the end of his career, when in the *Consolatio* (III metrum IX, 13 – 14) he speaks of the world soul in this way: "*tu triplicis mediam naturae cuncta moventem / connectens animam per consona membra resolvis.*"[38]

The importance of music in the philosophy of Boethius (as previously for Augustine) testifies that his treatise on the topic was not conceived simply as an introduction, but aimed at underlining its significance. Music is not simply the theory of sound, but is the profound essence of reality and governs the world. Many poems of the *Consolatio philosophiae*, written twenty years later, exalt the presence of music in nature, which produces concord and harmony between opposed elements (for instance, *Consol.* I metrum 5; II metrum 8).[39] Chadwick has made some significant observations on the *Institutio musica* and has admirably explained its technicalities. We shall limit ourselves here to underlining the traditional character of the prooemium, in which Boethius dwells upon illustrating the ethical significance that music has for education and behavior, as asserted by Plato.[40] Ammonius Hermeiou (the supposed 'master' of Boethius) stated that music had a philosophical character of outstanding significance and importance towards calming the passions of the soul and exciting it to virtue (*In Porph. Isag.*, p. 8,23 – 4). According to Boethius, music helps reason control the irrational parts of the soul (*Institutio musica*, p. 186,30 – 187,3, Friedlein), just as the parts of the cosmic soul are connected thanks to music (*Timaeus* 35b). This is repeated in the *Consolatio* as well (V metrum 4, 30—41), and it is not by chance that effeminate music is excluded by Lady Philosophy, who substitutes it with a serious form. This

37 Among the different sources used by Boethius there are two works by Nicomachus of Gerasa, the *Handbook of Harmony* and the tractate *On Music.* Another source is the *Harmonics* of Ptolemy. On the content of this treatise see Obertello (1974), 462 – 70, Chadwick (1981), 78 – 101, Gruber (2011), 22 – 23 and particularly Heilmann (2007), whose account is most important for the relations between Boethius' theory of music and Neoplatonism.

38 "You, binding soul together in its threefold nature's midst, / soul that moves all things, then divide it into harmonious parts," cf. Chadwick (1981), 82.

39 In this poem the harmony of music is exclusively connected to harmony produced by love.

40 Cf. for instance *Resp.* 399c; 424b-c.

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higher kind of music, as stated in the prologue to the *Institutio musica*, must accompany the arduous reasonings of Philosophy and provide the soul refreshment for its struggles.[41]

1.2 Translations of Greek works on logic

Already in the *Institutio arithmetica* Boethius conceives his work as a cultural enterprise of the highest level: "to pass into the treasure of Latin language the heritage of Greek philosophy and science" ("*ea quae ex Graecarum opulentia litterarum in Romanae orationis thesaurum sumpta conveximus*," *praef.* 1).[42] Yet Boethius does not intend to do so in a slavish manner, but rather through a conscious reworking, even though, as Jean-Yves Guillaumin observes, the changes he made are relatively insignificant.[43] But with his expressed intention to modify the original and his awareness of obeying the necessities of rhetoric, Boethius reconnects with a vision of Greek culture typical of the Roman world, which dates from Cicero. This combined necessity of scientific precision and of literary elaboration is a characteristic of the logical works as well, written later.[44]

Boethius' central declaration on this theme is: "*At non alterius obnoxius institutis artissima memet ipsa translationis lege constringo, sed paululum liberius evagatus alieno itineri, non vestigiis, insisto*" (*Instit. Arithm.*, *praef.* 3).[45]

Therefore Boethius, although remaining faithful to his model, took certain

41 See on this topic the excellent article by Chamberlain (1970), 80 – 97.

42 The *Institutio geometrica*, too, was a translation (from Euclid's *Elementa*) if we believe Cassiodorus, *Variae* (I 45): "*translationibus tuis* […] *Nicomachus arithmeticus, geometricus Euclides audiuntur Ausonii.*" ("thanks to your translations, now the arithmetician Nicomachus and the geometer Euclid sound Latin"). See on this problem Obertello (1974), 470 – 5, Chadwick (1981), 102 – 7, Lejbowicz (2003), 301 – 39, at 326 – 7, who is skeptical about this possibility. It has been observed that in the *De hebdomadibus* Boethius quotes as a "*communis animi conceptio*" Euclid's *Elementa* I, n.c. 3: "*si duobus aequalibus aequalia auferas, quae relinquantur aequalia esse.*" But such an (obvious) principle can also be found in Martianus Capella, *De nuptiis* VI, 723. Cassiodorus' inquiries on *Mathematics* and *Geometry* are, according to Lejbowicz, very inaccurate and substantially generic. There is some truth to these observations, and in my opinion Cassiodorus was not so intimate with Boethius' family, not even after the demise of the Gothic kingdom.

43 Cf. Boèce, *Institution Arithmétique* (1995), XL. Guillaumin's statement (unduly, in my opinion) contradicts Boethius' aim.

44 About Boethius' translations and works on logic see Obertello (1974), 476 – 506, Chadwick (1981), 108 – 73, Marenbon (2003b), 43 – 65.

45 "But I am not the slave of the doctrines of others and I am not obliged to the law of a translation, but I pass more freely from one argument to another and I follow the path, not the steps, of the other". It is true that Boethius asserts this for his 'translation' from Nicomachus' *Institutio*, but we can safely assume that such was his method of translating. See also above, note 20.

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liberties in his translation, expanding some parts, summarizing others, and altering other parts of the Greek text to adjust it to the Latin public and make it more easily comprehensible. In fact, he often takes care to furnish those doctrines, which seem to him to be the most difficult, with ampler and more detailed examples. In so doing, he followed Cicero's principles about literary translation, always observed by Latin writers, including the Christians (Jerome, for example[46]). One particularly significant instance of this method is found in *Instit. Arithm.* II 45, where Boethius makes a remarkable addition, a comparison (not included in Nicomachus' tractate) demonstrating that he was freely elaborating his source: he compares the three principal types of proportion, the arithmetic, geometric, and harmonic, to the three types of political regime, oligarchy, democracy, and aristocracy, respectively – we might say: '*obscura per obscuriora!*'

After a preliminary exploration of the Platonic-Pythagorean tradition, Boethius proceeded towards Aristotelian logic. The extent of the presence of Aristotle and the Peripatetic school in the Latin world from Cicero to Boethius is still unclear, and has yet to be studied thoroughly.[47] A general study on Aristotelianism in the Latin world is, however, currently not available. The spread of philosophy in Rome did not involve Aristotle's logical works, which, like the others, were still concealed by the corpus of his esoteric works. For this reason, they were scarcely available in the western world for the entire fourth century. The availability was almost exclusively limited to the *Topica*, which Cicero had already used. Since in the Hellenistic age the tripartite division of philosophy into logic, physics, and ethics had become popular, Aristotelianism preferably termed the first discipline 'logic,' while the Platonic tradition generally preferred the appellation 'dialectic.'

An interest in Aristotelian logic was not new to Platonism since at least the second century AD, a fact especially true for the environment of Greek Platonism. Latin Middle and Neo-Platonism share the common attitude of Latin culture with respect to logic (both Aristotelian and Stoic). They substantially neglect it, on account of their inability to penetrate into the heart of strictly technical problems which are difficult to solve. Apuleius promised (*De Platone* I 4,189) to explain the logic of Plato, yet, if he had actually made the attempt, he would certainly have gone no further than the *Didaskalikòs* of Alcinous. Alcinous' interest in Aristotelian logic is limited to a summary and schematic study of the categories, insofar as they were applicable to the philosophy of Plato, according to the conviction of the Middle-Platonists of the time, namely that the study of Aristotle is a preparation to that of Plato. Apuleius, however, does not carry through. We are not able to say why, but it is certain that logic was an issue quite far from his mind. The spread of Platonism

46 See Jerome's treatise on the right way of translating (*epist.* 57, 5 – 6).

47 For the fourth century, the definitive monograph on Marius Victorinus by P. Hadot may be consulted (Hadot 1971).

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in a Latin environment during the course of the fourth century is attributable – even more than to the teaching of Plotinus – to the popularizing and systematic activities of Porphyry. They engendered a greater interest in logic, which manifested itself not only in the works of Marius Victorinus, but also in the production of certain pseudo-Victorinian and pseudo-Apuleian works, such as the *De interpretatione*, falsely attributed to Apuleius, which aims to integrate the teachings of the most famous masters.[48] A comparison between Marius Victorinus and Boethius is instructive. It was noted that Boethius constructs his studies on logic in sharp and conscious contrast to those of Marius Victorinus, surpassing them precisely in relation to certain key aspects of logic as a philosophical discipline, which transcends all rhetorical and didactic intention. Luigi Adamo has shown in a study[49] that has been well received by other scholars[50] that Victorinus' method, in his study of Porphyry's *Isagoge*, lacked all speculative interests and was instead mainly influenced by issues of rhetoric. The translation by Marius Victorinus, therefore, would have been more the work of an orator than a philosopher, and Boethius would have understood the necessity of furnishing his work on logic with the scientific characteristics missing from the work of Victorinus. This may perhaps arouse wonder, given that we know the depth of Marius Victorinus' theological thought, his ability to convey to a high level of speculation the themes of Western theological tradition; however, Victorinus, in addition to commenting on Porphyry, also studied Cicero (the *Topica* and the *De inventione*). Consequently, Boethius asserts for the translation of works on logic a principle much more sophisticated than the Ciceronian and traditional one which he presented in the *De institutione musica*. The topic still requires thorough study.

Marius Victorinus, however, even with his shortcomings was an exception in the Latin Platonism of the fourth century. His contemporary, Calcidius, who dedicated an ample commentary to Plato's *Timaeus*, which in many ways is a work of considerable cultural significance, taking care to provide a broader knowledge of the *Timaeus* in the Latin West, is not interested in logic: in his commentary only sporadic mentions of the doctrine of the categories are encountered, which in a Platonic environment was the best known of Aristotle's teachings on logic (c. 226; 319; 336).

The position of Martianus Capella, who devoted an entire book, the fourth of his *Nuptiae*, to logic (or dialectic, as he calls it), is ambiguous. The logic of the *Nuptiae* has not been studied in depth recently. In principle, his position

48 The *De interpretatione* attributed to Apuleius is, in my opinion, spurious, and was composed in the times and in the environment of Marius Victorinus; see Moreschini, Apuleius and the 'Metamorphoses' of Platonism, forthcoming.

49 Adamo (1967).

50 In fact, his theories have been accepted by Obertello (1974), 548–50 and the most eminent scholar of Marius Victorinus, P. Hadot, who substantially admits the weakness, on the logical level, of Victorinus' translation of Porphyry's *Isagoge* (cf. P. Hadot (1971), 182 and 184–5).

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may be perceived as being similar to that of Marius Victorinus, inasmuch as he considers logic primarily from a rhetorical point of view. Logic, moreover, is positioned within a work that is divided into the seven liberal arts: it is evident, therefore, that it is located purely within an educational framework. The most genuine Platonic tradition, dating back to the times of Xenocrates,[51] placed logic, as we mentioned, in a tripartite division of philosophy that included physics and ethics, while Martianus Capella situates it in a tripartite division that will remain the same throughout the Middle Ages, which included also grammar and rhetoric (which came to be called '*trivium*'). In addition, in the introduction to the fourth book discussing dialectic, the author repeats all the common clichés about this science. Dialectic is personified as a young girl in the entourage of Mercury, like the other liberal arts. She possesses a sharp mind, but brings snakes with her in whose coils the incautious reader could be enveloped (IV 328 – 9): here the allusion to sophistry and specious questions, that were usually considered characteristics of this art, is evident.

Boethius' attitude, therefore, deviates significantly from that of his predecessors and represents a broadening of the horizon of enormous magnitude. This was made possible because Boethius followed Neoplatonism: many Neoplatonic philosophers were also commentators of Aristotelian logic, and Boethius might have been induced by them to treat this topic extensively and to translate Aristotelian Logic into Latin. His interest in logic is extended to the *De consolatione Philosophiae.*

While it is true that Boethius was unable to complete his program of an entire translation of the works of Plato and Aristotle, what he was able to accomplish – some commentaries and some translations from Aristotle's *Organon* – was of inestimable value for the knowledge of Aristotle in the Middle Ages. Such a program was new. If Plato was partly known, however imperfectly (almost exclusively the *Timaeus* and what Cicero had read of Plato a few centuries earlier), it is necessary to emphasize that in Latin culture, Aristotle was known almost exclusively for his exoteric writings.

The Neo-Platonist Porphyry, who wrote an *Isagoge to the Categories*, was crucial for this enrichment of Latin culture, as for other ways of diffusion of Greek philosophy in the West. We must also consider that Aristotle was certainly studied at the school of Plotinus, as Porphyry informs us (*Life of Plotinus*, c. 14). Besides the already mentioned *Isagoge*, Porphyry wrote also a work *On the Discordances between Plato and Aristotle*, two commentaries on the *Categories*, and one on the *Tractate on Interpretation.* The Latin world, in accordance with its cultural trends, while ignoring Porphyry's more strictly theoretical and scientific works, read with great interest the *Isagoge* which, by providing the introductory instructions on the discipline, could be used as a manual, and therefore had a wide circulation.

Marius Victorinus translated the *Isagoge* and, since he was both a

51 Cf. Xenocrates, fr. 1 Heinze = 82 Isnardi Parente.

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rhetorician and a philosopher, added to his translation other technical works, such as a commentary on the *Tractate on Interpretation*, one on the *Tractate on Invention*, and one on the *Topics of Cicero*. It was mainly Victorinus' merit to plant Aristotelian logic in the Latin philosophical tradition: he connected Aristotle with Cicero, thus prefiguring the attitude of Boethius. However, Boethius criticizes his predecessor not only for his translation of Porphyry, but also for his commentary on Cicero's *Topica*, and proceeds to write a more detailed one. His position towards his predecessor is harshly polemical, but is not always justified. There is no doubt, at any rate, that Victorinus' role was eclipsed by Boethius: during the Middle Ages, in fact, until the rediscovery of Aristotle through Scholasticism, Boethius was regarded as a master of logic, and the entire corpus of his writings on Aristotle had an extremely wide circulation.

Naturally, to summarize the logical works by Boethius in a few words – or few pages – is hardly possible, nor it is possible to present them or illustrate their contents if one is not an expert in that discipline: we must therefore confine ourselves to referring to the research of specialists, and only hinting at the fact that Boethius conceived, around 510 AD, the venture to translate and comment in Latin the works of Aristotle and Plato. He began with translating and commenting those of Aristotle on logic first. It was an endeavor of enormous scope, which could not be completed both for its dimension, which would probably have crushed anyone, and because Boethius met with his violent death, to which he had been condemned by Theoderic. There is a great need for an examination of the rhetorical elaboration of the logical works, which scholarship continues to neglect entirely.

Boethius declares in detail his cultural commitment in the prologue to the second book of the second commentary on Aristotle's *De Interpretatione*. Here he sets out to delineate the cultural path of the classical *paideia*, which had long become traditional: from rhetoric the educated man, or from logic the true philosopher, proceeds to the philosophy of nature, whose most important discipline, thanks to the influence of Platonism, had become metaphysics. Boethius resumes this path, certainly not slavishly, but with a personal contribution renewing from within the contents of a project commonly accepted in the sixth century. It is remarkable that, during those years of his greater commitment in public office, when he was thus exposed to continuous distractions (also culturally: it suffices to recall his constant, substantial interest in theological themes), Boethius was able to dedicate himself to his great project. Here is the famous text to which we refer:

In quantum labor humanum genus excolit et beatissimis ingenii fructibus complet, si tantum cura exercendae mentis insisteret, non tam raris hominum virtutibus uteremur: sed ubi desidia demittit animos, continuo feralibus seminariis animi uber horrescit. Nec hoc cognitione laboris evenire concesserim, sed potius ignorantia. quis enim laborandi peritus umquam labore discessit? quare intendenda vis mentis est

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verumque est amitti animum, si remittitur. mihi autem si potentior divinitatis adnuerit favor, haec fixa sententia est, ut quamquam fuerint praeclara ingenia, quorum labor ac studium multa de his quae nunc quoque tractamus Latinae linguae contulerit, non tamen quendam quodammodo ordinem filumque et dispositione disciplinarum gradus ediderunt, ego omne Aristotelis opus, quodcumque in manus venerit, in Romanum stilum vertens eorum omnium commenta Latina oratione perscribam, ut si quid ex logicae artis subtilitate, ex moralis gravitate peritiae, ex naturalis acumine veritatis ab Aristotele conscriptum sit, id omne ordinatum transferam atque etiam quodam lumine commentationis inlustrem omnesque Platonis dialogos vertendo vel etiam commentando in Latinam redigam formam. Iis peractis non equidem contempserim Aristotelis Platonisque sententias in unam quodammodo revocare concordiam eosque non ut plerique dissentire in omnibus, sed in plerisque et his in philosophia maximis consentire demonstrem. haec, si vita otiumque suppetit, cum multa operis huius utilitate nec non etiam labore contenderim, qua in re faveant oportet quos nulla coquit invidia (Commentarii in librum Aristotelis Περὶ ἑρμηνείας *pars posterior*, 79,1 – 80,8, Meiser).[52]

1.3 The theological treatises

During the years he composed the logical works Boethius had occasion to discuss some questions regarding the Christian faith. He presented his interpretations in the *Opuscula theologica*, which he wrote in various

52 "If our care in exercising the mind proceeded at the same pace as that which our labour cultivates and, with the most blessed fruits of its ingenuity, perfects mankind, then our enjoyment of human virtue would not be such a rare occurrence. Once idleness slackens the mind, however, its fertile soil immediately bristles at the ruinous sowing of seed, and I am not prepared to concede that the latter phenomenon results from our cognizance of the labour involved, but rather [that it results] from our ignorance of it. For who has ever turned away from labour after having had some experience of it? And so it is necessary for us to strain our mental powers, and the saying is true: the mind once slackened proves lacking. Assuming divine favour nods in my direction, this is my confirmed plan: although there have been distinguished talents whose studious labour has conferred much upon the Latin language in connection with the subjects which I too am now in the course of treating, nevertheless they have not produced an ordered filament, as it were, or graduated disposition of the disciplines: I will compose commentaries in Latin on every work of Aristotle that comes into my hands while translating them into the Roman style, so that everything stemming from the subtlety of his logical art, from the gravity of his moral understanding, from his insight into the truths of nature—so that I will translate all of it in due order and shine the light of commentary upon it. And I will give Latin form to all of Plato's dialogues by translating and commenting on them as well. Once these tasks have been completed, I will hasten to restore a unified harmony, as it were, to the views of Plato and Aristotle, demonstrating that they, unlike most philosophers, do not disagree on all points but in fact agree on most, the philosophically most important ones included. All of this, assuming life and leisure allow. Given the enormous utility of the undertaking, I will set myself to it despite the labour involved, and those who are free of feelings of petty jealousy really should prove favourable to the matter" (trans. Magee).

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moments and on different occasions, and which were compiled into one corpus during the Carolingian age. After composing an early treatise (ca. 510 AD?) dedicated to the exposition of the Christian faith (the so-called *De fide catholica*, treatise IV in modern editions), in the *Contra Eutychen et Nestorium* (number V, ca. 513 AD) he proposed a solution to controversies in Christology dividing Rome and Constantinople, then he discussed Trinitarian theology, taking his stance when the question arose after the arrival of the so-called 'Scythian monks' in Rome (ca. 520 AD). For that occasion he wrote first the *Utrum Pater et Filius et Spiritus Sanctus de divinitate substantialiter praedicentur* and the *De sancta Trinitate* (nn. II and I). It is possible that both were preceded by the third treatise, the so-called *De Hebdomadibus*, which at first sight appears to have nothing to do with the Scythian controversy.

The *opuscula theologica* constitute (with the exception of the *de fide catholica*) a series of meditative studies and personal speculations. This attitude is void of rhetorical effect or pedagogical motivation, but rather characterized by an esoteric attitude. The first treatise (n. V), the *Contra Eutychen et Nestorium*, is properly discriminatory: its prologue depicts a tumultuous scene in which many authoritative people are present, but all are incompetent regarding the issues under discussion. Boethius intends to separate himself from them and keep to himself. We must not believe that he is concerned with the divulgation of the accessibility to the holy mysteries, but rather realize how Boethius seeks their closure through a selective language and reasoning.

The dedication of his first tractate (but last in chronology, the *De sancta Trinitate*) to his father-in-law Symmachus demonstrates that Boethius is writing for an esoteric group (*praef.* 5 – 15, yet the whole preface should be considered for this topic):

Qua in re quid mihi sit animi quotiens stilo cogitata commendo, cum ex ipsa materiae difficultate tum ex eo quod raris, id est vobis tantum, conloquor, intellegi potest. Neque enim famae iactatione et inani vulgi clamoribus excitamur, sed, si quis est fructus exterior, hic non potest aliam nisi materiae similem sperare sententiam. Quocumque igitur a vobis deieci oculos, partim ignava segnities partim callidus livor occurrit, ut contumeliam videatur divinis tractatibus inrogare qui talibus hominum monstris non agnoscenda haec potius quam proculcanda proiecerit.[53]

53 "You can readily understand what I feel in this matter whenever I try to write down what I think both from the actual difficulty of the topic and from the fact that I discuss it only with the few – I may say with no one but yourself. It is indeed no vain striving after fame or empty popular applause that prompts me; but if there be any external reward, we may not look for more warmth in the verdict than the subject itself arouses. So, apart from yourself, wherever I turn my eyes, they fall on either the apathy of the dullard or the jealousy of the shrewd, and a man who should cast his thoughts before such unnatural creatures of men, I will not say to consider but rather to trample under foot, would seem to bring discredit on the study of divinity."

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The second tractate (*Utrum Pater et Filius et Spiritus sanctus de divinitate substantialiter praedicentur*) is dedicated to John the Deacon, a veritable expert in the topic, and is as technical as the first, completely founded on Augustine's Trinitarian theology.

The same may be said about the so-called *De hebdomadibus*. The *Hebdomad* (whose meaning, under its full title "*Quomodo substantiae in eo quod sint bonae sint cum non sint substantialia bona*,"[54] will be discussed later) could only be understood by those who were initiated to theology and philosophy. Boethius reminds the person to whom he is speaking of the duty of being worthy of such a doctrine, namely of being the privileged addressee of the profoundest secrets of theology (186,7 – 187,14):

Hebdomadas vero ego mihi ipse commentor potiusque ad memoriam meam speculata conservo quam cuiquam participo, quorum lascivia ac petulantia nihil a ioco risuque patitur esse seiunctum. Prohinc tu ne sis obscuritatibus brevitatis adversus, quae cum sint arcani fida custodia tum id habent commodi, quod cum his solis qui digni sunt conloquuntur.[55]

This problem of Boethius' esotericism has been discussed in full by Alain Galonnier.[56] That this was intentional was already noticed in the Middle Ages, for instance by Gilbertus Porretanus. Such an attitude of scorn against 'unprofessional' scholars is connected with a typically scholastic method which appears in Boethius for the first time in Christian literature. Boethius was dubbed "the first of the Scholastics:" the designation fits not only his tracts on logic, but also the *Opuscula theologica* (I – III and V). For good reasons, Daley investigated if an analogous scholastic method had been employed in the East (mainly for Christological questions) and pointed out the analogies between Boethius and Neo-Chalcedonian theologians. Yet he admitted, first, that direct analogies cannot be found, since the Greek theologians are all later than Boethius, and, second, that the sources Boethius used are not the Neo-Platonists, but Augustine.[57]

Taken as a whole, the *opuscula theologica* treat theological issues using a purely philosophical method, but do not make philosophy an *ancilla*

54 "How substances are good in virtue of their existence without being substantial goods."

55 "But I think over my *Hebdomads* with myself, and I keep my speculations in my own memory rather than share them with any of those pert and frivolous persons who will not tolerate an argument unless it is made amusing. Wherefore do not you take objection to obscurities consequent on brevity, which are the sure treasure-house of secret doctrine and have the advantage that they speak only with those who are worthy."

56 Boèce, Galonnier (2007), 135 – 47, who gives the exact reference on p. 145: Gisleberti Pictavensis Episcopi, *Expositio in Boecii librum primum de Trinitate*, prologus 4 – 6 (ed. N.M. Häring, Toronto 1966, pp. 53,20 – 54,32). See also Daley (1984), 158 – 91, at 188 – 9.

57 Daley (1984), 163 – 6 (for the scholastic method) and 178 (for the chronology). That Boethius did not follow Neo-Platonism in his *Opuscula theologica* is not true.

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theologiae. The postulate: "*fidem, si poteris, rationemque coniunge*," so fitting for Boethius, a Christian in toga, reaches here its culmination.[58]

1.4. Boethius' legacy: Cassiodorus

Boethius' cultural project failed to gain recognition by his contemporaries. Most likely he was better known by the Roman milieu as a consul and a *magister officiorum* at the court of Theoderic, that is, by his political activities, than as a philosopher or a theologian. Ennodius and Maximianus knew him personally, but they were too unsophisticated to understand his cultural relevance. Although Ennodius was a bishop, he really had little to teach to his flock during the Christological and Scythian controversies.

Cassiodorus was not on the same humble cultural level. He was a conspicuous civil servant of Theoderic, and his political career, although faithful to the Gothic king and yielding to the political powers of the moment, underwent an evolution, ending in a moral crisis which led to the foundation of the monastery at Vivarium. Yet not even Cassiodorus appears to have appreciated the significance of Boethius' philosophy or theology.

As a faithful officer of Theoderic, Cassiodorus wrote many letters in his name, which were later collected and published (the so-called *Variae*). Theoderic was entirely illiterate according to the *Anonymus Valesianus:*

Rex Theodoricus inlitteratus erat et sic obruto sensu ut in decem annos regni sui quattuor litteras subscriptionis edicti sui discere nullatenus potuisset. De qua re laminam auream iussit interrasilem fieri quattuor litteras 'legi' habentem, unde subscribere voluisset, posita lamina super charta, et per eam penna ducebat, ut subscriptio eius tantum videretur (ch. 79).[59]

Given Cassiodorus' rhetorical education, his letters usually contain variations, inspired by the problems he had to address, even though they may have little to do with the topic of the respective letter. For instance, the *Varia* I 10, concerning the emoluments that should be paid to "*domestici equitum et peditum*" at Theoderic's royal palace. These servants had been paid, as it appears, with coins of inferior value, so they complained. Consequently, the letter of Cassiodorus includes a long disquisition on money and the value of

58 On the *opuscula theologica* see Obertello (1974), 252 – 85; Chadwick (1981), 174 – 222; Marenbon (2003), 66 – 95; Bradshaw (2009), 105 – 128.

59 "King Theoderic was so illiterate and stupid that until the tenth year of his reign he could not learn to write the four letters which were necessary for signing his edicts. For this reason he ordered a stencilled golden sheet to be prepared for him containing the four letters '*legi*'; where he wanted to sign, he would put the sheet on the paper, and draw the pen through it, so that the signature only appeared to be his."

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number, which symbolizes it: discussing numbers is justified by Boethius' scientific knowledge of them, testified by the *Institutio arithmetica*.

The *Varia* I 45 was written on the occasion of a political occurrence: the king of the Burgundians, with whom Theoderic desired to be on good terms, had asked the king of the Goths for a water clock. Amidst the stilted lucubrations on the clock, the sun, and the mechanisms that moved the clock, Cassiodorus lingers on the philosophical activity exercized by Boethius thus far: that activity would certainly also enable Boethius to deal with the clock.

When the king of the Franks, attracted by the reputation of Theoderic's banquets, asked him to send him a citharist, Cassiodorus addressed Boethius (*Varia* I 40) since he knew he was a music expert, due to his *De institutione musica*.

As we can see, the praise for Boethius' works is certainly profuse, but insubstantial, and some scholars also consider it to be false: most likely Cassiodorus never read Boethius' works, neither when writing the *Variae* nor when composing the *Institutiones*.

Cassiodorus' admiration for the philosopher was certainly put to a severe trial when Theoderic condemned Boethius to death and the vacant position of *magister officiorum* was given to Cassiodorus himself.[60] It is not difficult to draw the conclusion that Cassiodorus had foreseen Boethius' fall and broken off all relations with him, maintaining fidelity to the dynasty of Theoderic.

Cassiodorus retained his pro-Gothic position up to the final days of the Gothic reign, but after the victory of the Byzantines, he attempted to secure the friendship of Boethius' family. For this reason, after retiring to Vivarium, at the very end of his life he presents a list of works by Boethius and his predecessors, which he had copied for the library of the monastery (*Institutiones* III 3,18). In this list he mentions Marius Victorinus' and Boethius' commentaries on Porphyry's *Isagoge* and on the *Perihermeneias* – but neither the *Opuscula theologica* nor the *Consolatio*.

It corresponds to Cassiororus' newly-revived interest in Boethius that at the end of his life, when composing the *Institutiones*, he explains the arts of the *quadrivium* and their significance according to Boethius *Institutio arithmetica* and *Institutio musica*.[61]

Fabio Troncarelli proposes to attribute to Cassiodorus the 'first edition' of the *Consolatio*, basing his argument on the fact that some of the marginal notes to the text found in some manuscripts show such a command of late antique culture as is unlikely to have been possessed by anyone other than Cassiodorus. Furthermore, some of the concepts presented in these notes

60 Chadwick (1981), 253.

61 Cf. I. Hadot (^{2}2005), 193 – 205. For instance, the definition of the *disciplinae liberales* as sciences which are not subject to change is also proposed by Cassiodorus (*Instit.*, p. 131,14 ss. Mynors) following Boethius *Instit. Arithm.* I 1,1 (see above, p. 15).

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are only found in Cassiodorus' works.[62] This supposed edition includes, at the beginning, a *Vita Boethii*,[63] which also features the figure of Symmachus and contains information about Boethius' life and works; it supplies various details about Theoderic and the most illustrious men of the Gothic age, which coincide with those of contemporary sources. Whoever wrote this rhetorical commentary on the *Consolatio* employs, according to Troncarelli, terminology derived from Cassiodorus. This most ancient commentator of the *Consolatio*, with his modest display of rhetoric, is able to tune in to the text: he extracts from it its 'pathetic' dimension, emphasizes the emotional facet, and the religious fervor. If this commentator is indeed Cassiodorus, as Troncarelli asserts, then certainly his attention to Boethius' suffering and tragic death is neither biased nor superficial.[64]

From Cassiodorus the so-called *Anecdoton Holderi* ("an unpublished work") also derives. It was discovered by the director of the Library of Karlsruhe, A. Holder, and immediately published in 1877 by his friend Hermann Usener. It is found at the end (fol. 53v) of ms. Augiensis CVI (first half of the ninth century), one of the most important in the manuscript tradition of the Boethian *Opuscula theologica.* The *Anecdoton* consists of excerpts from a *libellus* sent by Cassiodorus to a famous senator, Cetegus. Cetegus had fled to Constantinople together with other Roman senators from Theoderic's persecution of certain eminent Romans citizens. These excerpts include certain biographical and bibliographical information on Symmachus, Boethius, and Cassiodorus himself. We shall discuss it later, when reconsidering the importance of the *Anecdoton* for the *Opuscula theologica* and for Boethius' own Christian faith.[65] After speaking of Boethius' father-in-law, Symmachus, the excerptor introduces some lines on Boethius and Cassiodorus:

Excerpta ex libello[66] *Cassiodori Senatoris monachi servi dei ex patricio et consule ordinario, quaestore et magistro officiorum, quem scripsit ad Rufinum Petronium Nicomachum*[67] *ex consule ordinario patricium et magistrum officiorum.*[68]

The first illustrious man mentioned by the *Anecdoton* is Symmachus, Boethius' father-in-law: he is called 'philosopher' and imitator of the ancient

62 Troncarelli (1988b), 501 – 50, more recently (2012), 88 – 97 (with bibliography).

63 Troncarelli published this Vita, which is preserved in various ancient manuscripts of the *Consolatio.*

64 Troncarelli (1988b), 525 – 6.

65 Troncarelli (1988b), 512 – 5.

66 This is the common name (in the sixth century) for *epistula*, Troncarelli notes.

67 These were the *nomina* of Cetegus. The titles of the magistracies have been questioned by modern historians, but we will not discuss this issue here. See, *inter alios* and with bibliography, Momigliano (1978), 494 – 504, at 495, Galonnier (1997), 58 – 73.

68 "Excerpts from the letter sent by Cassiodorus the monk, God's servant, ex-patrician and ex-ordinary consul, quaestor and *magister officiorum*, to Rufinus Petronius Nicomachus, ex-ordinary consul, patrician and *magister officiorum.*"

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Cato, but, it is written, Symmachus surpassed the virtues of the ancient Romans thanks to his *sanctissima religio*. Then the *Anecdoton* introduces Boethius:

Boethius dignitatibus summis excelluit, utraque lingua peritissimus orator fuit. qui regem Theodericum in senatu pro consulatu filiorum luculenta oratione laudavit. scripsit librum de sancta trinitate et capita quaedam dogmatica et librum contra Nestorium. condidit et carmen bucolicum. sed in opere artis logicae, id est dialecticae, transferendo ac mathematicis disciplinis talis fuit, ut antiquos auctores aut aequiperaret aut vinceret.[69]

We notice that, just as in Cassiodorus' *Institutiones*, Boethius is extolled principally for his works on logic; new – and it is a notice of first rank – the *Anecdoton* mentions the *Opuscula theologica*, but it does not mention the *Consolatio philosophiae*. Then follows the information regarding Cassiodorus himself, who (not with great legitimacy) desired to be considered a member of Symmachus' family.

The *Anecdoton* has a particular significance, according to Troncarelli it is:

an extract, which is in the appendix of the *Institutiones* [scl. of Cassiodorus] […] it is, in all likelihood, an extract prepared at Vivarium. The *Anecdoton* is of a very particular nature: Cassiodorus, who had just recently been a minister of the Gothic monarchs, even during the harsh and more restrictive phase against the Latin nobility […], highlights with liveliness his kinship with Boethius and Symmachus, who were the symbol of the very Roman tradition offended by the barbarians. It is not by chance that the addressee of the libellus is the leader of Latin aristocracy, that Cetegus who spiritually leads in Constantinople the exiles of the tragedy of the Gothic war. How can a text of this kind circulate outside the milieu of Cassiodorus and Cetegus, how can it have been written by an 'anonymous redactor'?

The reason is that

with that text, Cassiodorus tried to be rehabilitated towards those Romans who had been persecuted by the Goths, and maintain a relationship with the members of the circle of Boethius and Symmachus: with good reason we find him at the side of Cetegus with the order to sedate the Latin opposition to the Three Chapters.[70]

In the *Vita Boethii* the Cassiodorian *Anecdoton* is quoted precisely word by word.[71]

69 "Boethius excelled in the highest dignities and was particularly skillful both in Greek and Latin. He extolled King Theoderic delivering an eloquent oration in the Senate for the consulate of his sons. He wrote a book on the Holy Trinity, some chapters on the Christian faith and a book against Nestorius. He composed also a bucolic poem. But in his works of translation of logic, that is dialectic, he reached such an excellence as to be of the same or of a greater worth than the ancients."

70 Momigliano, (1978), 498 – 9.

71 Troncarelli (1988b), 514.

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But there is also another reason for underlining the importance of the *Anecdoton.* The *Opuscula theologica*, we recall, had not been mentioned by Cassiodorus' *Variae* among Boethius' works: they became important and frequently quoted and employed by the greatest philosophers and theologians of the ninth century, not earlier.[72] This appeared suspect in the past, when the dispute over Boethius' Christianity was a problem intensely and frequently discussed: the *Opuscula theologica* were considered to have been composed (and attributed to Boethius) in the Carolingian age, in order to give an authoritative voice to the religious discussions of those times. Now, the *Anecdoton* offers exactly what was previously missing: the testimony of a contemporary of Boethius, namely Cassiodorus, about the authenticity of the *Opuscula theologica:* they were not a forgery of the Carolingian age, but the work of Boethius. Therefore, those who doubted Boethius' Christianity and argued only on the basis of his works on logic and on the *Consolatio* to assert that Boethius had been a Neo-Platonist but not a Christian were forced to find a solution to the difficulty the *Anecdoton* represented.

Recently, the significance of the *Anecdoton* has been questioned in a thorough investigation by Alain Galonnier.[73] He re-examined the history of the interpretations of the *Anecdoton*, from its discovery and publication by Hermann Usener: at first, that is until the end of the nineteenth century, the reactions of critics to the notices contained in the *Anecdoton* were mostly sceptical, due also to the fact that the judgment of the non-authenticity of the *Opuscula sacra* coincided with the prevailing interpretation of Boethius as a layman and a Neo-Platonic philosopher in opposition to the Christian faith. In contrast, from the beginning of the twentieth century the *Anecdoton* was considered by almost all critics to be reliable, a testimony of first rank of the authencity of the *Opuscula sacra* and consequently of Boethius' Christian faith. Such a conviction produced a 'lethargie,'[74] which Galonnier wished to counter — yet he did not arrive at a negative conclusion regarding its authenticity. On the other hand, one of the most enthusiastic assertors of the *Anecdoton*'s value is, as we have seen, Troncarelli, who most recently reasserted his opinion.[75]

Maybe it is a consequence of Galonnier's scepticism about the *Anecdoton* that has led to a completely different assessment of the relations between Boethius and Cassiodorus, formulated by Max Lejbowicz. He asserts, by means of numerous sound observations, that Boethius and Cassiodorus were mutual strangers: first, neither the epistles of the *Variae* nor the *Institutiones* exhibit any real knowledge of Boethius' works, which Cassiodorus quotes with

72 Galonnier (1997), 28 – 29.
73 Galonnier (1997).
74 Galonnier (1997), 73.
75 Troncarelli (2012), 100 – 9. It is curious that the same Troncarelli prefaced Galonnier's work, which substantially proposed an evaluation of the *Anecdoton* contrary to his.

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(apparent) enthusiasm, but in substance only by hearsay; second, Cassiodorus' political stance remained faithful to the Amali dynasty, even after Theoderic's death, changing alliance only after the Byzantine victory; third, the *Anecdoton Holderi*, to which Troncarelli attributed such great importance, is absolutely silent not only about the *Consolatio* (from which Boethius' fame and Theoderic's blame stem), but also about such dramatic events as the condemnation of Symmachus and Boethius himself.[76] We may add, as well, the observation that even the title of the work against Nestorius is incorrect, because the *Anecdoton* neglects to say that it was also written against Eutyches: a proof that 'Cassiodorus' did not really read it.

We wish to propose a different solution that does not deny the authenticity of the *Anecdoton*, but judges its importance to be not as great as some have claimed, both among those who have denied and those who have asserted it. We regard the silence on the *Opuscula theologica*, which was normal among the writers of the seventh and eighth centuries from Isidore of Seville to the Venerable Bede, not to be the consequence of them being considered non-Christian nor a proof of forgery by Carolingian theologians, but merely to reflect a normal fate befalling many classical texts. The so-called 'Carolingian Renaissance' had the beneficial effect of rediscovering many works commonly read until the sixth century, but forgotten and no longer copied in the seventh and eighth centuries due to the overall difficult situation of European culture. This happened to many Latin authors. Boethius suffered the same fate: the *Consolatio*, notwithstanding its edition by Cassiodorus, was almost forgotten only to flourish again in the ninth century: the most ancient manuscripts of the *Consolatio* were written beginning with 820 AD. It is no surprise, then, but rather normal that the *Opuscula* were almost forgotten in the darkness of the early Middle Ages, and rediscovered thanks to the theologians of the Carolingian age.[77] So the *Anecdoton*, in spite of its antiquity, does not possess a cogent strength of demonstration.

Boethius' studies on liberal arts were appreciated in the Middle Ages exactly for those very reasons for which modern historical science considers them works of lesser speculative quality, that is, because they merely represent a compendium of Greek doctrines on mathematics, philosophy, and music. But the Middle Ages did not require Boethius to be 'personal' and 'original;' scholars looked to his works for knowledge that might prove to be useful and scientifically valid. And they found it, so they had high esteem for Boethius. His importance was even greater in the ambit of logic, since via his philosophy he not only transmitted to the following centuries Aristotle's logical works in translation, but also expanded them with rigorous commentaries. In them, the Latin writer had condensed and gathered the scientific experience of his Greek

76 Cf. Lejbowicz (2003), 301 – 39, at 333 – 9.

77 This has been demonstrated with great perspicacity and erudition by the many contributions of d'Onofrio: (1980b), 707 – 52, (1980a), 189 – 200, (1981), 343 – 54, (1986), 45 – 57.

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predecessors, and in this way he provided medieval philosophy, at least until the re-discovery of Aristotle, with the tools for further meditations. In the Middle Ages, many commentaries on Boethius' logical and theological works (the *Consolatio philosophiae* included) were composed: it is, however, beyond the scope of this book to examine these in detail.[78]

According to a *communis opinio*, with the arrival of fifteenth-century Humanism, the polemics against the Middle Ages affected Boethius too, and the lack of interest in his scientific works increased in the ensuing centuries, when philosophy took quite different paths. The medieval commentaries on Boethius appeared to Humanists so boring and heavy, and unconvincing that they felt compelled to interpret Boethius in quite a different way.[79] But this opinion has been too easily and too hastily constructed: certainly it is necessary to re-examine Boethius' *Nachleben* in the Renaissance.

78 The history of Boethius' interpretations in the Middle Ages has been sketched by Courcelle (1967), 240 – 332. Nauta (1997), 41 – 68 provides the problem with a more scientific and thorough interpretation and presents an amusing imaginative portrayal of the supposed behavior of Courcelle scornfully dismissing the commentaries of the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries in Nauta (2003), 767 – 78, at 768. See also Nauta (2009), 255 – 78.

79 The 'dullness' of medieval (thirteenth and fourteenth centuries) commentaries has been underlined, for instance, by Courcelle (1967), 323 – 32.

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2. Philosophy and Theology in Boethius' *Opuscula Theologica*

2.1 The *De fide catholica*

The so-called *Anecdoton Holderi*, which we previously considered above, asserts that Boethius "*scripsit librum de sancta Trinitate*[1] *et capita quaedam dogmatica et librum contra Nestorium.*" This assertion provides the basis for our discussion of the authenticity of *De fide catholica* as well as its subject matter.

2.1.1 Authenticity

It is easy to recognize in the first title of the *Anecdoton* the first opusculum, and in the third title the fifth. It is more uncertain to establish whether the second, third, and fourth tractate are alluded to with the general definition: "*capita quaedam dogmatica.*" Usener, on publishing the *Anecdoton*, supposed that the *capita dogmatica* were the *De fide catholica*, and believed that the opuscula two and three were included in the *Liber de sancta Trinitate.* He considered the *De fide catholica* to be spurious,[2] and believed that it was an addition made in the Carolingian age to the genuine opuscula, since the ms. Augiensis (Karlsruhe, Landesbibliothek 18, saec. IX), copied by Regimbertus of Reichenau, which includes the *Anecdoton*, contains opuscula one, two, and three, and at the end of opusculum three writes: "*actenus Boetius*," and then proceeds with the *De fide catholica.* Evidently, Regimbertus had thought that the *De fide* did not belong to Boethius, and his statement continued to influence a large part of modern scholarship, even though many scholars have doubted that Regimbertus was any better informed than we are on the problem. He simply noticed that the *De fide catholica*, which followed, appeared to him spurious due to its style, which is different from that of opuscula one, two, and three.

Other elements of the manuscript tradition leading scholars to reject the authenticity of the *De fide catholica* are the following: as may already be discerned from Peiper's edition (Leipzig, Teubner 1871), in the most authoritative manuscripts the work normally has no title; the codex Einsiedlensis of the eleventh century (we refer to the observations by Peiper,

1 This notice of the *Anecdoton* agrees with the title of the most authoritative families of manuscripts, and for this reason we have attributed that title to the first opusculum in our edition.

2 Usener, Anecdoton Holderi, 48 – 59, now in the annotated French translation by Galonnier (1997). The German original is not easily found in libraries.

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since we did not use this manuscript in our edition) is the first to give it the title that is usually employed: "*incerti de fide catholica.*" The manuscript S (Bamberg, Staatsbibliothek Q VI 32, Patr. 45) of the ninth to tenth century, bears the inscription "*ista epistola in aliis libris non invenitur.*"

Among the ancient testimonies, only the *altera manus* of the ms. Laurentianus, San Marco 167 (tenth century), which we have indicated with the siglum X, adds the following inscription: "*incipit liber Boethii de fide christiana.*"[3] Finally, Vallinus, who first published the *De fide catholica* in 1656, gave it the title "*Incipit eiusdem (scl. Boethii) brevis fidei christianae complexio.*" Therefore, he considered it to be a genuine work by Boethius, and this opinion was upheld until Usener asserted the opposite. Since the beginning of the twentieth century, the work was attributed more and more often to Boethius, and now the attribution is generally accepted.

One of the most influential critics of Boethius, E.K. Rand, who had initially stated that the work was not genuine,[4] later changed his opinion:[5] he did not explain on which basis he did so, but Troncarelli, having access to the archives of the Academy of Science in Vienna for which Rand was to prepare a new edition of the *Opuscula Theologica* for the *Corpus Scriptorum Ecclesiasticorum Latinorum*, found a draft of Rand's interpretation of the *Anecdoton:* Rand considered the *Anecdoton* reliable and thought that the "*capita quaedam dogmatica*" referred to the *De fide catholica*, (as Usener had stated), but that the *De fide catholica* was genuine. In this, he has been followed by Troncarelli.[6] Later, Obertello first considered *De fide catholica* to be a Boethian work written under the influence of John the Deacon,[7] then simply attributed it to Boethius alone,[8] while both Chadwick and Marenbon are in no doubt that the *De fide catholica* is a genuine work.[9]

Recently, the authenticity of the *De fide catholica* was reconsidered anew by Alain Galonnier. Although he arrives at a conclusion similar to others, it is to his credit to have reintroduced a certain amount of scepticism and critical spirit to a question that seems to have been solved too early.[10] Galonnier's intention is to assume a neutral standpoint, confining himself to selecting four clues that lead one to doubt the authenticity of the *De fide catholica*;[11] after emphasizing them, he tries to explain their inherent difficulties.

3 These are the most authoritative manuscripts of the *De fide catholica.* Other manuscripts, twelfth to fourteenth centuries, are listed by Troncarelli (1988a), 3 – 19, at 16 – 19. Troncarelli is followed by Galonnier (2007), 384 – 5.

4 Rand (1901), 401 – 61.

5 Rand (1928), 156 – 7. He was followed by Bark (1946), 55—69, at 56, Troncarelli (2000), 39 – 86, at 69 – 76.

6 Troncarelli (2000), 68 – 73.

7 Obertello (1974), 281 – 5.

8 Severino Boezio, Obertello/Ribet (1979).

9 Chadwick (1980), 551 – 6, (1981), 174 – 80, Marenbon (2003b), 67 – 68.

10 Boèce, Galonnier (2007), 377 – 409, at 409.

11 Boèce, Galonnier (2007), 384 – 6.

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The first problem is that, as Hildebrand[12] had already stated, the information in the *De fide* on Nestorius is inaccurate (*De fide catholica* 199 – 201: "*Nestorius* […] *hominem solum* [scl. in Christ] […] *putavit asserere*"[13]) and does not agree with what Boethius rightly says in his undoubtedly genuine work on Christology (*Contra Eutychen et Nestorium*[14] 4,272 – 3: "*Hanc* [scl. *Personam*] *in Christo Nestorius duplicem esse constituit*").[15] Chadwick[16] and Micaelli[17] attribute this error to the adopting of what is said in the *Tractatus de duabus naturis* by Pope Gelasius I: "*Eutychiani dicunt unam esse naturam, id est divinam, ac Nestorius nihilominus memorat singularem, id est humanam.*[18]" Galonnier expands this explanation.[19] According to him, it is a question of two formulas that had become 'classical,' and had possibly been simplified according to the purpose of each writer (Gelasius and Boethius), to strike the sensitivity of the followers of Chalcedon in Rome, who would have grasped in this way the absurdity of the Christology of the two heretics, Eutyches and Nestorius. In such a case, the search for this effect would have required the necessity to sacrifice a more rigorous interpretation. Galonnier, in fact, observes that, in order to explain the two definitions concerning Nestorius and Eutyches, it is not necessary to have recourse to Nestorius' works but rather to the Latin tradition of his thought. In the two opuscula Boethius reacts by using the polemical writings, the acts of the Council of Ephesus, and the translations given in the Latin, in the CEN on the one hand, and the Roman (i. e. Western) tradition in the *De fide* on the other hand. Therefore, the *De fide* and the *Contra Eutychen* are two different approaches to one single problem:[20] in the CEN, Boethius depends on the interpretation proposed by Cyril of Alexandria, which was the most widespread and repeated, whereas in the *De fide* he may have depended on Cassian, who had written the *Contra Nestorium* for Pope Celestine I.

Another problem is that of the assertion of the procession of the Holy Spirit, which seems to be incorrect (*De fide catholica* 23 – 4): "*sanctum vero Spiritum neque Patrem esse neque Filium* […] *sed a Patre quoque procedentem* vel *Filio.*[21]" But in Late Antiquity, *vel* can also mean *et*, and Micaelli finds other evidence of this use.[22] More subtly (but perhaps less convincingly), Galonnier

12 Cf. Hildebrand (1885). We did not read this work, but repeat Galonnier's account of it.
13 "Nestorius thought fit to say that Christ was only man." Here I modify the translation of Tester.
14 Henceforth, the work will be quoted as 'CEN.'
15 "Nestorius affirmed that in Christ person was twofold."
16 Chadwick, (1981), 183.
17 Micaelli (1988), 21.
18 "The Eutychians assert that in Christ there is only one nature, viz. the divine one, while Nestorius speaks of a singular nature of Christ, that is, the human one."
19 Boèce, Galonnier (2007), 391 – 401.
20 Boèce, Galonnier (2007), 399 – 400.
21 "But the Holy Spirit is neither Father nor Son […] but proceeding as well from the Father as the Son."
22 Micaelli (1988), 13 – 14.

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asserts that Boethius means that the Spirit essentially proceeds from the Father, just like the Son is generated by the Father, and proceeds from the Son in the second place (*vel*), because everything comes from the Father, including the Son. This is in accordance with the formula of the procession of the Spirit ("*cogitemus processisse ex utrisque Spiritum Sanctum*") found in Boethius' *De sancta Trinitate* (5, 322 – 3[23]). If Obertello observed that Augustine's Trinitarian doctrine had not yet prevailed definitively,[24] according to Galonnier, "plus que la manque de fidélité envers Augustin, c'est cette distortion entre le DF et le DT[25] qui peut amener à douter que le premier soit bien de la main de Boèce."[26] Ultimately, Galonnier arrives at the same conclusion others have: the *De fide catholica* is a genuine work by Boethius.

Once the genuineness of the opusculum has been acknowledged, it remains to be examinded if the plural *capita* also indicates treatises two and three. Usener himself, considering the non-logic but catechetic character of the *De fide catholica* thought that it was independent not only from one and five (which is clear), but also from two and three, which he considered an 'appendix' to one (*De sancta Trinitate*).[27] In fact, the *De fide catholica* does not have the character of a scientific text, which is typical of the other opuscula, but proceeds in a dogmatic form, that is by expounding the doctrines of the Church of Rome. The *capita dogmatica* contained in the *De fide catholica* are *articula fidei*, although not presented in a systematic connection, but taken from salvation history.[28] We concur with Rand's and Troncarelli's interpretation, although Galonnier argues the opposite, publishing a first volume under the title "*capita dogmatica*," containing treatises two, three, and four, and a second volume, containing treatises one and five (*De sancta Trinitate* and *De duabus naturis*, i. e. *Contra Eutychen et Nestorium*). As Rand observed,[29] if Cassiodorus asserts that Boethius wrote *capitula quaedam* this means that the manuscript he consulted had no title, and this corresponds exactly to the situation of the *De fide catholica*.[30]

23 "Let us consider that God the Son proceeded from God the Father, and the Holy Ghost from both."

24 Obertello (1974), 281, n. 122.

25 That is, Boethius' *De fide catholica* and Augustine's *De Trinitate*.

26 Boèce, Galonnier (2007), 403 – 4, 409.

27 Cf. also Bark (who appears to be somehow uncertain) (1946), 59, Troncarelli (2000), 74.

28 Cf. Leonardi (1969), 142 – 9, at 146, Chadwick (1981), 180.

29 Troncarelli (2000), 72 – 73.

30 One title might be that discovered by Troncarelli in a manuscript of the Bibliotheca Apostolica Vaticana (saec. X – XI), which he attributes to the *De fide catholica*.

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2.1.2 The doctrines

In this work, Boethius summarizes the theology of Augustine. Rand already identified many details from Augustine's *De civitate Dei* and *Enchiridion* (which, however, neither Chadwick nor Galonnier mention).[31] Some of these Augustinian doctrines are:[32] World and time were created together (*Civ. Dei* XI 6). The rebellion of the angels is connected with the creation of man: after the fall of the rebellious angels, God did not want their number to decrease and therefore created man and placed him in Paradise. If man had not fallen, he would have been able to replace the number of the rebellious angels. This is a theory proposed by Augustine in the *Enchiridion* (a work that, like the *De fide catholica*, explained the Christian faith as the history of salvation: cf. 28 – 29 and 62) and in *Civ. Dei* XIV 26; as a consequence, the creation of man occurred after the precosmic fall of the angels. In addition, in this work Boethius seems to accept the idea of the *creatio ex nihilo* (*De fide catholica* 54 – 55), which he rejects in both the *De instit. arithm.* (I II 3, p. 11: "*neque* […] *ex non subsistentibus effici quicquam potest*")[33] and the *Consolatio* (V 1,9):

nam nihil ex nihilo existere vera sententia est, cui nemo umquam veterum refragatus est; quamquam id illi non de operante principio sed de materiali subiecto hoc omnium de natura rationum quasi quoddam iecerint fundamentum[34].

This might be explained with Obertello's hypothesis, according to which Boethius might have attempted to organize in written form the teaching received from John the Deacon,[35] while Bark (with some simplicity) claims that there are no contradictions between the two interpretations.[36] The *processus in infinitum*, which is mentioned and criticized in *De fide catholica* 16 – 21, is confirmed elsewhere in several passages by Boethius (*Isag.*, *In categ.*, *In perihermeneias* II *comm.* II 4, p. 83,5 – 9, Meiser). This process is also found in Augustine, *Contra Maximinum* II 12,3, as Micaelli[37] notes.[38]

31 Cf. Rand (1901), 422 – 24.

32 I have omitted, however, some parallels which appear to me to be quite generic. For an exhaustive discussion of the 'Augustinianism' of the *de fide catholica*, see also Obertello (1974), 270 – 75; Chadwick (1981), 177 – 79.

33 "Nothing can be created out of non-being."

34 "For that nothing comes from nothing is a true opinion, which none of the ancients ever contested, but they laid it as it were as a foundation of all arguments about nature, though they applied it not to the creative principle but to the material subject of it."

35 Cf. Obertello (1974), 281 – 85.

36 Cf. Bark (1946), 59, n. 21. Obertello, too, supposes (in a rather convoluted explanation) that there is no contradiction between the *creatio ex nihilo* of the *De fide catholica* and the assertion of the *Consolatio.* See Obertello (1981), 161 – 62, followed by Micaelli (1988), 20.

37 Micaelli (1988), 12 – 13.

38 Of course, similarities between Augustine and *De fide catholica* deserve to be mentioned, not

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2.1.3 The purpose

The *De fide catholica* is, as we have shown, different from the other opuscula and this requires explanation. According to Chadwick,[39] Christianity in the *De fide catholica* is a revealed religion built around a particular sacred history with certain precise doctrines, which it is heretical to transgress. Little space is left for philosophy: Boethius might have 'compartmentalized' his intellectual activity, accepting the doctrines of Christian faith while at the same time proceeding in his philosophical speculations independently from them. But Boethius believes that it is possible for faith to be in relationship with philosophy. In *Contra Eutychen et Nestorium*[40] he shows how Aristotelian logic and physics, if accurately applied, can demonstrate how inconsistent heretical Christology is and explain orthodox doctrine. In the first two tractates he shows that the application of Aristotelian logic to God is valid, although only to a certain extent, there being a radical difference between God and created things.

The absolute absence in the *De fide catholica* of allusions to logical and philosophical issues cannot be accidental. Boethius is not interested in underlining the rational character of Christian faith, nor in including philosophy in his discussion. His tractate almost looks like 'a gage of challenge' to the learned and aristocratic reader of Late Antiquity: it strongly insists, almost with a defying tone, on the supernatural and distinctive elements of orthodox Christianity.[41] This aspect may be an important clue for identifying Boethius' intentions in composing this tractate. Boethius wants to show the discrepancy rather than the harmony between faith and reason. The central issue of the tractate is, therefore, the fact that Christian faith is presented in the form of salvation history. Even though it is not a work of logical character, the *De fide catholica* finds its position among the opuscula because it is a typically Christian work, appearing as a vibrant profession of Christian faith. In addition, the statements of dogmatic character do not differ from those of the other tractates, while its lexicon and its circumlocutions accord with other definitely authentic works.[42]

We cannot concur with such an interpretation, since it contradicts what Boethius explicitly asserts elsewhere: "*fidem, si potes, rationemque coniunge*" (*Utrum Pater et Filius*, 185,67). Why should he have followed such a different method? Did he change his views after the *De fide catholica?* If it was

differences: for instance, Boethius does not mention Purgatory, in spite of Augustine's hints, but we cannot construct an argument around this.

39 Chadwick (1981), 179 – 80.

40 Marenbon too believes that the *De fide* is genuine and is the first tractate. In our opinion, it is difficult to maintain its authenticity if it is not placed at an early period of Boethius' activity.

41 Chadwick (1981), 179.

42 So far Chadwick's interpretation, cf. (1981), 179 – 80.

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composed at the beginning of Boethius' career, it is contemporary to *De institutione arithmetica* and *De musica*, which are at once quite 'logical' and 'religious.'[43]

It is more probable that *De fide catholica* was Boethius' very first tractate, and that he wrote it to embed in his mind what John the Deacon had taught him in his catechism.[44] That it is indeed by Boethius is testified by the care used in composing it,[45] since it was destined for publication. Being his first tract, what could have been Boethius' objective in writing it? Barks' interpretation was that *De fide catholica* was a guide for the Western layman, who was confused by the difficult questions posed by Oriental theologians:[46] "If so, Boethius wrote it for himself," Chadwick observes[47] – in my opinion not very perspicuously. Galonnier, in contrast, accepts *De fide* being a sketch of the doctrinal program Boethius himself had developed, namely that of placing Plato and Aristotle at the service of Catholic faith. Boethius might have attempted to inaugurate the method he would develop later in the other opuscula, which consists of taking the assertions of faith as supports for a philosophical reflection. Although still in a tentative form, this attempt surfaces here and there. It seems that Boethius is trying to clarify the main aspects of Christian doctrine he had recently assimilated during his catechesis received as an adult, and now hastens to impress them on his mind.[48] In any case, no contrast between *fides* and *ratio* can be detected here, but only the uncertain progression of the beginner.

As a conclusion, the *De fide* might be the first of the *Opuscula sacra*, the work of a still quite young Boethius, who tries to approach Christian doctrine in a catechetic tone, clear, yet by no means unphilosophical or contrary to philosophy. The unsatisfactory nature of some explanations, such as the label applied with great simplicity to Eutyches and Nestorius, and the tendency to accept without hesitation the doctrine of the *creatio ex nihilo*, which by the sixth century had long been accepted doctrine in the Church, reveal this initial phase in the studies of Boethius. The prudence and modesty displayed there (24 – 5) do not appear in the other tractates: note, for instance, the ease with which the writer, a few years later (CEN 4,265 – 8), grants the Church the liberty of choosing terms that seem useful to it, even though they are imprecise. Also, Axel Tisserand considers the *De fide catholica* to be an "ouvrage d'initiation

43 See also Troncarelli (2000), 67.

44 Cf. Chadwick (1981), 180.

45 It is impossible, in my opinion, to ascertain the authenticity of the *de fide catholica* on the basis of peculiarities of style, which it shares with the surely authentic works. Chadwick (1980, 555 – 6) thought he may have identified some such peculiarities, but they are of no great significance.

46 Bark (1946), 68.

47 Chadwick (1981), 180.

48 About the literary aspect of the *De fide catholica*, Chadwick has observed that there is also an allusion to Horace in 143 and to Virgil in 78. The poetical prose of the conclusion resembles the metrum III 9 of the *Consolatio.*

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catéchétique," belonging to the beginning of Boethius' career, together with the first edition of the commentary on the *Isagoge* by Marius Victorinus and the first edition of the commentary on the *De interpretatione* by Aristotle.[49] Later, Boethius deepens his Neo-Platonism and excludes the *creatio ex nihilo* and, by studying with greater attention the heresy of Nestorius, abandons the simple and sketchy definitions of this early work.

According to Galonnier, the *De fide catholica* belongs to the tradition of those works meant to expound the Christian faith and combat heresies, that is, essentially, to the tradition of catechetic works. For this same reason it firmly depends on Augustine, on the *De fide et symbolo* and *Enchiridion*. Therefore, the *De fide catholica* is characterized by a different style: the fact that it attempts to imitate the *Enchiridion* suffices to explain its clear style and its lack of brevity, which characterizes other opuscula, in particular one, two, and three; discussion and demonstration are conducted with simplicity, but clearly. Boethius had not yet found a way of discussing difficult problems briefly and esoterically.

2.2 The *Contra Eutychen et Nestorium*

In chronological order, the second (the first for those who deny the authenticity of the *De fide catholica*) among the theological works of Boethius[50] is that which has generally been placed last in the printed editions, the *Contra Eutychen et Nestorium*. It confronts a completely different theme than the others, since it is concerned with the Christological controversy, frequently debated in Boethius' times since the Council of Chalcedon (451 AD). The diversity of occasions which led Boethius to write first his Christological treatise and then the Trinitarian ones is also reflected in the difference of style between the *Contra Eutychen et Nestorium* and the tractates one to three: the style of the CEN is more relaxed and lavish, with a certain oratory fervor in some passages, while that of the other opuscula, especially of the *De hebdomadibus*, is more concise and esoteric.

2.2.1 The theological problem

The public occasion compelling Boethius to compose the *Contra Eutychen* occurred when the Church of Rome found it necessary to decide on a proposal of conciliation presented by Eastern bishops faithful to the Symbol of

49 Tisserand (2008), 59.

50 It was considered to be the first by Schurr (1935), Leonardi (1981), 109–22. The letter of the Western bishops can be read in *Epistulae Romanorum Pontificum*, Thiel (1867).

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Chalcedon on certain dogmatic assumptions. They sent a letter to a Roman council, in which they claimed that the Catholics asserted that Christ "*ex duabus naturis consistere et in duabus.*" A heated discussion arose in the Roman assembly: Boethius was present, but could not have received any advice or suggestions from his mentor, John the Deacon. Soon after he wrote his treatise *Contra Eutychen et Nestorium* to express his personal opinion on orthodox Christology. His objective, just like the letter of Pope Gelasius written twenty years earlier, was to assure the hesitant Catholics that the formula *ex duabus et in duabus naturis* was necessary to avoid the opposite heresies of Nestorius and of Eutyches, being (as was the usual interpretation of the Church) the right path between the two divergent roads.[51] As Chadwick indicated,[52] the letter that was the object of the discussion is printed in Thiel's edition as Symmachus' *Epistle* 12.[53] It is undated, but as it is addressed to Pope Symmachus (498 – 513 AD) it was probably written about 513 AD and was perhaps taken into consideration by the Roman Church under Symmachus' successor Hormisdas (514 – 523 AD). Boethius, therefore, wrote his treatise in 514 – 515 AD.

The CEN's originality lies in Boethius' search for a solution not so much in the council decrees of the previous century or the official documents of the Roman Church, but rather in Greek philosophy. Most likely, Boethius considered it impossible to propose again the dogmata of Chalcedon without any modification; moreover, he was only vaguely familiar with them and had not read them in the original version. It is likely that his sources were limited to the *Tomus ad Flavianum* by Pope Leo and those remarks offered him in those years by the authoritative, though not very profound teaching of Pope Hormisdas,[54] whose letters repeat to surfeit the statements of the formula of Chalcedon and Pope Leo.

Assuredly, with regard to the terms of the Christological question, Boethius could glean very little from Hormisdas's letters. The *Epistola* 7 (pp. 748 – 55, Thiel) contains detailed instructions for the Roman envoys sent to Constantinople to confer with Emperor Anastasius with the purpose of refuting the *Henotikòn:* Let the envoys take care to keep always, in order to present them to the emperor, the acts of the Synod of Chalcedon and the letters of the holy Pope Leo (§ 2 – 3). All the bishops, in reciprocal agreement, in the assembly before the Christian people must assert that they embrace the holy faith of Chalcedon and approve the letters written by Pope Leo against the

51 The formula "*ex utrisque et in utrisque naturis*" is employed, before Boethius, in Latin theologians of the fifth century. Cf. for instance, Vigilius Thapsensis, *Contra Eutychen* IV 16: "*quia ex utrisque Christus subsistens unus est in utroque.*" ("because Christ, existing in two natures, is the one and the same in both").

52 Chadwick (1981), 181 – 3.

53 Cf. *Epistulae Romanorum Pontificum*, Thiel (1867), 709 – 17.

54 On the theological opinions of Pope Hormisdas and his relations with the Eastern bishops and the Emperor see Chadwick (1981), 181 – 90.

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heretics Nestorius, Eutyches, Dioscorus, and their followers Timothy Aelurus, Peter, and those who are in the same party (§ 8). They must issue anathema against Acacius, the bishop of Constantinople, and Peter of Antioch, together with their companions.

The same is repeated in *Epistola* 8 (pp. 755 – 8). First the pope condemns, as usual, the heresy of Nestorius, then the heresy of Eutyches. A praise of Emperor Marcianus and Pope Leo, the defenders of orthodoxy in the previous century, follows. The followers of Eutyches are condemned, namely Dioscorus, Timothy Aelurus, Acacius, and Peter of Antioch. The true faith is considered, as was commonly said from the beginning of Christianity, the straight path between the two extremities. And so on in all Pope Hormisdas' letters.

In conclusion, Pope Hormisdas, like many others in Rome before him, essentially followed the Christological formulation of Pope Leo and, more precisely, his *Epistola ad Flavianum*, which, written by an energetic pope considered to be a champion of the correct faith, had become authoritative for Western Christianity. It also offers a precise canonical terminology to express in Latin the Chalcedonian formulas, which were so useful that Boethius, too, employed them. In the *Tomus ad Flavianum* it is said that Christ is not *divisus essentia* (§ 20), that his body possesses a *veritas* (i. e. a true human nature, § 50), that the *proprietas* of each nature is united "(*coeunte*) *in unam personam*" (§ 55), so that in Christ there is a single person (§ 122), a *unitas personae* (§ 126).[55] Therefore, Leo rejects the confession by Eutyches (§ 178 – 9): "*ex duabus naturis fuisse Dominum nostrum ante adunationem, post vero adunationem unam naturam*,"[56] that is, the divine nature. The term '*adunatio*,' which means the hypostatic union of the two natures of Christ corresponds to ἕνωσις in the Symbol of Chalcedon (§ 19), and to the expression 'reunited in a unity' in the letter of Pope Hormisdas to the archimandrites. But it is also found in the Latin writers of that age, who were concerned with the problem of the two natures of Christ, such as John Maxentius,[57] and finally in Boethius' works (CEN 5 and 7 several times).

2.2.2 Boethius' solution

Such was the orthodoxy of the Roman Church upon which Boethius had to reflect: a sketchy doctrine reduced to a few repetitious formulas. The meagerness of Hormisdas' theological thought could not satisfy those who, like Boethius, wanted to say something new or make their own personal

55 We use the edition by Silva Tarouca S.I. (1959).

56 "That our Lord was composed of two natures before the union (the incarnation), but he was one nature after the union."

57 In his works the term recurs *ad abundantiam*, so that it is not necessary to quote it in detail: see CCLat XCIa; LXXXVa.

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contribution. Boethius accepted the formula proposed by the Eastern bishops (*ex utrisque et in utrisque naturis*), re-examining (and this is the new element) on the basis of the Aristotelian and Platonic doctrines the heretical formulas of Christology, which had become reduced to mere hollow statements by his time.[58] This was an attitude favorable to the Eastern Church, which Boethius considered perfectly orthodox:

Cum igitur utrasque manere naturas in Christo fides catholica confiteatur perfectasque easdem persistere nec alteram in alteram transmutari, iure dicit et in utrisque naturis Christum et ex utrisque consistere: in utrisque quidem, quia manent utraeque, ex utrisque vero, quia utrarumque adunatione manentium una persona fit Christi (7,607 – 13).[59]

In so doing, Boethius certainly did not act '*piscatorie*,' but '*Aristotelice*.' These terms have been reviewed by Grillmeier, who analyzed the criticism of an obscure bishop, Euippus, who attended the Council of Chalcedon, of the discussions and conclusions of the Council itself. Grillmeier, like Euippus, believes that the conclusions to which the Fathers arrived were characterized by a philosophical attitude, which had abandoned the 'kerygmatic' one typical of the previous centuries of Christianity.[60] Presuming that such opposition is valid (and we believe that it is only partially so),[61] Boethius, too, is the victim of this mode of expression in Aristotelian style about which Euippus complained. But precisely with this Aristotelian attitude he arrived at theological formulations – in particular '*substantia*' and '*persona*' – that remained essential for Scholastic philosophy.[62] To the essentially scant basis of the theological speculation of his time, Boethius introduced his philosophical analyses.

2.2.3 God and matter

Beginning with the most original entities, Boethius, as a good Platonist, commences by distinguishing God and matter. They share the characteristic

58 As Micaelli notes (1981a, 327 – 36, at 336), this attitude does not result from philosophy prevailing over theology in him, but from a feeling that a new examination of Biblical passages would have been pointless at that stage, after a century of heated discussions.

59 "Since then the Catholic Faith confesses that both natures continue in Christ and that they both remain perfect, neither being transformed into the other, it says rightly that Christ consists both in and of the two natures: *in* the two, because both continue, *of* the two because the one person of Christ is formed by the union of the two continuing natures."

60 Grillmeier (1990), 765 – 6, Daley (1984), 171 – 2.

61 It was, however, traditional: cf. for instance, Hilary of Poitiers in Latin theology (*Trin.* II 13 ff.), Gregory of Nazianzus (*Orat.*23,12) in Greek.

62 On these definitions cf. Micaelli (1981a), 329 – 31, (1988), 45 – 60, Milano (1984), 320 – 5, 333 – 5, Chadwick (1981), 194 – 7.

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that "*integro perfectoque intellectu intellegi non possunt, sed aliquo tamen modo ceterarum rerum privatione capiuntur*"[63] (1,70 – 2).

By this definition Boethius differs from Christian writers as well, who are never concerned with matter and maintain that God cannot be grasped in any way, not even by the intellect. According to Obertello,[64] this Boethian definition of God means that it is possible to conceive of him as pure form when any trace of potentiality has been removed. Actually, what Boethius asserts is a usual procedure in the Platonic tradition, because it employs the *via negationis*, introduced to Latin Christian Platonism by Marius Victorinus:

Etenim cum quid sit deus nullo modo scire possimus, sublatio omnium exsistentium, quae Graeci ὄντα appellant, cognitionem Dei nobis, circumcisa et ablata notarum rerum cognitione, supponet: deus est neque corpus neque ullum elementum neque anima neque mens neque sensus neque intellectus neque aliquid quod ex his capi potest. His talibus sublatis, quid sit deus poterit definiri; magis si addas, quod etiam definiri non potest, id deum esse (*Defin.* p. 354,18 – 25, Hadot).[65]

The *via negationis*, Victorinus says, is a '*privatio*' ("*iuxta negationem omnino omnimodis, ut* privatio *sit existentis*," *Ad Cand.* 4, p. 19,2 – 3[66]) or a '*privantia*' (*Defin.* p. 353,9 – 10, Hadot). And, more precisely, he states that God is an absolute non-being, but "*non per privationem universi eius quod sit*"[67] (*Ad Cand.* 4, p. 19,12 – 13; cf. *Adv Arium* IV 23, p. 260,23 – 6: "*Quare* […] *sine existentia, sine substantia, sine intelligentia, sine vita dicitur, non quidem per* στέρησιν*, id est non per privationem, sed per supralationem*").[68]

In addition, the other formulas of the Platonic tradition to attain knowledge of God are indicated by Victorinus as the '*via eminentiae*,' cf. *Ad Cand.* 13, p. 30,5 – 6 ("*necessario per praelationem et per eminentiam* τῶν ὄντων *deum dicemus supra omnem exsistentiam*");[69] *Adv. Arium* IV 19, p. 254,10 – 12

63 "God and matter cannot be apprehended by the intellect, be it never so whole and perfect, but still they are apprehended in some way through the removal of other things."

64 Severino Boezio, Obertello/Ribet (1979), 322, n. 8.

65 "Since in no way can we understand what God is, the elimination of all that exists, which Greeks call ὄντα, will give us the knowledge of God, after we have cut away the science of all that we know. God indeed is neither a body nor a natural element nor a soul nor an intelligence nor anything else which we can obtain thanks to the help of these things. Once all this has been taken away, we can have a definition of God's nature, and the more so, if we add that God is exactly that which in no way is the object of a definition."
The text of the *Liber de definitionibus* can be found in P. Hadot (1971), 329 – 65. The passage has been discussed by Hadot, 163 – 78, particularly at 175 – 6; see also Elsässer (1973), 52 – 53.

66 "According to negation, so that absolutely and in all ways there is privation of existence." We quote here and below from: Marius Victorinus, Henry/P. Hadot (1971). The translations are taken from Clark (1981).

67 "Not through privation of all that is his".

68 "That is why it is said that he is without existence, without substance, without understanding, without life, certainly not by privation, but through transcendence."

69 "Necessarily we say that through superiority and preeminence over the existents God is above all existence."

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("*verum esse primum ita inparticipatum est, ut nec unum dici possit nec solum, sed per praelationem, ante unum et ante solum*").[70]

Boethius, however, does not insist on the unknowability of God: Micaelli, after a long and in-depth study of God's metaphysical attributes according to Boethius, correctly observes[71] that negative theology does not carry the same weight for Boethius as for Proclus or Pseudo-Dionysius. In addition, the assertion that God and matter cannot be comprehended *integro perfectoque intellectu* reminds us of the similar assertion by Plato (*Tim.* 52b), which is traditional in the Platonic school, that matter can only be comprehended λογισμῷ τινι νόθῳ ("through a bastard reasoning").[72] Thus, it becomes evident from these parallel passages that Boethius employs Marius Victorinus more often than commonly thought, even though he had previously criticized his translation of Porphyry's *Isagoge.*

2.2.4 God and action

It is a prerogative of God to be able to exercize all action without being subject to passion, which is typical, on the other hand, of created things: "*facere vero tantum, ut Deus ceteraque divina*"[73] (CEN 1,84 – 5). Gersh[74] refers to different passages in Augustine (*De mus.* VI 17,56 – 7; *De gen. ad litt.* I 18; IV 11 – 2; IV 22; V 20); the most significant being that from *Trin.* V 8,9: "*solus enim Deus facit et ipse non fit, neque patitur quantum ad eius substantiam pertinet, qua Deus est*".[75]

The expression *ceteraque divina* seems to be quite generic, as it remains unclear who these 'divine substances' besides God are. To surmise that Boethius is referring to the Persons of divine Trinity[76] is absurd, because the Persons cannot be distinguished from God himself. An analogous expression is found in *Consol.* V 2,7: "*supernis divinisque substantiis.*"[77] Boethius' phrase,

70 "But the first 'to be' is so unparticipated that it cannot even be called one or alone, but rather, by preeminence, before the one, before the alone."

71 Elsässer (1973), 68, Micaelli (1995), 51 – 126, at 126.

72 Matter is comprehensible with an *adulterata opinio* already according to Apuleius (*Plat.* I 5,192), and the same is repeated by the Middle-Platonist Calcidius (*Comm.* 346 – 7) (see Moreschini, 2014, forthcoming) and the Christian heretic Hermogenes (Tert., *Hermog.* 35,2, Waszink: cf. Greschat (2000), 182 – 4). The explanation by Elsässer (1973), 53 is in my opinion too convoluted.

73 "On the other hand, only act, as God and other divine substances."

74 Gersh (1986), 695 – 7.

75 "Only God acts and is not patient nor is acted upon, as far as His substance is concerned, because He is God."

76 As Elsässer does (1973), 58.

77 Cf. Boethius, Kommentar, Gruber (^{2}2006), *ad locum.*

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"all the divine reality that can be conceived," must be considered generic, because logically the divine reality is only one.[78]

2.2.5 God and being

In chapter 3,250 – 2 (a passage involving a discussion to which we shall return later), Boethius asserts: "*Deus quoque* (scl., besides man) *et* οὐσία *est et essentia: est enim, et maxime ipse est, a quo omnium esse proficiscitur*".[79] This means that God is the *primum esse*, that is the being of the highest degree. This conception unites, in Christian Neo-Platonism, the Platonic concept of ὄντως ὤν with the biblical one of Es 3:14: ἐγώ εἰμι ὁ ὤν, interpreted as "I am the one who is," more frequently than as "I am that who am."

That the first principle possesses the being of the highest degree is, in fact, a doctrine that dates back to Porphyry, *Sent.* 39:

On the contrary, of the real and immaterial being, existing by itself, the predicates are: it always perseverates in itself (τὸ ὡσαύτως κατὰ ταυτὰ ἔχειν), is identically equal, is substantialised (οὐσιῶσθαι)[80] in the identity, is immutable in its essence, simple, indissoluble, is not in a place nor is dispersed in a mass, is not being born and does not die, and all the other predicates similar to these (τοῦ δὲ ὄντως ὄντος καὶ καθ'αὑτὸ ὑφεστηκότος ἀύλου τὸ εἶναι ἀεὶ ἐν ἑαυτῷ ἱδρυμένον, τὸ ὡσαύτως κατὰ ταυτὰ ἔχειν, τὸ ἐν ταυτότητι οὐσιῶσθαι, τὸ ἀμετάβλητον εἶναι κατ'οὐσίαν, τὸ ἀσύνθετον, τὸ μήτε λυτὸν μήτε ἐν τόπῳ εἶναι μήτ'εἰς ὄγκον διαπεφορῆσθαι, τὸ μήτε γινόμενον μήτε ἀπολλύμενον εἶναι καὶ ὅσα τούτοις ὅμοια).

This is a doctrine of the Platonic tradition (already in Plutarch, *De E apud Delphos* 393AB). The difference between divine and material reality (an obvious distinction for a Platonist) is also found in Boethius' *Arithm.* II 31:

Dicunt enim omnes omnium rerum substantias constare ex ea, quae propriae suaeque semper habitudinis est nec ullo modo permutatur, et ea scilicet natura, quae variabilis motus est sortita substantiam. At illam primam immutabilem naturam unius eiusdemque substantiae vocant, hanc vero alterius, scilicet quod a prima illa immutabili discedens prima sit altera, quod nimirum ad unitatem pertinet et ad dualitatem, qui numerus primus ab uno discedens alter factus est.[81]

78 It is possible to read some inaccuracies into this treatise due to the work's more discursive character. For instance, the final assertion, at chapter 7, to expose the doctrine of the Catholic Church on the incarnation of the Son, does not correspond to orthodox Christology, but is a personal interpretation of Boethius.

79 "Next, God is οὐσία or essence, for he is and is especially that from which proceeds the being of all things."

80 On this term see Moreschini (2014 – forthcoming).

81 "They assert that all the substances of the things are formed of that substance which has its proper character and always retains it, and of that nature which had the substance of the changeable movement. But the first, unchangeable nature is characterized by the same and one

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Later, Porphyry's teaching passed to Marius Victorinus: "*Equidem ratio sic se habet, ut primum esse sit Deus*" (*Adv. Arium* II 4, p. 176,7 – 8);[82] "*verum quoniam quod est illud esse purum est, hoc magis substantia est*" (*Adv. Arium* II 4, p. 177,3 – 4).[83] That is, since this primary being is without bonds it is substance *par excellence:* God is specifically being and substance. See also: "*Verum esse primum ita imparticipatum est ut nec unum dici possit*" (*Adv. Arium* IV 19, p. 254,10 – 11);[84] "*hoc cum ita sit, videamus an illius primi quod est esse sit* λόγος"(*Adv. Arium* IV 20, p. 255,1 – 2).[85]

And finally, the concept of God as pure being, as being of the highest degree is also attested in Augustine, as Gersh notes,[86] who quotes several passages: for God as an equivalent of '*esse*' cf. *De vera religione* 18,35; *Trin.* V 2,3; VII 5,10 etc.; as an equivalent of '*essentia*' cf. *De vera relig.* 11,22; *Trin.* V 2,3 and V 9,10 etc.

The passage by Boethius is thus both Porphyrian (via Marius Victorinus) and Augustinian. This is also demonstrated by a long discussion on the term *subsistentia*, a translation of οὐσίωσις dependent on Victorinus.[87] A further result of the doctrine of the being is the assertion that Being coincides with the 'One'[88] (CEN 4,296 – 301):

Nihil igitur unum secundum Nestorium Christus est, ac per hoc omnino nihil. Quod enim non est unum, nec esse omnino potest; esse enim atque unum convertitur, et quodcumque unum est, est. Etiam ea quae ex pluribus coniunguntur, ut acervus, chorus, unum tamen sunt.[89]

It is the same doctrine of *Cons.* III 11,36 – 7: all that exists must be one. The phrase *omnium esse* is resumed a few years later with an abundance of uses in the third theological tractate, as we shall examine further below.

Connected to this sentence is the concept that from the being of God the being of all things derives: to express this doctrine in the CEN, Boethius employs the term '*proficiscitur*' (3,252), in the *De hebdomadibus* the verb '*fluxit*' (136; 142; 149), or (God's) '*producere*' (140 – 5), and in the *Consolatio*

substance, while the other one is of a different substance, of course, because it is the first which comes after the absolutely first. No wonder, because the second is connected with unity and duality, since the first number, abandoning itself, became another number."

82 "Certainly, reason requires that God is the first 'to be'."

83 "Indeed, since that which is primary 'to be' is pure, this is predominantly substance."

84 "But the first 'to be' is so unparticipated that it cannot even be called one."

85 "Since this is, let us see whether the 'to be' of that first has a Logos."

86 Gersh (1986), 684, n. 160.

87 See Moreschini, quoted above, n. 80.

88 Cf. Micaelli (1995), 68 – 70, 123 – 25.

89 "Therefore Christ is, according to Nestorius, in no respect one, and therefore he is absolutely nothing. For what is not one cannot exist at all either, because being and unity are convertible terms, and whatever is one, is. Even things which are made up of many items, such as a heap or a chorus, are nevertheless one."

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(III metrum IX 19) (God's) '*provehere.*'[90] All these terms assume a value that changes in accordance with each occurrence, but all aim to express how God is at the origin of all beings, without reference to the concept of 'creation,' which is not Platonic.[91] Boethius therefore asserts that God is "*fons rerum*" (*Cons.* III, metrum IX 4 – 6; I 6,11; III 12,1 – 2; IV metrum VI,43; V 3,27) and the "*rerum principium*" (*De hebdomadibus* 114 – 5).

This assertion is also found in Marius Victorinus: "*Quid istud illud est, ex quo omnia? Deus*"[92] (*Candidi epist.* 3, p. 4,9 – 10); God is "*omnium causa*" (*Ad Cand.* 3, p. 19,2; 6, p. 21,3; 18, p. 36,10 – 11: "*Si enim prima causa, non solum omnium causa, sed et sibi ipsi causa est*;"[93] cf. also *Adv. Arium* II 4, p. 176,4 – 5: "*Deus est omnipotens causa omnium, et fons et origo omnium quae sunt*");[94] God is "*illud principale, illud unde omne vivere omnium ceterorum*" (*Adv. Arium* IV 15, p. 246,3 – 4).

To interpret the first cause as the first good is common in Neo-Platonism. Boethius asserts that God is the *primum bonum*, the real good, and this doctrine is essential to *De hebdomadibus*, as shall be shown further below.

2.2.6 The refutation of Nestorius and of Eutyches

The purpose for writing the CEN was to refute heretic Christology: Eutyches and Nestorius proposed an unsatisfactory solution to the problem of the conjoined presence of the two persons, the human and the divine, in the incarnated Christ. The opposition to Nestorius and Eutyches is traditionally interpreted as the orthodox choice of the *via media.*

To demonstrate that neither of the two solutions is valid, Boethius recurs to the Aristotelian-Stoic doctrine of the mixture[95] by applying one of its aspects to the Christology of Nestorius and another to that of Eutyches, concluding that neither conforms with orthodox Christology. One clue that the origin of this discussion depends on Aristotelian doctrine is provided by the assertion in 6,526 – 7: "*Omne enim corpus quod* in generatione et corruptione *subsistit communem videtur habere materiam.*"[96]

90 Also Procl., *In Tim.* I, 27 (προάγων).

91 On this issue see the important observations by Micaelli (1995), 74 – 79, and the hints in Baltes (1980), 313 – 40, at 316.

92 "And what is that from which all things come? It is God."

93 "For if God is first cause, he is not only the cause of all things, but he is also cause for himself."

94 "God is the omnipotent cause of all, both source and origin of all existents."

95 The use of the Aristotelian and Stoic doctrines to interpret the two opposite heresies of Eutyches and Nestorius has been hinted at by Micaelli (1981b), 177 – 99, at 177 – 8 (about παράθεσις) and 188—90 (about κρᾶσις). Micaelli, however, apparently insists more on Stoicism and Alexander of Aphrodisias' definitions than on Aristotle's *De generatione et corruptione*, which seems to me to accord much more with Boethius' sources.

96 "For every body which subsists in conditions of birth and decay seems to possess a common matter."

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First, Nestorius' solution does not produce an adequate compenetration of the two natures of Christ, but only a *coniunctio* of them. It is similar to that union which is said by the Greeks (another clue that Boethius is using precise philosophical doctrines) to be accomplished "by juxtaposition," that is κατὰ παράθεσιν: "*Quae est igitur facta hominis deique coniunctio? Num ita quasi cum duo corpora sibimet apponuntur, ut tantum locis iuncta sint et nihil in alterum ex alterius qualitate perveniat?*"[97](4,286 – 8).

This kind of mixture is what Aristotle defined as σύνθεσις καὶ οὐ κρᾶσις οὐδὲ μῖξις[98] (*De generatione et corruptione* 328a9) and clarified with the following example: οἷον κριθὰς μεμῖχθαι πυροῖς ὅταν ἡτισοῦν παρὰ ὁτινοῦν τεθῇ (328a2 – 3).[99] The Stoics adopted both the definition (cf. SVF II 157,38) and the example (cf. SVF II 471,4):[100] "as we see that it happens in the heaps, in the case of wheat, barley and lentiles" (ὡς ἐπὶ τῶν σωρῶν ὁρῶμεν τῶν πυρῶν τε καὶ κριθῶν καὶ φακῶν) and specify that this kind of union, that is, a 'contact on the surface,' is only a 'juxtaposition of the bodies.' The term παράθεσις is exactly the one Boethius used.

The solution proposed by the Eutychians, on the other hand, is more complicated: "*aut enim divinitas in humanitatem translata est aut humanitas in divinitatem aut utraeque in se ita temperatae sunt atque commixtae, ut neutra substantia propriam formam teneret*"[101] (6,484 – 7). The first case is impossible: "*sola enim mutari transformarique in se possunt quae habent unius materiae commune subiectum*[102], *nec haec omnia, sed ea quae in se et facere et pati possunt*"[103] (6,502 – 4).

This assertion is based on Aristotle (*De generatione et corruptione* 328a24 – 5): τῶν δε ποιητικῶν καὶ παθητικῶν ὅσα εὐδιαίρετα, πολλὰ μὲν ὀλίγοιν καὶ μεγάλα μικροῖν συντιθέμενα, οὐ ποιεῖ μῖξιν, ἀλλὰ αὔξησιν τοῦ κρατούντος:[104] the union between matters which are subject to making and suffering, if it occurs when the matters themselves are of different nature, does

97 "What kind of union, then, between God and man has been effected? Is it as when two bodies are laid the one against the other, so that they are only joined locally, and nothing of the quality of the one reaches the other […]?"

98 "For this will be 'composition' and not 'blending' or 'mixing'" (the translations of Aristotle are taken from Forster (1955)).

99 "For instance, we say that barley is mixed with wheat when each grain of barley is placed side by side with a grain of wheat."

100 Cf. Micaelli (1981b), 177 – 8.

101 "Either divinity was translated into humanity, or humanity into divinity, or both were so modified and mingled that neither substance kept its proper form."

102 This is the translation of ὑποκείμενον.

103 "For only those things can be interchanged and transformed which possess the common substrate of the same matter, nor can all of these so behave, but only those which can act upon and be acted on by each other."

104 "But of things which are capable of action and capable of being acted upon, those which are easily divisible, when many of one of them are compounded with few of another or a large bulk with a small, do not produce a mixture, but an increase of the predominant ingredient, for there is a change of the other ingredient into the predominant."

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not produce a real union, but an increase of the strongest substance. The union of the two natures in Christ, proposed by the Monophysites, appears to be impossible, because not an interpenetration of the divine nature with the human would occur, but rather an increase of the strongest substance, that is of the divine one to the detriment of the weaker one, the human substance. This example dates from a time long before: Gregory of Nyssa had already asserted in his *Against Eunomius* that the humanity of Christ is lost in his divinity just like a drop of vinegar in the sea.[105]

One example of what Boethius intends is illustrated by the mixture of wine and water, and their reciprocal *pati:* if one of the two substances, the water or the wine, prevails, the other is corrupted. This example is taken from Aristotle as well: another question concerns the determination of what increases during the mixture, that is, if it is the body to which something is added, or the thing which is added to the body (*De generatione et corruptione* 321a29). For instance, in the growth of the leg by means of nourishment it is the leg that grows, not the nourishment, whereas if wine is added to water they both seem to grow. In the first case, the substance of nourishment disappears, while in the second case it does not, because it is the dominating component which gives its name to the mixture, as happens in the case of wine, since it is the action of the wine, not the action of the water to produce the mixture as a whole (ποιεῖ γὰρ τὸ τοῦ οἴνου ἔργον ἀλλ᾽ οὐ τὸ τοῦ ὕδατος τὸ σύνολον μῖγμα) (321b 1).[106] If then, Boethius continues, the mixture occurs between mutually balanced substances, a *temperatio* (6,520 – 3) ensues, but this is only possible in the bodies and in those which are subject to a reciprocal making and suffering (6,523 – 6): now, all this cannot be the case of the union of the human person and the divine person in Christ.

The Eutychians maintained that Christ consisted of two natures, but was not in two natures, evidently because they believed that what is formed of two natures is unified in the sense that "*illa ex quibus dicitur constare non maneant*" (6,562), as it occurs in the case of the union of water with honey, which produces mead, but neither of the two components of the compound remains as it is (6,563 – 7). To this assertion Boethius replies (7,622) by rejecting the Eutychian formula "*ex utrisque consistere*" as *aequivocum*, or rather *amphibolum.* The state of *aequivocus*, according to the common definitions of the rhetorical and logical texts, occurs when "*multarum rerum unum nomen est, sed non eadem definitio*,"[107] as Martianus Capella writes (*De nuptiis* IV 355), meaning in our context that the Eutychian formula indicates

105 Cf. *Contra Eunomium* III 3,45; 3,68.

106 "For the mixture as a whole performs the function of wine and not of water." See also Aristotle, *De generatione et corruptione* 322a 9—10.

107 "When of many things only one is the name, but the definitions are different."

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that the person of Christ is made of more than one nature, without specifying which is predominant, the divine or the human.[108]

Therefore Boethius, after having explained the state of "*ex utrisque consistere*," which, if correctly understood, means: "*ita ex utrisque coniunctum, ut utraque permaneant*"[109] (7,626 – 7), accepts, as he had already explained in the introduction to his work, the formula just proposed at that time in Rome by the Eastern bishops, of Christ "*ex utrisque et in utrisque naturis*." In fact, it means that those substances that are united to form a new one are preserved in it, as in the case of a crown made of gold and precious stones (7,595 – 605).

This solution is thus an attempt at overcoming the difficulty constituted by the Eutychian formula without risking to fall into that of Nestorius: it rejects both the μῖξις and the παράθεσις, even though the weakness of such a proposal is evident,[110] since it presents a nonessential but composite unity; this solution had already been prefigured in the criticism of Nestorius (4,300 – 1), whose heresy seems to be considered generally less dangerous than that of Eutyches.[111] We must remember, in the end, that the use of Aristotelian definitions like Boethius' may also be traced in Eastern theologians: for instance, Maximus the Confessor proposes the very same definitions of *mixis* and *krasis* (*Opusc. theol. et polem.* 17, PG 91, 213AB): of course, Maximus had not read Boethius, but we can presume that a scholastic tradition of such definitions actually did exist, both in the East and the West.

Boethius' proposal is nevertheless novel, because it attempts to solve the difficulties without resorting to the Council's (and therefore strictly Christian) formulas, but by employing philosophical definitions, by applying in a more rigorous way certain concepts, like μῖξις, παράθεσις, and κρᾶσις, of which the contenders in the Christological controversies of the fifth century had availed themselves according to common usage.[112] For instance, Theodoret of Cyrus criticized Cyril of Alexandria for his concept of 'mixture,' remarking that it is necessary that "the confusion is the result of the mixture, and the confusion, by happening, eliminates the peculiarity of each nature" (τῇ κράσει ἀκολουθῆσαι τὴν σύγχυσιν, εἰσιοῦσα δὲ ἡ σύγχυσις ἀφαιρεῖται τὴν ἑκάστης φύσεως ἰδιότητα, *Acta Conciliorum Oecumenicorum* I 1,6).[113]

108 This is explained by Boethius in *Isagog.*, 17,21 Schepss-Brand; cf. Tisserand (2008), 370.

109 "The union effected of the two is such that both natures continue."

110 This is also the opinion of Milano (1984), 380.

111 Cf. Quacquarelli (1981), 227 – 45, at 240, Lutz-Bachmann (1983), 48 – 70, at 68 – 69.

112 They can be read in the texts quoted by Grillmeier (cf. 1990, 885, 923).

113 Some of Boethius' tenets in his Christological discussions have, according to Chadwick (1981, 197 – 202), their source in Augustine. Yet some of the parallels (in particular those with the *Sermones*, which I doubt Boethius read) are not so convincing.

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2.2.7 *Natura* and *persona*

A discussion such as this one is extremely difficult and technical. In order to explain how the presence of two natures (and consequently of two persons) in Christ can possibly form a single person, Boethius preliminarily devotes himself to the definition of both nature and person. The first definition of *natura* is: "*natura est earum rerum quae, cum sint, quoquo modo intellectu capi possunt*"[114] (1, p. 209,66 – 7). To this the clarification is added "in some way" (*quoquo modo*), which means that God and matter are not conceivable by the human intellect: this clarification appears in various Greek Neo-Platonists,[115] but also in Calcidius (c. 319, p. 315,20, Waszink). According to Augustine as well (*De ordine* II 6,44), nothingness has its own existence.

The second definition is: "*natura est vel quod facere vel quod pati possit*,"[116] (1, p. 210,81 – 2) a definition probably deriving from Plato's *Sophist* (247de).[117] Here 'natura,' as in Aristotle, is attributed to physical substances.

The third definition also comes from Aristotle (*Phys.* 192b20), where nature is defined as "*motus principium secundum se, non per accidens:* the principle of movement *per se* and not accidental." (1, p. 211,97).[118]

As a fourth definition nature is, still according to Aristotle (*Phys.* 193a28—31), "*unamquamque rem informans specifica differentia:* the specific difference that gives form to anything." (1, p. 212,111 – 2). The third and fourth definitions are those bringing Boethius closer to his own definition of *persona. Persona*, therefore, must be exclusively referred to nature, that is to substance, and not to accidents.

2.2.8 The human person

These considerations on *persona* are not the first Boethius proposes. Commenting on Porphyry's *Isagoge* for the second time, around 508 – 509 AD (thus a few years before the CEN) Boethius explains:

Dividere enim est in multitudinem quod unum ante fuerat dissolvere (*Isagog.*, p. 228,14, Schepss-Brand) […] *Omnia enim individua disgregativa sunt et divisiva* (p. 229,10) […] *Participatione speciei, id est hominis, Cato, Plato et Cicero pluresque*

114 "Nature belongs to those things which, since they exist, can in some way be apprehended by the intellect."

115 For instance, Iohannes Philoponus, *In Aristot. Categ.*, 52,2 ss. Busse and elsewhere (see Micaelli (1981a), 328).

116 "Nature is either that which can act or that which can be acted upon."

117 A hypothesis advanced (*inter alios*) by Schurr (1935), 15; Micaelli (1981a), 328, (1988), 52 and Schlapkohl (1999), 24.

118 Probably taken from Alex. Aphrod. *In Metaph.* 358,4 – 8, Hayduck (Micaelli (1981a), 329), Chadwick (1981), 192 – 3.

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reliqui homines unus, id est milia hominum in eo quod sunt homines, unus homo est; at vero unus homo, qui specialis est, si ad hominum multitudinem qui sub ipso sunt consideretur, plures fiunt (p. 229,21 – 230,3).[119]

So Porphyry believes that real individuals, because they are such, that is, because they are single and limited unities, dissolve the general and divide the species. Boethius, therefore, maintains, by following Porphyry, that persons constitute an individuality compared to the species, but underlines how especially their differences consist in accidents, which is considered by Milano[120] as "a weak, or rather a degrading consequence." This assertion may be grasped by considering the so-called "tree of Porphyry," according to which the single species, which is man, is a part in comparison with the more general species, which is the animal, while it is a whole with regards to single individuals, such as Plato, Cato, and Cicero. These constitute parts of the very special species, and are no longer totalities, which are in turn divisible:

Individuum autem pluribus dicitur modis: dicitur individuum quod omnino secari non potest, ut unitas vel mens; dicitur individuum quod ob soliditatem dividi nequit, ut adamas; dicitur individuum cuius praedicatio in reliqua similia non convenit, ut Socrates (ibid., p. 195,12 – 16).[121]

On the basis of these assumptions, the individual nature of a man is only constituted by a mixture of common properties, such as reasonableness, sensitiveness, capacity to laugh, and individual properties, which respectively and exclusively fit each single man, such as Cato, Plato, and Cicero. Since reason is included in the number of the common properties, it cannot be used to distinguish one individual from another within the human species, because one individual is distinct from another because of a property or a group of individual properties:

Quae enim unicuique individuo forma est, ea non ex substantiali quadam forma species, sed ex accidentibus venit (ibid., p. 200,5 – 7); *speciei adunationem in singulares individuasque personas accidentia partiuntur* (ibid., p. 229,1 – 3).[122]

119 "To divide, in fact, means to dissolve into a multiplicity what previously was one […] In fact, all individual realities are a cause of disaggregation and division […] Thanks to the participation in the species – that is, in the species 'man' – Cato, Plato, Cicero and all the other men are one, that is to say that the multitude of men, as far as they are men, is a single man. But the single man, who is that of the species 'man' [*qui specialis est*], if he is considered and compared with the large number of men that are summarised under him, becomes a multiplicity of men."

120 Milano (1984), 336.

121 "But the term 'individual' is said with different meanings: 'individual' is defined what cannot absolutely be divided, such as unity or human intellect; 'individual' is defined what, because of its solidity, cannot be divided, like a diamond; 'individual' is defined that whose predicate does not fit in with other similar individuals, like Socrates."

122 "In fact, what constitutes the form of each individual is not a species which derives from a substantial form, but comes to him from the accidents; the accidents divide into singular and individual persons what is gathered in the species."

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As a consequence, the person has no substantial weight, it is much less important than the species. "Such a philosophy proclaims the shipwreck of our persons: these all depend on an anonymous humanity and are only the superficial protuberances of the species."[123] Where there is more plurality, there we become more removed from the One, that is from the supreme principle of being. In the *De sancta Trinitate* (1, p. 167,46 – 8 and 168,58 – 63) Boethius also asserts:

Principium enim pluralitatis alteritas est: praeter alteritatem enim nec pluralitas quid sit intellegi potest […] *Sed numero differentiam accidentium varietas facit. Nam tres homines neque genere neque specie, sed suis accidentibus distant. Nam vel si animo cuncta ab his accidentia separemus, tamen locus cunctis diversus est, quem unum fingere nullo modo possumus: duo enim corpora unum locum non obtinebunt, qui est accidens. Atque ideo sunt numero plures, quoniam accidentibus plures fiunt.*[124]

However, Boethius followed Aristotelian doctrine as well. He maintains that the individual does not only derive from accident, but also from substance. Even if it must become manifest through accident, individuality consists in a *quid proprium* of substantial nature:

Primas substantias aequaliter esse substantias. Aliquis homo enim atque aliquis equus, quoniam sunt individua principaliter substantiae sunt, et propriae et maximae […] *individua igitur aequaliter substantiae sunt* (*In categ.*, PL 64,188C).[125]

So Boethius, changing what he had said in following Porphyry, insists on the individuality of the first substance, which, in this case, is the single individual. The mere presence of individuality is for him proof of substantiality.

In his second commentary on Aristotle's *De interpretatione*, Boethius distinguishes two kinds of *qualitates:* one is the *qualitas singularis*, which is found in individuals as a single form belonging to each individual, for instance, that which belongs to Plato or Socrates such as they are. The other is the *qualitas communis* of all those belonging to the same species or the same gender, and it is a whole both in each individual and in the ensemble of the individuals participating in the same form, such as humanity or the human soul: both Socrates and Plato, being individuals each have their own specific

123 Cf. Nédoncelle (1955), 201 – 38, at 205.

124 "For the principle of plurality is otherness; for apart from otherness plurality is unintelligible. In fact, the diversity of three or more things lies in genus or species or number: for as often as 'same' is said, so often is 'diverse' also predicated. […] Now numerical difference is caused by a variety of accidents; for three men differ neither by genus nor species but by their accidents, for even if we mentally remove from them all other accidents, still the places for each are diverse, which we cannot by any means make into one place, since two bodies will not occupy one place, and place is an accident. Wherefore it is because men are made plural by their accidents that they are plural in number."

125 "The first substances are all equally substances. In fact, a man and a horse, since they are individual beings are substances in a principal sense, and are specific and the greatest substances. […] The individual realities, therefore, are all equally substances."

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properties, and properties which are common to the entire human species. Describing these two kinds of qualities, Boethius notes:

Quotienscumque enim aliquid tale animo speculamur, non in unamquamque personam per nomen hoc mentis cogitatione deducimur, sed in omnes eos quicumque humanitatis definitione participant (p. 136,25 – 28, Meiser).[126]

Boethius, therefore, proposes to create a special term to indicate the *qualitas singularis:* for instance, *platonitas*, that is the particular and incommunicable form making the person Plato who he is in his uniqueness, while the term designating the common quality, for example, *humanitas*, contains what is general:

Unde fit ut, quoniam Platonitas in unum convenit Platonem, audientis animus 'Platonis' vocabulum ad unam personam unamque particularem substantiam referat; cum autem audit 'hominem' ad plures quosque intellectum referat quoscumque humanitate contineri novit (p. 137,13 – 8, Meiser).[127]

The '*platonitas*,' therefore, specifically fits the single person, while the *humanitas* indicates all those who participate in the definition of '*homo*,' that is, in the '*qualitas communis*.' The '*platonitas*' refers to him who possesses the '*forma*,' specific and not communicable with others, of Plato, and so it might designate the '*particularis substantia*' of the person Plato. "Here we have arrived at a complete reverse of what Boethius had proposed: the human individual is not the result of the sum of the accidents, but precedes it; rather he influences, as it were, the substantiality itself of man," Nédoncelle notes.[128]

With Boethius the speculation on *persona* reaches a great profundity and his achievements will be well received in the Middle Ages; however, he starts from assumptions entirely different from those of Augustine and of the Christian tradition. For Boethius, a layman without ecclesiastical commitments, the problem is exclusively philosophical, even though his philosophical speculation affected Christology. More particularly, and still unlike Augustine, Boethius arrives at a definition of *persona*, which is more well-known – namely that expounded in *Against Eutyches and Nestorius* examined here – after various attempts, which do not constitute a finished synthesis. Boethius "appartenait à l'espèce assez rare des classificateurs qui sont en même temps des conciliateurs: d'ou le caractère assez composite de ses spéculations."[129] In

126 "In fact, every time we consider with our intellect something of this kind, we are led by our thought to conceive through this name not each single person, but all those who participate in the definition of human nature."

127 "As a consequence, since the 'Platonicity' is referred to Plato only, when we hear the word 'Plato,' we are led with our thoughts to a single person and to a single particular substance. When, on the other hand, we hear the name of 'man,' our thought is led to many, to all those that it knows to be contained in the term 'human nature'."

128 Nédoncelle (1955), 208.

129 Nédoncelle (1955), 208.

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any case, a certain evolution can be observed in his thought, even though he oscillated between different perspectives, ultimately unable to successfully unite them.

On the basis of what has been said on *platonitas*, it is possible to arrive at that famous definition found in the *Against Eutyches and Nestorius*. As Nédoncelle notes, it is not possible to speak in this regard of a real changement of opinion on Boethius' part, due to his interest in Christology. But it is impossible to comprehend Boethius' discussion without taking into consideration the importance the concept *persona* had in the Christological controversies. In any case, his approach remains rational, not religious, that is, not determined by the Christian faith.

How can the presence of two persons in the incarnated Christ be conceived? As we have seen above, Nestorius, on the one hand, saw the presence of the divine and the human persons, which nevertheless remained separate; Eutyches, on the other hand, united the two to the extent of forming a single one, in which the divine component could not but preponderate over the human one: for the incarnated Christ, therefore, the totality of the humanity assumed by him was not available.

Boethius distinguishes *persona* from *natura* and proposes his solution in chapter one. First of all, he observes, it is necessary to establish what *natura* means. We have read above the different definitions. What is significant here is that, according to Boethius, there cannot be a *persona* who is not a *natura* too, and that *persona* cannot be predicated regardless of *natura:* there is some nature that is not person, but not the other way around. *Natura*, in a word, is a broader term than *persona*. Moving from the universal to the particular, the meaning of *persona* must be determined by starting from that of nature:

Quoniam praeter naturam non potest esse persona quoniamque naturae aliae sunt substantiae, aliae accidentes et videmus personam in accidentibus non posse constitui (quis enim dicat ullam albedinis vel nigredinis vel magnitudinis esse personam?), relinquitur ergo ut personam in substantiis dici conveniat (2, p. 213,130 – 5).[130]

Only the fourth meaning of *natura*, which we saw above, can be taken into consideration when we speak of the two natures of Christ, that of God and that of man. Not even the accidents, such as whiteness or blackness, can be included in the category of *persona*. Each *persona* must be a substantial reality: therefore it cannot be said of either the unanimated substances like stones, or of those deprived of sensation like trees, or of the irrational ones like a horse, an ox, and other animals: the word can only be employed with regard to man, angel, and God.

130 "Since person cannot exist apart from nature and since natures are either substances or accidents and we see that person cannot consist in accidents (for who can say there is any person of whiteness or blackness or size?), it therefore remains that person is properly predicated of substances."

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On these assumptions, the universal realities must be excluded as well, such as the species 'man.' What is left, therefore, is only the individual, such as Cicero or Plato. From this it derives that:

si persona in solis substantiis est atque in his rationabilibus substantiaque omnis natura est nec in universalibus sed in individuis constat, reperta personae est definitio: naturae rationabilis individua substantia (3, p. 214,168 – 72).[131]

This definition became canonical in the Middle Ages, because it gave a clear meaning to a term that was sometimes deprived of it (to be essentially identified with the single), and sometimes appeared to be difficult to use in a theological context (as noticed by Augustine).[132] Yet, Boethius himself was not satisfied with the definition at which he had so laboriously arrived. *Persona* in Latin is connected with the meaning of 'mask' or 'role' in a play, a fruit of Boethius' learning provided by the grammatical tradition (3, p. 215,173 – 88),[133] and he considered it to be not functional. Boethius recognized that *persona* is a mould of the Greek *prosopon*, but in his opinion, his definition also included what the Greeks more opportunely designated as *hypostasis* to express the same concept of *naturae rationabilis individua substantia.* To introduce, therefore, *persona* into the philosophical or theological vocabulary is, in Boethius' opinion, not without inconveniences.

Then the definition in Greek follows, whose origin is not made explicit, but whose context[134] is certainly the Peripatetic one:[135] "αἱ οὐσίαι ἐν μὲν τοῖς καθόλου εἶναι δύνανται, ἐν δὲ τοῖς ἀτόμοις καὶ κατὰ μέρος μόνοις ὑφίστανται, *id est: essentiae in universalibus quidem esse possunt, in solis vero individuis et particularibus substant.*"[136] The species and the genera are part of the universals, which was not stated in the *In Isagogen comment.* I 11, CSEL, p. 167.[137] *Esse* and *substare* are not the same.

At this point, Boethius had achieved a convincing distinction of the Christological categories, although the reason why the two individual natures of Christ constitute a single person still required explanation. This problem

131 "Wherefore if person belongs to substances alone, and these rational, and if every substance is a nature, and exists not in universals but in individuals, we have found the definition of person: The individual substance of a rational nature." The statement "*reperta est definitio*" should mean that this is the result of Boethius' considerations on *persona* (Micaelli (1988), 47).

132 See Augustine, *De Trinitate* VII 4,7 – 6,11.

133 They had been the object of the definition of the grammarian Gavius Bassus, quoted by Aulus Gellius (*Noctes Atticae* V 7).

134 Micaelli supposes that such a definition is likely to be an invention of Boethius, who sought to assert in Greek his own thought (see (1981a), 331, (1988), 61 – 65). But if this is not a real citation, why did Boethius feel it necessary to present his sentence in Greek? Galonnier, too, is not convinced by Micaelli's hypothesis (cf. Boèce (2013), 236).

135 For instance, in the comment attributed to Alexander Aphrodisiensis, *On metaph.* Z 13 (CAG I 523 ss.) (a parallel proposed also by Chadwick (1981), 194).

136 "Essences can indeed exist in universals, but they subsist in individuals and particulars alone."

137 Cf. Schurr (1935), 33; Micaelli (1988), 64.

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was solved by a contemporary of Boethius, Leontius of Byzantium. Leontius conceived, similarly to Boethius, 'nature' to be something general and 'hypostasis' to be the concrete individual, and explains that a particular hypostasis for each individual nature cannot be asserted, because the individual nature might be the part of a general whole, so that it might be included in another hypostasis from which it draws its life and its reality, it would be, as it were, an 'enhypostatic' reality (*Against Eutyches and Nestorius*, PG 86,1273). So the person of the incarnated Christ finds its reality in the person of the Son.

In conclusion, Marenbon notes[138] that Boethius, although giving the impression through his reliance on the use of logic of intending to separate religion from philosophy, reaches a conclusion of immediate significance to the course of the doctrinal controversies of his age, accepting the formula that Christ is "in and from two natures." But the philosophical interest of CEN and its significance from the viewpoint of theological method is much greater than this conclusion may suggest.

2.2.9 After Boethius: *persona* according to Deacon Rusticus

Rusticus, a Roman deacon, wrote, around 553 – 564 AD, the *Disputatio contra Acephalos* (PL 67, 1169 – 1254) in defense of the diphysite Christology of Chalcedonian origin.[139] In this treatise, Rusticus dwells on the meaning and the definition of *persona.*[140]

He tries to define '*persona*' in two different ways. Rusticus begins his argument with the concept of individuality, and then proceeds to connect *persona* to the concept of 'existing per se.'[141] The first definition is proposed by Rusticus' interlocutor, a Monophysite: he connects the *persona* to individual nature: "*Omnis individua et rationalis natura persona est*" (1196 A). Rusticus refutes such a formula, underlining what, according to him, is the weak point in the definition, that is the excessively tight connection between *natura* and *persona:* due to such a connection, the formula of the Monophysites, that Christ is "*ex duabus naturis*" would mean "*ex duabus personis.*" If such were the case, the humanity of Christ would be an autonomous person, which contradicts the Monophysites' very own premises.

The second way of defining *persona* is proposed by Rusticus. He does not examine the concept of nature, but that of 'existing per se,' i.e. the '*subsistentia.*' Person, therefore, is a "*concursus eorum quae describunt subsistentiam rationalem*" (1238B), it is the whole of the characteristics which

138 Marenbon (2003b), 69.
139 Recently edited by Petri (2013).
140 Petri (2010), 128 – 30.
141 Cf. Grillmeier (1990), 819 – 22.

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are typical of a particular subject. The basis of his characteristics is the '*subsistentia:*' if a subject (a *subsistentia*) is missing, nothing can exist in relation to him. So the *persona* is not separable from the s*ubsistentia*, and thanks to this principle, Rusticus can solve the problem which the Monophysite definition had introduced: he concludes that Christ's humanity, since it does not have a proper basis in itself, but in the *Verbum*, cannot be defined as a *persona* (1238D).

The first definition of '*persona*,' that which based itself on the concept of '*natura*,' introduces the problem of the relation between Rusticus and Boethius. That definition is similar to Boethius': "*natura est cuiuslibet substantiae specificata proprietas, persona vero rationabilis naturae individua substantia.*" (4,270 – 2).

Such a connection between Boethius' definition and that of Rusticus, attributed to a Monophysite, induced scholars to presume that Rusticus is harshly criticizing Boethius. According to Manlio Simonetti, Rusticus intended to reject Boethius' definition, most likely because he thought that to presume a connection between *natura* and *persona* could help the Monophysites, who had founded their Christology upon the very principle that a nature without a person could not exist.[142]

In contrast, Micaelli argues that it is not justifiable to suppose an actual polemic against Boethius, but assumes that Rusticus wished to critically reconsider the terminology proposed by Boethius in its entirety.[143] It must not be forgotten that the heretic in the *Disputatio* proposes a definition that appears to be Boethian, but has the exact opposite meaning to that proposed by Boethius himself: Rusticus does not go so far as to employ the terms *natura* and *substantia* in that passage in the same way Boethius does.

Milano observes that the greatest difference between Rusticus' and Boethius' definition of *persona* consists in the fact that, while Boethius applies the definition to all rational beings (humans, angels, and God), Rusticus maintains that in these species the person has a different constitution.[144] The Monophysite adopts Boethius' doctrine: "*Dum enim tres existant confesse rationales naturae, id est Dei et militiarum coelestium et hominis, in iis unaquaeque individua natura persona est*" (1196B), and Rusticus objects: "*Etsi in reliquis rationalibus creaturis substantia individua persona est, sed non in Domino Christo*" (1196C).

142 Simonetti (1981), 259 – 89, at 282.
143 Micaelli (1995), 69 – 71.
144 Milano (1984), 340 – 1.

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2.2.10 *Persona* in the Trinity

Augustine was not entirely satisfied with the formula "*una substantia*" (a 'single substance') "*tres Personae*" ('three persons'), which went back to Tertullian's *Adversus Praxeam* and was characteristic of Western theology. He asserts that God is *essentia*, that is, being, while the plurality of the Father, Son, and Spirit is not a differentiation of being and substance, but of relationship, a relationship of equal or identical beings, of which no example can be found on earth. Father, Son, and Spirit are not words that separately express a substance, and the relationship of the Trinity is eternal and not accidental (*Trin.* V 5,6). In the same way, according to Boethius, 'substance' is not a predicate of God in the sense that it is the substratum of the other things, which are his attributes, but because he is the origin of all things. Boethius' affirmation (CEN 3, p. 218,260 – 4) coincides with what Augustine says (*Trin.* V 5,10), that God subsists and is a substance, but not a substratum.

Boethius also discusses the use of *persona* in the Trinitarian doctrine, following Augustine, whom he considered to be his master (*De sancta Trinitate*, praef. 167,1 – 3), and due to his adherence to Augustine's doctrine, he changes his opinion about its significance, expressed in *Contra Eutychen et Nestorium.* In the *De sancta Trinitate* he appears to be hesitant in the use of *persona*, just as Augustine had no difficulties using *persona* in Christology, but was uneasy to employ it in Trinitarian theology. As Nédoncelle and de Ghellinck have observed, Boethius uses '*persona*' on a total of ninety-six occasions, ninety times in the Christology, five in the *Consolation of Philosophy*, and only once in the tractate *On the Holy Trinity.*

In the Trinitarian context, Boethius maintains, all the Aristotelian categories undergo a radical change and can no longer be applied according to the human manner: "*At haec (*scl. *praedicamenta*) *cum quis in divinam verterit praedicationem, cuncta mutantur quae praedicari possunt.*" (4, p. 173,181 – 2)[145] But the real difficulty is that the meaning of *persona* designates a relation, as Augustine had said (the Father is a person because he is a relation to the Son and the Son a relation to the Father; the Holy Spirit, in turn, because he is the gift of the Father to the Son). Therefore *persona* cannot be used for God: "*Ad aliquid vero omnino non potest praedicari: nam substantia in illo non est vere substantia, sed ultra substantiam; item qualitas et cetera quae venire queunt*" (4, p. 173,182 – 5).[146] The names of Father, Son, and Holy Spirit cannot be predicated of the Trinity *secundum substantiam*, but according to a relative predication, i. e. '*ad aliquid*' (*Utrum Pater* 3, p. 184,46). As Augustine

145 "But when anyone turns these to predication of God, all the things that can be predicated are changed."

146 " Relation, for instance, cannot be predicated at all of God. For substance in Him is not really substantial but supersubstantial. So with quality and the other possible attributes."

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had taught, Boethius asserts that the word '*persona*' is relative, although he does not perceive in *persona* such an insufficiency in meaning as Augustine had, so that Augustine unwillingly had applied it to the Persons in Trinity.

Divine substance is infinitely simple and undivided while Persons are separate from each other (4, p. 184,55–9). In this assertion the influence of Augustine and his hesitation about Person in the Trinity is clear. Boethius maintains:

Quocirca si pater ac filius ad aliquid dicuntur nihilque aliud […] *differunt nisi sola relatione, relatio vero non praedicatur ad id de quo praedicatur* […] *non faciet alteritatem rerum, de qua dicitu*r […] *sed personarum* (*Trin.* 5, p. 178,310–6).[147]

But although in the Trinity there is more than one Person, this does not mean that the divine substance does not remain one and identical to itself: "*Ubi vero nulla est differentia, nulla omnino est pluralitas, quare nec numerus; igitur unitas tantum*" (*Trin.* 3, p. 172,123–4).[148] This is possible because in the Trinity Aristotelian categories are subject to a complete transformation and cannot be applied to humans (4, p. 173,181–5). Therefore relation, Augustine's doubts notwithstanding, does not produce an "*alteritas rerum*," but only "*personarum.*"

In conclusion, Boethius proceeds by recapitulating the theses of Augustine, but by examining them by a purely logical method he feels himself less constrained by issues of a theological nature.

2.3 The opuscula on the Trinity

The connection which holds together the first three opuscula (even if it is not apparent) was highlighted by Marenbon:[149] their fundamental argument is God, the predication of God and the Trinity. This corresponds, according to him, to Usener's and Chadwick's hypothesis mentioned above, that the "*capita dogmatica*" of the *Anecdoton Holderi* constitute the *De fide catholica*, so that "the book on the Holy Trinity also includes the second and third tractate." We concur with the opinion of these scholars.

The first and the second opusculum, that is, *De sancta Trinitate* and *Utrum Pater,* are closely related to each other. Both treat the problem of the Trinity, a discussion that had been exacerbated by the activities of Scythian monks in

147 "Wherefore if father and son are predicates of relation, and, as we have said, have no other difference but that of relation, but relation is not predicated with reference to that of which it is predicated […] it will not imply an otherness of the things of which is said, but […] an otherness of persons."

148 Cf. Nedoncelle (1955), 228–9.

149 Marenbon (2003b), 76–77, where one also may read a brief summary of the background of the three works.

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Rome armed with the writings of John Maxentius. The second tractate is theologically and philosophically less technical than the first and does not elaborate its arguments as extensively. In fact, the doctrine of *Utrum Pater* coincides exactly with the discussion of the second part of the *De sancta Trinitate* (chapters 4, 5, and 6), which treats, as Boethius writes, "the way in which everything is attributed to God" (3, p. 173,171 – 3), that is to say, a way to transpose to God natural denominations or to use for him the predications used by the sciences, in order to adapt them to theology.

For this reason it has been inferred that the work entitled *Utrum Pater*, which is the second in the order given by the editions and the shorter, chronologically precedes the first, the *De sancta Trinitate*. This is the view, for example, of Schurr and Chadwick,[150] who see in *Utrum Pater* a kind of rough draft or preparatory work for *De sancta Trinitate:* this Boethius would have presented to John the Deacon for approval.[151] Galonnier, on the contrary, emphasizes the dependence of the second on the first:[152] its '*quaestio*' is not incorporated into a wider context and completely lacks any deductions from the conclusions.[153] On the other hand, the logical pattern of meditation distinguishes it and makes it an independent work. In it Boethius writes that in God predication takes place "*alio modo*," specifically in relation to something (*ad aliquid*): in other words, God is not the Father in the same way that he is the Truth, namely according to the divine form that makes him what he is. Rather, he is and is called Father in relation to the Son. The same applies to the Son and the Holy Spirit. According to Galonnier, therefore, the second tractate preserves the character of an independent study and is posterior to the *De sancta Trinitate*. It consistently focuses on God, and does not evoke the affirmation that God is *ultra substantiam*, as we read in *De sancta Trinitate* (c. 4). Also the assertion that in God the categories do not have the same meaning as in the world is not retained in the second work, where no explicit opposition is found between God's being/existence and that of created things.[154]

2.3.1 *Utrum Pater*

This work, on a formal level, is incomplete, as it lacks both a prologue and a conclusion. Consequently, it is no wonder that, in terms of content, it is in

150 Schurr (1935), 97 – 104.
151 Chadwick (1981), 211 – 2.
152 Boèce, Galonnier (2007), 255 – 9.
153 Boèce, Galonnier (2007), 211.
154 That the *De sancta Trinitate* is later than the *Utrum Pater* is also rejected by Tisserand (cf. Tisserand (2003), 435 – 63, at 461). The *Utrum Pater,* he asserts, discusses only a part of the *De sancta Trinitate*, namely c. 5 and 6 (he follows completely Galonnier's thesis).

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almost every detail a mosaic of quotations from Augustine (cf. *Trin.* V 6,7 and CD XI 24).[155]

In fact, the tractate is based primarily on *Trin.* V 3,4, in which Augustine responds to the objections of the Arians. The Arians maintained that every predication relative to God is substantial. But the Father is not generated, while the Son is begotten. Consequently, if every predication relative to God is substantial, then the Father and the Son differ from each other in substance. Augustine's reply is (V 5,6) that a predication can be relative and not substantial, but on account of this not accidental as well.[156] Consequently, Boethius wonders whether an attribution to God takes place *substantialiter* with the words 'Father, Son, and Holy Spirit,' that is, if these three words refer to the essence of God or question the divine form. On the other hand, accidental predication is irrelevant when speaking of God. Boethius' *De sancta Trinitate* also insists on this Augustinian passage.

In the *Utrum Pater* (4, p. 184,55 – 7) Boethius asserts that "*si personae divisae sunt, substantia vero indivisa sit, necesse est quod vocabulum ex personis originem capit, id ad substantiam non pertinere*,"[157] although predication, though not stated *substantialiter*, is not made according to accident. In the *De sancta Trinitate* (4, p. 177,274 – 8) Boethius also maintains that what is attributed to God is identified immediately with his substance, because there is no dissociation between subject and predicate in him which would determine the attribution.[158] He distinguishes between essential or substantive categories (substance, quality, and quantity) and accidental categories (the other seven).[159] In fact, this distinction presupposes an equivalence already present in Aristotle and Augustine between *substantia* and *essentia.*

When we say 'God is Father,' 'God is Son,' 'God is Spirit,' God is different every time without being something else. This kind of predication does not express the essence of God by means of proper qualifications, considering each Person in himself, but rather indirectly, through correlative qualifications, which concern the Persons considered in their relation to one another. The second tractate sums up this whole problem, adding the following short conclusion: "The Trinity consists of the plurality of the Persons; the Unity in the simplicity of the substance" (*Utrum Pater* 3, p. 184,52 – 4).

155 Chadwick (1981), 211 – 3; Boèce, Galonnier (2007), 251. According to Chadwick, the conclusion of Boethius coincides with that of the Scythian monk Dionysius Exiguus in his letter of introduction to the translation of the book by Proclus, addressed to Felician and Pastor, and this parallel confirms that the fifth tractate supports Maxentius.

156 Cf. Marenbon (2003b), 77.

157 "Now if the Persons are separate, while the substance is undivided, it must needs be that that term which is derived from Persons does not belong to Substance."

158 Boèce, Galonnier (2007), 260 – 7.

159 A further sub-distinction has been proposed, as we shall see, by Marenbon: substance – quality and quantity – the other categories.

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Galonnier maintains a different opinion.[160] The first tractate, he says, reaches these conclusions by means of a homogeneous set of arguments (*Trin.* 5, p. 178,295 – 300 and p. 178, 307 – 179,316). In God, the relationship constitutes the number by generating the plurality, but preserves the unity, since it never reaches directly to the essence of the thing (5, p. 179, 325 – 9 and 6, p. 179, 333 – 180, 341). Explaining the category *ad aliquid*, Boethius introduces an explanation that is not present in Aristotle. To summarize Galonnier's conclusion, the nature of God is not different in its three manifestations (Father, Son, and Holy Spirit); it is only the relationship that differs. Only the Trinitarian relationship that goes from the same to the same establishes a number in God and sustains a plurality.

We would like to offer another observation regarding the content of *Utrum Pater.* In chapter one (1, p. 183,11 – 3) Boethius states that the Three are one single *substantia*, which is not made up of parts but is one *simpliciter.* Tester translates *simpliciter* as 'simply,' which is too generic, and Obertello translates it incorrectly as 'strictly speaking.'[161] In fact, we are dealing here with the concept of the absolute *simplicitas* of God typical of Neo-Platonism.[162]

2.3.2 *De sancta Trinitate*

The first tractate is clearly linked to the problem discussed in the second and to Augustine; Boethius himself refers to Augustine in the prologue (p. 167,30 – 2). First, Boethius demonstrates that the Persons of the Trinity cannot differ in number, because difference with respect to number is derived from accidents (c. 1), but God generates no accidents. Therefore Boethius examines how the predication of the various categories apply to God (c. 4), before turning to explain (c. 5 – 6) that to the Father and to the Son relative categories would have to be applied.

Boethius' scheme uses the distinction developed by Augustine (see the entire fifth book of the *De Trinitate*): God does not depend on others but solely on himself, while creatures have their attributes through participation. A difficulty, however, arises. In the scheme of Augustine, the contrast was between the predication of quality and quantity with respect to creatures, all of which are accidental and must be interpreted in terms of a participation, and the predications of God that are substantive. What was the reason for considering the possibility of an attribution of the *praedicamenta* to God? According to Marenbon,[163] it is not possible for God to exist and not have those attributes. Creatures have substantive attributes as well. Boethius, therefore,

160 Boèce, Galonnier (2007), 264 – 7.
161 Severino Boezio, Obertello/Ribet (1979), *ad locum.*
162 See below, p. 80 – 82.
163 Marenbon (2003b), 80 – 82.

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must explain how the relationship Socrates has with the attributes of his being a man differ from the attributes of his being, for example, white. To do this, Boethius uses an Aristotelian doctrine but in a Platonic context. Things are made up of matter and form. By 'form' Boethius means the essential form by which a thing is a thing of that particular kind: it is the form that makes the thing concretely what it is. Using the infinitive of the verb 'to be,' Boethius states: "*omne namque esse ex forma est*" (each being derives from the form):[164] things exist only because they are things of a particular type.

God, however, is not a concrete sum of matter and form. For this reason he "is one and is what he is, while other things exist differently" (2, p. 170,94 – 9). Nevertheless, since God is pure form, there is no distinction between him and his essential form, while Socrates is not his human nature. Another reason why God is what he is, is that in him there is nothing else different from what he is (2, p. 170,100 – 4). Both unity and essence coincide (2, p. 170,101).[165]

What is the relationship between God, who is form, and the essential forms that make things that what they are? According to Marenbon, at the end of the section (2, p. 171,115 – 7) Boethius explains that the forms in matter are improperly called 'forms,' because in reality they are images.[166] As a consequence, despite the fact that Boethius uses the plural here, a plurality of forms does not exist with an independent existence, but there is only one true form, which is God: outside of God only images exist, which cannot be separated from matter. The world of Boethius, therefore, appears to consist of God and of 'concrete wholes,' as Marenbon calls them, each with an immanent and essential form of the Aristotelian type, which should strictly speaking not be called 'form' but 'image.' These 'concrete wholes' are the foundation of the full range of accidents. The division of the branches of knowledge (2, p. 168,68–p. 169,83) is well suited to this metaphysical scheme: it probably derives from Aristotle (*Metaph.* VI 1026a6 – 19).

The definition at 2, p. 170,92 – 3: "*sed divina substantia sine materia forma est, atque ideo unum, et est id quod est*"[167] can be connected to Augustine. According to Micaelli,[168] it could be a reworking of Augustine's *Sermo* 117,3: God is "*forma non formata, sed forma omnium formatorum, forma incommutabilis, sine lapsu, sine defectu, sine tempore, sine loco, superans*

164 In our edition, 169,83.

165 Chadwick notes (1981, 215) that Boethius here does not use the formula "*id quod est*," as in the *De hebdomadibus*, to express existence in opposition to essence."The fluctuation of the terminology," he writes, "may reflect a certain lack of clarity on the argument as a whole. Boethius does not show how God is pure form as opposed to other forms in which there is no material element." But it is not sure that "*id quod est*" must be interpreted as (metaphysical) 'existence' (see Hadot's interpretation, p. 74 – 76).

166 This is the distinction commonly made by Platonists between idea and *eidos enhylos*, between transcendent form and form in matter.

167 "But the Divine Substance is form without matter, and is therefore one, and is its own essence."

168 Micaelli (1988), 108 – 9, (1995), 82 – 84.

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omnia".[169] Augustine's doctrine reappears in the *Consolatio* (III metrum IX, 5–6): In God there is imbedded the *summi forma boni.* And the statement in *De trinitate* about the being of God as "*forma sine materia*" agrees with two axioms of the *De hebdomadibus* (axiom VII, which refers to God: "*omne simplex esse suum et id quod est unum habet*,"[170] and axiom VIII: "*Omni composito aliud est esse aliud ipsum est*," which refers to created things).[171]

Then *De sancta Trinitate* (c. 3) proceeds to discuss the problem of the numerical difference. Boethius asserts that it is the variety of accidents that produces the numerical difference, since the forms do not have accidents. Yet any numerical difference within the Trinity is excluded. To say the same thing three times is not to say that there are three things: 'sun, sun, and sun' is not to say that there are three suns; God the Father, God the Son, God the Spirit does not mean to say that there are three gods. This statement, however, points to the difficulty, because 'God the Father,' 'God the Son,' and 'God the Spirit' is not the same expression as 'sun, sun, sun,' nor are they synonyms.

In chapter four Boethius examines the question of whether it is legitimate to use categories with respect to God.[172] His familiarity with Aristotle's categories is well known:

Aristoteles […] *decem praedicamenta constituens, ad quae ipsa infinita multitudo significantium vocum referri debeat, terminavit* […] *Ergo decem praedicamenta quae dicimus infinitarum in vocibus significationum genera sunt, sed quoniam omnis vocum significatio de rebus est, quae voce significantur in eo quod significantes sunt, genera rerum necessario significabunt* (*In categorias*, PL 64,159C).[173]

But in *De Trinitate* he refers the *praedicamenta* to God, in order to demonstrate that such an application is impossible. He explains that there is a difference between the predication of the category of substance, the predication of the two categories of quality and quantity, and the predication of the other categories of accidents. Regarding the categories of quality and quantity, the explanation is exactly that of Augustine: to say that God is just or

169 "God is a form which did not receive any form, but is the form of all things which have received a form: a form not subject to change, free from decadence, from defect, from time and place, above all things." God is the supreme form, which did not receive a form, as it is the case for material things; the definitions of transcendence of God follow this statement.

170 "Every simple thing possesses as a unity its existence and its particular being."

171 Micaelli (1988), 102, (1995), 80–84 (important observations on the concept of *forma* in Boethius, Marius Victorinus, and Augustine).

172 Chadwick (1981), 216–7. The assertion that the ten Aristotelian categories do not fit the realm of the supersensible comes from Plotinus (V 10; VI 2,3,7). Plotinus' assertion is considered an essential fact by Augustine (*Conf.* VI 16,28–9 and *Trin.* V 8,9).

173 "Aristotle, introducing ten categories, stated the principles the infinite multitude of meaningful words must refer to […] Therefore the so-called categories are the genres of the infinite meanings which are contained in the words, but since every meaning has its peculiar object, which is revealed by the words just because the words are meaningful, categories necessarily reveal the genres of things."

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great does not mean that God has this quality or that quantity, but that he is justice and greatness in himself. Boethius elaborates this doctrine of Augustine in three ways. First, *substantia:* its meaning as explained in CEN (3, p. 218,260 – 4), was to be the foundation of the accidents, a meaning that will not be explored any further here. More important, rather, is the fact that regarding God, any negation, including that of the category of substance, is true. This is conform to the negative theology of Neo-Platonism, although Boethius does not develop this interpretation much further, because he simply says (*Trin.* 4, p. 174,189 – 90): "*Cum vero 'iustus'* [*dicimus*]*, qualitatem quidem, sed non accidentem, sed eam quae sit substantia sed ultra substantiam.*"[174] Given this pattern, Boethius wants to say that even in the category of substance there is a difference between predication regarding God and predication regarding creatures (4, p. 174,201 – 7). It is wrong to state that man, that is, a 'concrete whole',[175] is a substance (p. 174,203 – 5), whereas God, who is what he is, is rightly called 'substance' (p. 174,206 – 7).

Leaving aside, for now, the categories of the relationship (which are so important for the definition of *persona* in Trinity), in the following discussion Boethius examines the attributes of the remaining six categories (*Trin.* 4, p. 175,216–p. 177,68). He concludes by observing that while a predication of substance, quality, and quantity emphasize the thing to which they apply and show that it is something, the predications of the other six categories show only the circumstances of the thing (4, p. 177,270 – 4). Boethius goes so far as to say, throughout chapter four, that the attributes of these six categories are not predicates at all either of God or of other beings ("*de ceteris*," 4, p. 175,216 – 7): this means, I suppose, that those categories are not predicated *in the same way.*

When in the fifth chapter Boethius finally comes to address the relationship, it is clear that these predications are extrinsic, because one of the characteristics of extrinsic predicates is not to concern the things of which they speak, but their relationship with one another.[176] For this reason they cannot change or alter at all any essence (5, p. 178,308 – 10). It follows that Father, Son, and Holy Spirit differ only in the relative predication which can be made about them, and therefore cannot be turned into different *essentiae.* Boethius concludes (6, p. 179,333 – 180,9) that in God there is number, which is Trinity, because the relationship implies that there is more than one, exactly

174 "When we say of him 'He is just,' we do indeed mention a quality, but not an accidental quality – rather such as is substantial and, in fact, supersubstantial."

175 I employ here Marenbon's definition of the 'concrete being' (*id quod est*), which will be considered below (pp. 74 – 76). Man certainly is a 'concrete whole', but he cannot be said to be a real substance, since in real substance being and essence coincide. As Boethius says in 2,100 – 101, "*quod vero non est ex hoc atque hoc, sed tantum est hoc, illud vere est id quod est*" ("that on the other end which does not consist of This and That, but is only This, is really its own essence"). Man consists of This and That, because he is a composite, while God is simply This – again, the simplicity of God.

176 Cf. Marenbon (2003b), 86.

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that which is the subject of the relationship. There is, however, also unity, because (6, p. 180,345 – 53):

Sane sciendum est non semper talem esse relativam praedicationem ut semper ad differens praedicetur, ut est servus ad dominum: differunt enim. Nam omne aequale aequali aequale est et simile simili simile est et idem ei quod est idem idem est; et similis est relatio in Trinitate Patris ad Filium et utriusque ad Spiritum Sanctum, ut eius quod est idem ad id quod est idem. Quod si id in cunctis aliis rebus non potest inveniri, facit hoc cognata caducis rebus alteritas.[177]

In conclusion, Boethius detects God's most profound mystery: in God, contrary to any logic, there is a relation of numbers deprived of any plurality of substance: this is typically Augustinian.[178] The *De sancta Trinitate* can be considered an ambitious and successful attempt to build a doctrine based on Augustine's discussion of God and of predication. Augustine had offered a solution essentially *ad hoc*, making of the relationships in God neither substantial nor accidental predications, while Boethius traces his fundamental distinction between intrinsic predications (of substance, quality, and quantity) and those which are extrinsic.[179]

At the end, two observations remain. God is "*pulcherrimum fortissimumque, quia nullo nititur*"[180] (2, p. 170,101 – 2). Such a definition of the divine nature is confirmed by *Consolatio* III, metrum IX 7, where it is stated that God is "*pulcherrimus ipse*," and, as such, creates a "*pulcherrimus mundus.*" But this 'beauty' is that of goodness, as may be gathered from a passage from the *Institutio Arithmetica* (I 32,1): "*bonitas definita et sub scientiam cadens animoque semper imitabilis et perceptibilis prima natura est et suae substantiae decore perpetua*".[181] Another doctrine foreshadowing the *Consolatio* is the distinction, which goes back to Plato's *Timaeus*, between time and eternity: the discussion in *De sancta Trinitate* 4, p. 176,240 – 8

177 "One must not forget that relative predication is not always such that it is always predicated with reference to something different, as slave is with reference to master; for they are different. For equals are equal, likes are like, identicals are identical, each with the other; and the relation in the Trinity of Father to Son, and of both to Holy Spirit is like a relation of identicals. But if a relation of this kind cannot be found in all other things, this is because of the otherness natural to all perishable, transitory objects."

178 Cf. Tisserand (2003), 459.

179 Cf. Marenbon (2003b), 86 – 87.

180 " altogether beautiful and stable because it does not depend upon anything."

181 "The first nature is definite goodness which can be apprehended by science, and is the object of imitation and perception of man and is eternal in the beauty of its substance." The definition of Boethius' first work is very Platonic (knowledge of God and ὁμοίωσις θεῷ are possibile to man), while the treatise on the Holy Trinity is more hesitant and does not assert these possibilities with a similar confidence.

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corresponds to that of *Consolatio* III, metrum IX 2 – 3 ("*qui tempus ab aevo ire iubes*"[182]) and to that of V 6.

2.4 *De hebdomadibus*

The *De hebdomadibus* is renowned both for its title and for its concatenation of the arguments *more geometrico*, as well as its metaphysics of being. It should first be noted that the title *De hebdomadibus* is incorrect: it is only found in later manuscripts and printed editions, the real title being "*Quomodo substantiae in eo quod sint bonae sint cum non sint substantialia bona.*"[183] It derives from an obscure expression, which appears to refer to a work previously written by Boethius, indeed the "*Hebdomades nostrae*" (p. 186,1): Boethius, most likely addressing John the Deacon, says:

Postulas ut ex Hebdomadibus nostris eius quaestionis obscuritatem […] *digeram et paulo evidentius monstrem* […] *Hebdomadas vero ego mihi ipse commentor potiusque ad memoriam meam speculata conservo quam cuiquam participo* [etc].[184]

Chadwick focuses on the history of the term *hebdomas* and indicates the presence of the number seven in the thought of Syrianus and Proclus.[185] But this remains inconclusive. The problem is how to understand the words "*hebdomades nostrae.*" Most convincing is his proposal: "A simple solution would be that the axioms presented in the tractate and in the printed editions are nine, while Boethius really wanted to count seven only, in so far as the first was as a simple beginner's example, and the eighth was mistakenly divided into two." Chadwick's proposal to assume seven axioms instead of nine in this work has also been taken up by H. Merle, J.-Y. Guillaumin, and A. Tisserand.[186] Yet the demonstrations given by him are not cogent,[187] and Galonnier, too, rightly believes that one cannot exclude any of the axioms.[188] The problem is that Boethius speaks of "*hebdomades nostrae*," that is, as if it were another doctrine (or another work) of his and not of the '*hebdomades*' (i. e. the seven in number) of axioms in the present work. Since it has been supposed that the *De*

182 "You, God, who bid time to come from eternity" (my translation; Tester translates: "who bid time ever move," which does not correspond to the *Timaeus*).

183 "How substances are good in virtue of their existence without being substantial goods."

184 "You ask me to state and explain somewhat more clearly that obscure question in my *Hebdomads.* […] But I think over my *Hebdomads* with myself, and I keep my speculations in my own memory rather than share them with any of those [etc]."

185 Chadwick (1981), 203.

186 Cf. Boèce, Merle (1991), 88 – 91; Boèce, J.-Y. Guillaumin (1995), XX, n. 38; Boèce, Tisserand (2000), 217 – 8.

187 Marenbon (2003b), 195 – 6, n. 33.

188 Boèce, Galonnier (2007), 305. Besides, who was it that erroneously divided into two (seven and eight) the seventh axiom? And why?

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hebdomadibus, as is shown by its beginning, is a reply to John the Deacon to clarify an obscure point contained in a work called 'hebdomades,' it would seem to be a part of a field of research by Boethius that has been lost. The words of Boethius, however, cannot be interpreted as identifying a work not otherwise attested, since he says that he keeps his '*hebdomades*' memorized and thinks about them on his own, rather than share their content with ignorant people.[189]

Also, Marenbon[190] notes that one reason why Boethius cannot have made reference to an earlier work is that the word is used in a different way on the two occasions in which it is mentioned: first "*ex hebdomadibus nostris*," which is an ablative plural of '*hebdomas*,' and later "*hebdomadas*," which is the accusative plural of '*hebdomada*' of the first declension. If it were a title, Boethius would have used the same word. The difficulty of the title has given rise to various interpretations in medieval philosophers as well, with whom Galonnier is inclined to concur.[191] He agrees with Gilbert de la Porrée, according to whom '*hebdomas*' should mean 'tractate,' *quaestio*.[192] But this is not Boethius' use.

Jean Luc Solère proposed another interpretation of the '*hebdomadae*,' recurring to its philosophical meaning, which he considers to be particularly important in Proclus' philosophy.[193] In his opinion the symbolic meaning of the word must be determined. According to Proclus (*Tim.* II, p. 94,30 – 95,7), the '*heptàs*' is the light which comes from the Intellect, and for this reason the cosmic Intellect is monadic and heptadic at the same time. The *hebdomades* therefore are the principle of knowledge in humans, the end of the procession of the intelligibles, and therefore the result of a divine enlightenment. According to this meaning, Boethius speaks of the intelligibles or the intellections which are present in his mind. The evident axioms deserve to be called this way, and they are the universal rules permitting us to solve metaphysical problems. As far as the word has to do with Boethius, "en tant qu'elles sont dispensées par Athéna – Philosophie, les hebdomades dont parle Boèce (definies aussi comme des ennoiai) pourraient être simplement une manière un peu précieuse, à tout le moins codée, destinée aux membres d'un cénacle néoplatonisant, de designer des thèses philosophiques, des 'philosophèmes'." Boethius himself provides the Latin equivalent of *hebdomas:* '*speculata*' ("*Hebdomadas vero ego mihi ipse commentor potiusque ad*

189 Marenbon's proposed solution (2003b, 87—88) remains speculative and unclear: perhaps John had used the term *hebdomades* ironically, as an example of a pretentious title for a philosophical tractate, without Boethius having concealed any major philosophical work; it is as if we were to ask a friend with philosophical pretensions whether he had discussed the topic in his '*Critica*' or in his '*Tractatus*.'

190 Marenbon (2003b), 195, n. 32.

191 Boèce, Galonnier (2007), 301 – 3.

192 Boèce, Galonnier (2007), 307.

193 Solère (2003), 55 – 110, at 98, 100 – 1, 105.

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memoriam meam speculata conservo"). But '*speculata*' does not refer to '*hebdomades:*' it is the object of Boethius' reasoning: "I keep my speculations," Tester translates. The whole interpretation is surely convoluted!

The axioms, then, seem to propose the common metaphysical background and the terminology employed for its arguments, rather than providing the reader with axioms of an exhaustive and rigorous sense. According to Chadwick, the third tractate of Boethius has taught the Latin West, more than any other work, the method of the axiom, that is the way to analyze an argument and to make explicit the basic assumptions and the definitions upon which it bases its cogency.[194] The general appearance of the work is that of a strictly philosophical tractate, and not specifically Christian: Galonnier also notes that the tractate gives the impression of carefully avoiding all kinship with Christian theology.[195] But this is not convincing. The *De hebdomadibus* must be regarded as a theological tractate just like the *Consolatio*, even without any apparent explicit references to Christian themes, because for Boethius there are no rigid separations between theology and philosophy: they are united by having God as the supreme object of knowledge and his relationship with the world. Neoplatonism and Christian thought are not separated.

This work is known for its density of thought and its concise style, which the author consciously sought.[196] The argument is introduced only after Boethius has established a set of axioms that are used to solve it: everything that exists is good, because it tends toward the good, and like things tend toward those that are alike. So that which tends towards goodness is itself good. Yet, is it good through its participation in the good or in its substance? The relationship between the first two tractates and the third is evident. Like the first two, the third deals with a difficulty regarding the predication of God, even if here Boethius apparently discusses only the predication of creatures. In addition, the metaphysical system presented in the *De hebdomadibus* corresponds, though refined, to that of *De sancta Trinitate.* Although the first two tractates deal with specific problems of Christian doctrine, whereas the third with more general themes, such a difference is not decisive: the *De hebdomadibus* is connected by the same scope of issues in the other two tractates, but since it does not address a specifically Christian doctrine, that of the Trinity, its language is more specifically philosophical.

The structure of *De hebdomadibus* and Boethius' method have been excellently analyzed by L.M. de Rijk.[197] Boethius' method consists in employing four distictions: a) the distinction between a thing as a whole ("*id quod est*") and that which causes its existence (the "*forma essendi*" or the

194 Chadwick (1981), 210.

195 Boèce, Galonnier (2007), 289.

196 As he himself asserts in the introduction to the work, acknowledging the difficulty of the problem and the attempt to resolve it in mathematical form.

197 De Rijk (1981), 141 – 56, at 152 – 3.

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"*ipsum esse*"): this is stated in axioms II, IV, and VIII; b) the distinction between simply being ("*esse*") and being something ("*esse aliquid*"): axiom V; c) distinction between being something ("*esse aliquid tantum*") and being something thanks to its intrinsic being ("*esse aliquid in eo quod est*"): axioms V and VI; d) distinction between "*IPSUM ESSE*" ("*BONUM ESSE*"),[198] which is implicit in axiom V and developed in lines 92 – 8, Rand-Tester (= 102 – 7, Moreschini).

2.4.1 *Forma essendi*

The second axiom reads:

Diversum est esse et id quod est: ipsum enim esse nondum est, at vero quod est, accepta essendi forma est atque consistit.[199]

This axiom is famous and has proven to be the crux for interpreters. Hadot, basing his argument on the anonymous *Commentary* on Plato's *Parmenides*, which he considered to be Porphyrian, asserts that '*esse*' corresponds to 'being' and '*id quod est*' to 'that which exists,' i. e. an opposition between being in its absoluteness ("l'être en soi, absolument universel et indeterminé") and the concrete being ("l'être de quelque chose"). This corresponds to the Platonic doctrine of the One and the Being (hypotheses I and II of the *Parmenide*s) and to Porphyry's distinction between εἶναι and ὄν. The formula "*forma essendi*" means the pure alterity, which characterizes the single being, derived from the transcendent Being (the "être reçu et derivé"). It is the distinction asserted by Marius Victorinus (*Adv. Arium* II 4, p. 177,30 – 1): "*omne enim quod est* ὄν, *esse est cum forma.*"[200]

Obertello concurs substantially with Hadot.[201] The existing thing, he asserts, always has a particular form: being is not a form, but the form is added to being, as Victorinus stated, and gives it the possibility of being perceived. If being does not yet exist, this means that it does not exist as particular form, for instance a mountain or the sun. That which is, on the contrary, is and continues to be when it has received the form of being. Indeterminate and original being does not yet exist as particular thing, but gives to the particular and determined thing the quality of being. The *ipsum esse per se* is nothing, i. e. nothing concretely determined, but gives concrete things the form of being.

198 The capital letters are intended to signify the transcendence of the being and of the good ("l'expression se rapporte à Dieu": p. 154).

199 "'*Esse*' and that which is are distinct: '*esse*' itself is not yet, but that which is, having taken the form of being, is and consists." – transl. J. Marenbon (2003b), 88.

200 "For *on* (the existent) is 'to be' but determined by a certain form" (or: "all that is existent is to be but determined by a certain form").

201 Obertello (1974), 644 – 56, at 645 – 6. On the definition of *forma essendi* cf. also Galonnier (Boèce (2007), 340 – 1), who basically follows Hadot. See p. 342 for examples drawn from the *Perihermeneias.*

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L.M. de Rijk also proposed this solution:[202] he correctly opposes G. Schrimpf,[203] who mainly attributed to *ipsum esse* the meaning of "being in itself," or "being substantially." De Rijk, in fact, admitted[204] that the '*ipsum esse*' could be both the '*IPSUM ESSE*' (that is, being as such, being in itself, the pure Being) and the being of corruptible things.[205] He distinguishes between 'ipsum esse,' which is proper of the "ce qui est" ('*id quod est*'), from the '*IPSUM ESSE*,' which can be applied to God, as in *De hebdomadibus* 122 – 23, Stewart-Rand (= 112 – 4, Moreschini): "*secundum vero bonum quoniam ex eo fluxit cuius ipsum esse bonum est, ipsum quoque bonum est*"[206] and 149 – 50 (= 139 – 40, Moreschini): "*cum illud ipsum bonum primum et ipsum esse sit et ipsum bonum et ipsum esse bonum*".[207] So the *forma essendi* means that "l'immanence de la forme participée assure l'être à la chose périssable, lequel est tout à fait différent de l'être absolu et parfait."

Not unlike de Rijk, Gersh, too, considers the '*ipsum esse*' as signifying God, that is, understands it as "existence itself." In fact, Boethius applies to God the characteristics of the second hypothesis of Plato's *Parmenides* and of Plotinus' second hypostasis, which contains 'being' in the sense of Porphyry.[208]

Chadwick seems to have accepted Hadot's distinction, but has abandoned any metaphysical implication. Boethius, he states, "begins from the distinction between simple being (*esse*) and existence (*id quod est*).[209] Being in itself, as an abstract concept, is prior to existence. Existence (*quod est*) is and exists as soon as it has received the form of being, the "*forma essendi*".[210]

Micaelli has dealt with the formula '*forma essendi*' on two occasions. The first time, he accepts de Rijk's interpretation that Boethius intends to underline the difference between the 'form of being' (*forma essendi*), considered absolutely, and the *substratum* (*ens:* that which is).[211] He agrees with de Rijk, however, that Boethius' text exhibits a semantic ambiguity, since the *ipsum esse* of material and perishable things should be interpreted as a participation in Being-in-itself ('*IPSUM ESSE*'). Therefore the *ipsum esse* of the material thing is the *forma* of being (*forma essendi*) considered in its immanence, while the '*IPSUM ESSE*' is the *forma* of the transcendent Being, or transcendence itself. Micaelli re-examines the problem in a later study.[212] He objects that if one wishes to interpret the second axiom according to Hadot,

202 De Rijk (1981), particularly at 154 – 5.
203 Schrimpf (1966), in particular 13 – 33.
204 De Rijk (1981), 155.
205 Ibid., 154.
206 "But the secondary good, since it has derived from that whose existence is itself good, is itself also good."
207 "[…] while that very first good is existence itself and good itself and good existence itself."
208 Gersh (1986), 680 – 1.
209 Why not 'existent'?
210 Chadwick (1981), 209.
211 Micaelli (1988), 111 – 5.
212 Micaelli (1995), 87 – 94.

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one must assert that pure being according to Boethius exists without any qualification. Such a being should be the origin of every limited and concrete being, and this supposition should agree with the doctrine of God, who "*est enim et maxime ipse est, a quo omnium esse proficiscitur*"[213] (CEN 3,251 – 2). But Boethius never compares God to an indeterminate and pure being; his works on logic display the tendency, more Aristotelian than Platonic, to deny that being is something that exists above all. The '*ipsum esse*' can be identified with the '*forma*' of God, of which Boethius speaks in the *De sancta Trinitate* (2, p. 170,93 – 106). But this objection could be directed at de Rijk as well, who distinguishes between '*esse*' and '*IPSUM ESSE.*'

Marenbon also rightly dissociates himself from Hadot's interpretation of the second axiom and the distinction between *esse* and *id quod est* as if they were two different means of being.[214] According to Marenbon, '*esse*' signifies the immanent form that makes a thing what it is, while in *De sancta Trinitate*, Boethius had stated that such a form should really be called 'image' (*imago*, for example, the form 'humanity' that makes Socrates a man). Granted, in that tractate Boethius had said that every *esse* is the product of a form, in *De hebdomadibus* he does not so much change the meaning of *esse*, but rather extends it with a synecdoche that is an effect in place of its cause: with "*id quod est*" Boethius indicates the 'concrete whole,' for example, Socrates. The immanent forms exist only in the 'concrete wholes' that they inform: hence the observation that "*ipsum esse* does not exist yet," and "having taken the form of being" means "having taken the form that, by rendering the thing that which it is, allows it to exist."

In conclusion, the distinction between being and that which exists has recently been interpreted – correctly in our opinion – without any reference to transcendence. Marenbon's interpretation is by far the best.

2.4.2 Participation in God

The typically Platonic concept of the 'participation' of a lower in a higher reality, well known especially for the doctrine of ideas in which the sensible world participates to varying degrees was considered obvious in the Platonic schools of the Imperial age, along with its interpretation of the two levels of reality. We can also observe that participation can indicate the mutual relationships of various realities among themselves, manifest in, for example, the significantly different uses of the verb μετέχειν and its analogues in Neo-Platonism. A quick survey, by no means exhaustive, of some representative works by Proclus and Ammonius, has allowed us to assess a wide range in the use of the term, at times with a weak meaning (similar to that of κοινωνεῖν),

213 "For he is and is especially that from which proceeds the being of all things".
214 Marenbon (2003b), 88 – 89.

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which we will disregard here, at times with more interesting meanings. Our focus is directed at the latter. The term μετέχειν is also used in the field of logic, and is substantially equivalent to κατηγορεῖσθαι, as Hadot observed.[215] Ammonius did not make frequent use of this word. In fact, in his commentary on the *Categories* Ammonius presents at least two examples of this meaning 'to participate:' 'common' (κοινόν), he asserts, is used in four ways: either with the meaning of 'participated without division' (ἀδιαίρετον μεθεκτόν), such as that of 'animal:' in fact we all partake of it (μετέχομεν) without dividing it; or using that of 'participation with division,' as in the case of the field (that is to say, here μετέχειν is used in the same sense as κοινωνεῖν, *Categ.*, p. 19,10 – 11, Busse). Another example: division according to πρός τι can be according to μετέχον or according to μετεχόμενον, just as one who knows is called 'a knower' inasmuch as he participates in knowledge (*Categ.*, p. 67,21 – 2): here, obviously, the term 'participation' has a purely logical meaning. Explicit is the equivalence of terms μετέχειν and κατηγορεῖσθαι in *De interpr.*, p. 53,25: When we predicate the color white of man, the predication will be according to nature, and the predicate will logically be called 'word' (ῥῆμα), as it indicates what man participates in and which is predicated of him according to nature, inasmuch as that is the subject (κατηγορεῖσθαι αὐτοῦ πεφυκὸς ὡς ὑποκειμένου).

In Proclus the use of the term 'participation' is often quite free, with meanings that fall within the metaphysical and religious sphere. The soul possesses the quality of belonging to another, inasmuch as it is shared, and that of belonging to itself, inasmuch as it does not bend towards the participant and thus also acts as the father of the individual soul (*Comm. Tim.* I 10,28). The *Timaeus*, in the opinion of Iamblichus which Proclus relates, shows how beings participate in the demiurgic providence, the *Parmenides* shows instead how beings participate in uniform existence (*Comm. Tim.* I 13,25). Moreover (*Comm. Resp.* I 116,8), according to Syrianus, in the gods good and truth are united, while they are often divided in those who participate in the gods. Neither is the concept of 'participation in God' missing from Proclus, although normally it appears only in a context relevant to theurgy: though it is only one god in which one participates, the intellect participates in one way, the rational soul in another, the imagination in yet another, and the sensory faculty in a different way as well (*Comm. Resp.* I 111,19); Zeus awakens the divine love within himself, according to which he also fills with good those beings who partake of him directly: the terminology (τὰ προσεχῶς αὐτοῦ μετέχοντα) shows that the use of 'participation' here (*Comm. Resp.* I 134,30) is rather free, neither strict nor attentive to the implications it may entail. Elsewhere Proclus is more technical and exact: in *Element.* 128 he asserts that "every god, when participated by beings of an order relatively near to him, is participated directly (ἀμέσως); when by those

215 P. Hadot (1970), 143 – 56, at 149, n. 34.

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more remote, indirectly through a varying number of intermediate principles (διὰ μέσων ἢ ἐλαττόνων ἢ πλειόνων τινῶν)." The same distinction between a direct and an intermediate participation in the gods is proposed in *Element.* 129 and 139.[216]

2.4.3 Participation in God according to Boethius

In Boethius we find the same variety of meanings, at times in logic, at times in metaphysics. In fact, the participation of the species in the genus is one instance, another the participation of one substance in a superior substance. The term is used frequently in Boethius' logic, and with the same meanings as in Ammonius, which probably goes back to Porphyry. A cursory reading of some logical works of Boethius confirms this. Let two examples suffice here. Difference and species have a common characteristic, Boethius asserts, because the species expands itself (*se committit*) to the individuals it contains, and individuals participate in the species in the same way:

namque omnes homines aequaliter homines sunt et hominis participatione aeque participant. Eodem modo etiam differentia: namque omnes homines aequaliter rationales sunt, et rationabilitate, quae est differentia, omnes qui ratione participant, aeque participant (*Isag. Porph. comm.* I, *ed. prima* II 20, p. 120,4–8, Schepss-Brandt).[217]

More interesting is the case in which Boethius asserts that the whiteness that can be observed in a particular patch of snow is not simply (*communiter*) an accident, but is the accident which is peculiar to the snow we see. Therefore, from the fact that whiteness could have been predicated generally (since it can be said of many, such as a white man, a white horse, a white patch of snow), "*factum est ut de una tantum nive praedicari illud album possit cuius participatione ipsum quoque factum est singulare*" (scl. *album*)[218] (ibid., *editio secunda* II 5, p. 185,14–16). This means that the particular exists ("*factum est*") inasmuch as it participates in the universal, and the concrete object exists insofar as it participates in the *eidos.* Here Boethius seems to anticipate one of the postulates of the *De hebdomadibus:* the sixth, in fact, states: "*omne quod participat, eo quod est esse, ut sit; alio vero participat, ut aliquid sit*" (188,37).[219]

216 My thanks to Prof. Ilinca Tanaseanu-Döbler for indicating the passages of Proclus' *Elementatio.* I quote the translation of Dodds (1963).

217 "Men are all in the same way men, and all equally participate in the participation of man [which is the species]. The same can be said for difference: all men are equally reasonable, and all men, who participate in reason, equally participate in rationality, which constitutes the difference."

218 "It happens that the white can be predicated only of one [patch of] snow, because the white itself was also rendered singular by its [i.e., the patch of snow's] participation in it."

219 This is the text, typical in its brevity and its ideas, specifically intended by the author as presented in our edition recently published (2000, ²2005). Tester's translation runs as follows:

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In order to be white, the particular white needs to participate in the universal white, just as all that is participates in being in order to be, and participates in something else in order to be something else. The problem arises when Boethius will no longer speak of man participating in the universal, but in God. This axiom 'anticipates' what the *Consolatio* attempts to resolve, because the participation Boethius examines in the *De hebdomadibus* is the eventual participation of things in God, in being; it is the foundation and cause of their successive tending towards God and so becoming good, whereas the topic discussed in the *Consolatio* is the participation of things in God in order to be good. They indicate two different moments in a 'before' and an 'after' on a logical level: if the *Consolatio* discusses the successive moment, the *De hebdomadibus* examines the preceding: what is the essence of things before they tend towards (and thus participate in) God?

Neither alternative (good through participation or good in substance) is acceptable: things are good neither through participation, because if this were the case they would not be good in themselves, in their being; nor are they good in substance, because then their being would coincide with the good, and therefore all would be God (in God being and goodness coincide because God is *simplex*), which is a sacrilegious statement. In the first case, if things are good through participation they must already exist in order to participate, according to the sixth axiom, and in that case things would not be good, but would be participating in the good; in the second case, if they were good in substance they would have an identity between being and goodness, and in that case they would be *simplicia*, according to the seventh and eighth axiom, and therefore equivalent to God (189,55 – 61).

This does not mean, of course, that the statement that things are good is not true, because if that were the case the assertion of the ninth axiom, that things tend to participate in what is similar, i. e. in the good, would be rejected. It does mean that the problem must be solved by re-examining certain axioms that Boethius presents in the first part of his work.

Let us consider how things might be good, if they were not derived[220] ("*defluxissent*") from the "*primum bonum*" (190,86 – 8). If this is the case, their

"Everything that is participates in absolute being, in order to exist; but it participates in something else in order to be something", which presupposes Rand's text: "*omne quod est, participat eo quod est esse*" etc. But at p. 42 in a note (supposedly by Rand) it is said that *est* is omitted by the best manuscripts: why not translate accordingly? Besides, I do not accept the addition of "absolute," and "everything that is". Rightly MacDonald (1988), 245 – 79, who follows de Rijk's opinion (275, cf. de Rijk 1981, 152), but he adds a useless "*alio vero <in aliquot>*", translating: "Everything which participates in being so that it exists participates in something else so that it is something." I propose: "Everything which participates, (participates) in being, in order to be etc.". On the *De hebdomadibus* cf. also Micaelli (1995), 94 – 126.

220 This is Tester's translation. The term is undoubtedly ambiguous (and deliberately so, we would say, given the meaning it has: see above, p. 49, and later); Ribet translates it 'result' (cf. Severino Boezio (1979), *ad locum*). My exposition of the passage presents the fact as real, not as a hypothesis as the Latin text does, because it amounts to Boethius' opinion.

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being is different from being good: their being good would be a contingent good (190,89–90). Therefore one thing would be to be/exist, another to be good. So let us suppose that a substance that were good would also be white, heavy, round (190,91–2): if we do not consider this substance as being derived, all these qualities would coincide with the substance and would be indistinguishable one from another, which is impossible. Therefore, existence in things which are derived is one thing, their '*aliquid esse*' is another, and they are good, but they do not have the *ipsum bonum.* But if things were nothing other than good, then they would no longer be things, but the principle of things (191,105). Therefore all things would be reduced to the good and to the One – the One, in fact, is solely good – and nothing else would exist.

2.4.4 Participation and God's *simplicitas*

However, since these things are not *simplicia* (191,108), because *simplex* is the attribute of the highest good, they could not even exist if the highest good did not want them to. Their goodness comes, therefore, from the fact that their being '*defluxit*' from the will of the good (191,109–11). The first good, in fact, since it exists, is good precisely by the fact that it exists; in it existence and goodness coincide, because it is *simplex*; the second good, on the other hand, is such because it '*fluxit*' from it who is good thanks to its very existence (191,115–7): here the distinction between first and second good is introduced. The good of the particular being is, in fact, in the first good (191,117–8).

Our observations on the *simplicitas* of God, presented in a previous work,[221] were acknowledged by Micaelli,[222] who also mentions the assertion: "*cum illud ipsum bonum primum* [*est*] *et ipsum esse sit et ipsum bonum et ipsum esse bonum*" (p. 48,149–50, Stewart-Rand-Tester; p. 192,139–40, Moreschini).[223] In this sentence Boethius affirms the identity between being and the *forma* of being, and between the good and the *forma* of the good. This identity between the thing and its essence is considered true, however, in the *De hebdomadibus* only for simple realities free from composition with matter, while in the *De sancta Trinitate* (p. 10,29–31; p. 170,92–4, Moreschini) the identity between the thing and its essence seems to be valid only for God. This statement, according to Micaelli, is derived from Plotinus, for whom simplicity is reserved for the first hypostasis (cf. VI 8,12). Substances that are not *simplicia*

221 Moreschini (1991), 283–95, (reprinted 2003).

222 Micaelli (2003), 33–53, at 38–40.

223 "While that very first good is existence itself and good itself and good existence itself." Micaelli does not delete *est*, as Tester and as we did, but supports the validity of the manuscript tradition, because in his opinion, in this passage Boethius assigns to the '*ipsum bonum*' the attributes of the *nous* of Plotinus (and therefore the *ipsum bonum* certainly '*est*'). (Cf. Micaelli (1995), 108, n. 210, (2003), 38–39). That is true, but the sentence as it actually stands is grammatically incorrect ("*cum* […] *est et* […] *sit*").

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have come into existence only subsequent to the will of God. Being is attributed to the *nous*, rather than to the One, wherefore the *primum bonum* of Boethius is closer to the *nous* than to the One of Plotinus.[224]

In his discussion of the existence of a gradation between the supreme Good and the partial goods, Augustine says (*Trin.* VIII 3,5) that there could not be contingent things ("*mutabilia*") if the absolute and immutable Good did not exist. And this absolute Good is "*simplex:*" it is nothing other than the Good, and therefore is the supreme Good. Augustine anticipated Boethius here as well, as a follower of Neo-Platonism. For Boethius God is *simplex*, and the *simplicitas* of God consists in the identification between being and goodness: this is discussed more extensively in *Consolatio* III 10 – 12 and summarized in two axioms in the *De hebdomadibus:* "VII *Omne simplex esse suum et id quod est unum habet*" (this means that in God existence and goodness coincide); "III *Omni composito aliud est esse, aliud ipsum est*" (on the contrary, in the contingent goods, to be is not the same as to be good). Therefore, Boethius has expressed in an axiomatic form what was already clear to Augustine.

A passage of Augustine's *Enarrationes in Psalmos* (134,3 – 4) is of great significance for the problem currently under consideration. Because of its function, it is more discursive and didactic, preparatory to the *De Trinitate.* Augustine asserts that God made good all the things he created, as is clear from the narrative of Genesis; and those things classified as part of creation (*in creatura*) are immediately listed, just as in the passage of the *De Trinitate* discussed above: sun, moon, stars, earth, man, angels. They are all good things, but the goodness of God is different from theirs: God is not good in the same way that the things he made are good: "*ille bono suo bonus est, non aliunde participato bono; ille seipso bono bonus est, non adhaerendo alteri bono.*"[225] The created thing is "*bonum alio bono bonum* ("good due to another good")," whereas God is "*bonum seipso bonum* ("good that is good thanks to Himself")." God is perfect in himself, independently of the existence of creatures: "*non indigens, incommutabilis, nullius bonum quaerens quo augeatur*".[226]

Augustine also introduces the equivalence between goodness and absolute being, which is actuated in God, who, in fact, said of himself: "*Ego sum qui sum*" (*Exodus* 3:14) or: "*Ego sum qui est.*" In fact, God is; he exists in such a way that, compared to him, things that were made exist not; being really means to be immutable, and only God possesses this. All this is familiar to us, thanks to what we read in Boethius: the equivalence between being and goodness; the difference between being good in himself and being good

224 This is normal for Christian Platonists, due to the impersonal nature of the One, which could not apply to the Christian God.

225 "God is good thanks to His goodness, not thanks to a good in which he participates; God is good due to His very good, not because He adheres to another good."

226 "He needs nothing, he is without change, he does not require any other's good, in order to grow by it."

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through participation; creatures are good through participation, 'being united' ("*adhaerendo*") to God. What is not considered is the original relationship of goodness between God the Creator and creatures, which, as far as they exist, are good.

At the beginning of the eighth book of the *De Trinitate*, Augustine says that the attributes of the individual persons of the Trinity "*secundum essentiam dicuntur, quia hoc est ibi esse quod magnum esse, quod bonum esse, quod sapientem esse, et quicquid aliud ad se unaquaeque ibi Persona vel ipsa Trinitas dicitur.*"[227]

Therefore, to be '*bonus secundum essentiam*' is equivalent to the definition of the *substantialia bona*, which is the subject of the discussion in Boethius' *De hebdomadibus:* why are things that exist good insofar as they exist, without, however, being '*substantialia bona*'? This differentiation between the 'simple' being of God and manifold being of contingent reality is clear to Augustine, and frequently developed in the *De Trinitate*, e. g.: "*humano quippe animo non hoc est esse quod est fortem esse, aut prudentem aut iustum aut temperantem; potest enim esse animus et nullam istarum habere virtutem*" (VI 4,6).[228]

God, however, has many attributes: great, good, wise, blessed, true, and any other not unworthy of him. But his greatness is identified by his wisdom, and his goodness is the same thing as his wisdom and greatness, and truth itself is the same thing as all of these: "*et non est ibi aliud beatum esse et aliud magnum, aut sapientem aut verum, aut bonum esse, aut omnino ipsum esse*" (VI 7,8).[229]

2.4.5 The problems of participation

The solution to the problem considered in the *De hebdomadibus* is the following (191,119 – 192,36): Things, by the very fact that they exist, are good, but they are not similar to the first good, because, even if their existence is good, their being could not exist "*nisi a primo esse defluxerit, id est bono*" (192,123).[230] So their existence is good, but it is not similar to that from which it derives, which is good in every sense for the very fact that it exists: it is nothing else but good (192,125 – 6). The being of created things, if it did not

227 "For they are thus spoken of according to essence, since in them to be is the same as to be great, as to be good, as to be wise, and whatever else is said of each person individually therein, or of the Trinity itself, in respect to themselves." (transl. Schaff (1887), here and in the following, with slight adaptations).

228 "Since, in the human mind, to be is not the same as to be strong, or prudent, or just, or temperate; for a mind can exist, and yet have none of these virtues. But in God to be is the same as to be strong, or to be just, or to be wise, or whatever is said of that simple multiplicity, or multifold simplicity, whereby to signify His substance."

229 "And in Him it is not one thing to be blessed, and another to be great, or wise, or true, or good, or in a word to be Himself."

230 "Unless it has derived from the first being, that is, the good."

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derive from the being which is good, could perhaps be good, but not good in its existence. It could perhaps participate in the good, but their being would not have goodness, because it would not be derived from the good. Therefore, if the first good were removed, things might be good, but could not be good in virtue of their being/existence ("*in eo quod essent*"). Since, moreover, they never would have existed if the true good had not 'produced' ("*produxisset*") them, in this way their existence is good, but that which is derived from that which is substantially good is not similar to it (192,134 – 5).

Let us now consider one aspect of the problem more closely, that of being through participation. The doctrines of participation and of 'derivation,' namely that of the '*defluere*' of things from the highest good, that is from God, are Neo-Platonic, observes Brosch.[231] Boethius could not have failed to grasp the serious implications for his Christian faith. Therefore, Brosch argued that the concept of real participation in God must be rejected entirely, and together with that of '*defluere*' (which implies, essentially, the emanation of one reality from another) should be understood metaphorically, as if they were images of the creation ('bildhaft').[232] Finally, the '*bonum esse per participationem*' regards the creature, since creature is good because it has its cause in God, not because, as an '*esse secundum*,'[233] it is good '*per substantiam.*'[234]

In our opinion, Brosch, while identifying the ambiguous points in the problem, is too reductive in reading into Boethius a metaphorical way of expression to escape the danger of pantheism. The basis for his interpretation is the belief that Boethius had been a 'Christian' in the modern sense of the term, that is as a thinker 'obedient' to the 'dogma' of the Church. But Boethius can assert the derivation of things that are good from the supreme good not as a creation: when he wrote "*fluxit*" he did not mean '*creatum est, conditum est*,' according to the Christian *creatio ex nihilo.* As a Neo-Platonist, he understood creation as the 'coming' of a substance from God; but certainly this is not the *creatio ex nihilo*, which he does not consider even for the world. At the same time, Boethius is undoubtedly Christian, because his doctrine of derivation is alien to all forms of Neo-Platonism and emanatism: things '*defluxerunt*,' but thanks to the "*voluntas boni*" (193,145) and to the "*voluntas Dei*" (192,142).[235]

231 Brosch (1933), 96 – 98.

232 Brosch (1933), 99.

233 For this distinction, Brosch is primarily basing his argument on a passage of the *De sancta Trinitate* (c. 4,174,204 – 7): "*homo non integre ipsum homo est ac per hoc nec substantia; quod enim est aliis debet quae non sunt homo. Deus vero hoc ipsum Deus est; nihil enim aliud est nisi quod est, ac per hoc ipsum Deus est,*" ("Man is not simply and entirely man, and therefore is not substance after all. For what he is he owes to other things which are not man. But God is simply and entirely God, for he is nothing else than what he is, and therefore is simply God.")

234 Brosch (1933), 102.

235 For this reason, taking into account these expressions, Galonnier is inclined to believe (Boèce (2007), 320 – 3) that Boethius, even if he uses the terms '*facere*' or '*creare*,' is in favor of a creationist theory, based on a voluntary act of creation. See also on 320, n. 129, with reference to August., *Gen. ad litt.* II 2. Yet I do not find his suggestion convincing.

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Consequently, I do not see here, unlike Hadot,[236] a participation of the thing in being. Rather, as noted by Obertello,[237] "the identity of being and of the good in the first Being is the foundation for the identity of being and of the good in the things existing." This identity does not, however, include the identity of things with the first Being. The being of things that exist is good before any determination, because it is derived from the first Good, which is the first Being.

But there is one inevitable question that Boethius does not evade, as Obertello has lucidly observed.[238] If the composite being has in common its very radical foundation with the absolute Being, then it is identical to it, just as if I share in common with another man whiteness, it follows that I too am white. This is the *crux* of the metaphysical dilemma when looked at from the perspective of participation. The compound being is not the Absolute, yet it 'shares' its being in an essential and constitutive, and not in an accidental and extrinsic manner.

Boethius nevertheless flatly denies that a consequence of participation is a form of 'pantheism:' he considers it blasphemy. Pantheism had already been refuted by Augustine in his anti-Manichean controversy: in *Contra epist. Fund.* 37 (CSEL 25, 242) he introduces the gradation in being and in the good; the identification between God and the partial good is therefore wrong. Participation in the good, Boethius asserts, implies the presence of the good in all things inasmuch as they exist. Insofar as they are basically good, they tend to the good (188,49 – 52) and participate in it; it is an inevitable consequence that, if all good things participate in the supreme good, good be in them, but participation does not imply the identity of God and created things.

A second difficulty lies in the section p. 192,139 – 194,64. Let us take the example of whiteness, to which Obertello alludes. It is not difficult to solve: whiteness is something accidental, and does not have any substantial relation with the Good (see 192,140 – 193,152). Yet another difficulty is more momentous. Why are things, besides being good, not also just, since just too is an attribute of good? Because if goodness has to do with being, justice, on the contrary, has nothing to do with being, but with acting, and therefore, as being and action coincide only in God, who is wholly simple, created things are good in their being, but they are not also just (193,153 – 5). Galonnier also addresses this difficulty: if things are white, it is not because God is white, in the same way as they are good because they were created by God, nor for that reason are they just.[239] The example of whiteness (p. 192,140 – 193,52), he observes, derives from the 'affection' in the Aristotelian classification, and that of justice (p. 193,153 – 194,161) appears in Aristotle as a 'permanent state'

236 A distinction explained in (1970), 149 – 50.
237 Obertello (1974), 646.
238 Obertello (1981), 157 – 68, at 164.
239 Boèce, Galonnier (2007), 334 – 5.

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('*hexis*'). But whiteness does not raise problems if it is not reserved to God, whereas justice does.

The doctrine of '*participatio boni*' also appears in the *Consolatio:* Boethius takes up once more, at the end of his life, what he had already considered earlier. Having demonstrated in a major passage (*Cons.* III 10), which is the fulcrum of the subsequent argument, the equivalence between God and the highest good, which constitutes His intimate essence, Philosophy presents, by way of corollary, a very significant conclusion:

nam quoniam beatitudinis adeptione fiunt homines beati, beatitudo vero est ipsa divinitas, divinitatis adeptione beatos fieri manifestum est. Sed uti iustitiae adeptione iusti, sapientiae sapientes fiunt, ita divinitatem adeptos deos fieri simili ratione necesse est. Omnis igitur beatus deus. Sed natura quidem unus; participatione vero nihil prohibet esse quam plurimos (III 10,23 – 5).[240]

This is followed by another important section (*Cons.* III 11,5). Philosophy endeavors to demonstrate that earthly goods are of a contingent and limited character, even though they are desired by most men, while the *verum bonum* is obtained when all the goods come together to make up a "*veluti forma atque efficientia*" (that is, a '*dynamis*,' as Gruber correctly understands it),[241] so that all differences between the various individual goods are eliminated. Here we find the Platonic doctrine of form, which is the only one that constitutes true reality; without form there is only an appearance of good; God is pure form, as Boethius said in the *De sancta Trinitate* (2, p. 170,91 – 2). If all goods were not to overlap, there would be no reason for them to be desirable. For this reason, this assumption of all goods in the highest good is effected by means of the "*adeptio unitatis*" (III 11,7). But all that is good is so thanks to the "*boni participatio*" (III 11,8): this participation is to be understood, therefore, in the fullest sense, as in a previous passage of the *Consolatio* (III 10,23 – 5), in the sense that something is good insofar as it takes into itself ('*partem capit, participat*') part of the good. As for Boethius and the Neo-Platonists, the *summum bonum* is God, which is why the goodness of creatures derives from their participation in God. In the *Consolatio*, Boethius discusses once more the

240 "For since men are made happy by the acquisition of happiness, but happiness is itself divinity, it is obvious that they are made happy by the acquisition of divinity. But as by the acquisition of justice they become just, or by the acquisition of wisdom wise, so by the same argument they must, when they have acquired divinity, become gods. Therefore every happy man is a god, though by nature God is one only; but nothing prevents there being as many as you like by participation." This may be a reception of Proclus, as Prof. Ilinca Tanaseanu-Döbler observes. Proclus' principles (quoted above, p. 77 – 78), take into consideration the possibility of a contact of inferior beings, such as divinized souls, with gods: this does not differ greatly from Boethius' opinion that there can be many gods, thanks to the imitation of God. See also n. 248, where we observe that according to Proclus there are many kinds of similarities.

241 Boethius, Gruber (^{2}2006), *ad locum.*

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problem of the identification of God with good things, for which he had excluded in the *De hebdomadibus*, as we have seen, pantheism.

2.4.6 Boethius and Augustine

Which doctrines and which authorities does Boethius follow? Mostly the Neo-Platonism of his time, but not exclusively: he himself provides an indication, when he declares in the prologue of *De sancta Trinitate* to have followed Augustine (166,29 – 167,32), and requests confirmation and assurance of this fact from his father-in-law Symmachus. Schurr had good cause to devote a large portion of his study to tracing aspects of the presence of Augustine in the works of Boethius, and this interpretation of Boethius' Augustinianism is also proposed by Chadwick.[242]

Here we wish to address the topic of the Augustinian doctrines in Boethius only in regard to those problems discussed in relation to 'participation in God.' It seems, in fact, that this issue is present in Augustine, given their common Neo-Platonic education. In the *De Genesi ad litteram*, Augustine disputes with heretics (in all likelihood Manicheans), who, scandalized by the evil will of the devil,[243] try to eliminate him from the creation of the supreme and true God, and to assign him to another principle contrary to God, namely the principle of evil. In fact, they are not able to understand that "*omne quod est, in quantum aliqua substantia est, et bonum esse et nisi ab illo Deo vero, a quo omne bonum est, esse non posse*" (XI 13).[244] Instead, evil is caused by an evil will, which prefers lower to higher things, it violates in other words the order of the universe. Evil, therefore, is not substantial, but consists in the violation of order.

Another famous passage, already emphasized by Obertello,[245] is that in which Augustine (*Trin.* VIII 3,4) is moved to affirm the goodness of things in the different degrees of being. All things are good, but (and this is the most important point): "*Quid plura et plura? Bonum hoc et bonum illud. Tolle hoc et illud, et vide ipsum bonum, si potes: ita Deum videbis, non alio bono bonum, sed bonum omnis boni*".[246]

242 Schurr (1935), 89 – 92, 97 – 100. Regarding the correspondence between Boethius and Augustine, Chadwick (1981, 211) quotes Augustine's *Enarr. in Psalmos* 49,2 and 52,6; *De civ. Dei* IX 23; *Ioh. Tract.* 48,9.

243 Not without reason, Augustine speaks here of an "evil will," and not of an "evil nature:" evil, indeed, is not substantial, according to Augustine, but arises from free will; thus the devil is not evil by substance, but by will.

244 "All that exists, since it is a substance, is good and cannot exist if it did not derive from that true God, from whom every good derives."

245 Severino Boezio, Obertello/Ribet (1979), 37 – 38.

246 "And why add yet more and more? This thing is good and that good, but take away this and that, and regard good itself if thou canst; so wilt thou see God, not good by a good that is other than Himself, but the good of all good."

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Boethius asserts the same in *Consolatio* III 11, which we examined above: next to individual limited goods arises, as a form and a power of good (which is the technical Neo-Platonic language added by Boethius) the *summum bonum*; similarly, Augustine had observed that God is not good because of a good that is alien to him, but, rather, is the good of all good. In the same vein (*Trin.* XI 5,8), Augustine says: "*in quantum ergo bonum est quidquid est, in tantum scilicet, quamvis longe distantem, habet tamen nonnullam similitudinem summi boni.*"[247] *Similitudo* in this passage of the *De Trinitate* is certainly generic, but it indicates, as in the *De hebdomadibus* (p. 191,119 – 20 and 124 – 5), the relationship between the *bona* and the *primum bonum:* "*idcirco enim, licet in eo quod sint bona sint, non sunt tamen similia primo bono* […] *idcirco ipsum esse bonum est nec est simile ei a quo est.*"[248]

One could therefore say that Augustine had already laid the groundwork for the discussion that Boethius would develop later. The problem of participation appears, however, still to be in a much less developed stage in Augustine, with all ensuing consequences. To Boethius, on the other hand, the consequences are quite clear, as the *De hebdomadibus* demonstrated. In Augustine's *De Trinitate* one can find statements similar to those of Boethius, in which the word 'participation' is employed. Such is the case in V 10,11:

In rebus enim quae participatione magnitudinis magnae sunt, quibus aliud est esse, aliud magnas esse, sicut magna domus et magnus mons et magnus animus, in his ergo rebus aliud est magnitudo, aliud quod ab ea magnitudine magnum est et prorsus non hoc est magnitudo quod est magna domus.[249]

It is evident that this argument is moving towards the issue of the distinction, already mentioned above, between a simple and compound substance, so that the *participatio magnitudinis* of contingent things is not a real participation, a

247 "In so far, therefore, as anything that is, is good, in so far plainly it has still some likeness of the supreme good, at however, great a distance."

248 "For though they are good in virtue of their existence, they are not therefore like the first good […] therefore their particular being is good, but it is not like that from which it derives." As Micaelli noted (2003, 48 – 49), the gradation between fullness and *similitudo* is also expressed by Proclus (*Element.* 18, p. 20,9, Dodds; *Tim.* I, p. 363,48 – 9). Proclus imagines three hypotheses: the first is rejected by Boethius as '*nefas*' (189,72: "*Ex quo fit ut omnia quae sunt Deus sint, quod dictu nefas est*") ("Hence all things that are, are God – an impious assertion"), because it would entail the pure and simple identity of things with the First Good (in other words, pantheism). The second is that which, in Boethius, led to the exclusion of goodness from the being of things, because goodness through participation was perceived as something accidental, and therefore not part of the essence of the thing. The third and last hypothesis, which is accepted by Proclus, coincides with that of Boethius. As Proclus states, that which is given is preexistent in the giver, and Boethius likewise asserts, "*ipsum igitur eorum esse bonum est; tunc enim in eo.*" ("Therefore their particular being is good: for then it is in the first good").

249 "For in things which are great by partaking of greatness, to which it is one thing to *be,* and another to be *great,* as a great house, and a great mountain, and a great mind; in these things, I say, greatness is one thing, and that which is great because of greatness is another, and a great house, certainly, is not absolute greatness itself."

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partem capere of the form of the *magnitudo*, but is a kind of 'predication' of being great one makes of contingent things. Of greater weight is, of course, the statement in *De Trinitate* VIII 3,5, which fits into the context, already noted, of the goodness of all things inasmuch as they exist: there it is stated that, after having observed the various contingent goods, abstracting from them, it will be possible to see God: "*si potueris sine illis quae participatione boni bona sunt, perspicere ipsum bonum cuius participatione bona sunt.*"[250]

Here, in fact, Augustine came quite close to the point from which Boethius began, and speaks a language reminiscent of the style of the *Consolatio*. Boethius, in fact, returns to the problem of *participatio*, of course referring to Augustine as well as to his Neo-Platonic sources, tackling it consistently and providing a coherent organic response.

2.4.7 Conclusions

As Marenbon observes,[251] the apparent Neo-Platonic metaphysics of the *De hebdomadibus* is based on a distinction that exists within Aristotelian logic, even if it is an Aristotelian logic presented by the Neo-Platonist Porphyry and expanded by Boethius himself. As for his theological method, the strong innovation of Boethius' *Opuscula* (with the exception of the fourth), which had profound influence, is his insistence on employing the tradition of Aristotelian logic as developed in Neo-Platonism to approach theological problems. Augustine had in the *De Trinitate* effectively anticipated Boethius, but the Neo-Platonic metaphysics had always remained his favorite philosophical instrument.

2.4.8 Some observations on the terms of 'being'

A striking feature of the philosophical and theological works of Boethius is the technicality of the language, and the fact that, simultaneously, such technical language is entirely missing in the *Consolatio*, which is a work of high literary polish, including even attempts at poetry, often successful.

We would like to dwell somewhat on the vocabulary of being, as developed in the *Opuscula Theologica*, and especially in the *De hebdomadibus*. Following the custom, based on a long tradition (Cicero's first attempts at a philosophical language come to mind, and the limitation of grecisms and neologisms in

250 "If you can put aside those things which are good by the participation of the good, and discern that good itself by the participation of which they are good." Augustine goes on to explain that when we speak of this or that good thing, we understand at the same time also the good itself: this is the way to see God.

251 Cf. Marenbon (2003b), 94–5. See also Chadwick (1981), 262.

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Seneca's philosophical vocabulary for reasons of purity of diction),[252] Boethius uses *esse* in the *De hebdomadibus* as a subject ('to exist'), in its simplest form (i. e. "*esse:*" 28, 97, 100), as well as determined by a genitive, "*esse eorum*" (110, 135) or "*esse igitur ipsorum*" (64).

More problematic is the stronger, abstract form of "to be", signified by *ipsum:* either employed simply as "*ipsum esse*" (26, 29, 33, 69, 98, 129), or in combination with a genitive: "*omnium igitur rerum ipsum esse*" ("the very being of all things") (64 – 5); "*ipsum esse earum*" (121 – 2) or "*ipsum eorum esse*" (117, 139, 140), or "*ipsum esse omnium rerum*" (114) and "*ipsum esse rerum*" (122 – 3). In this case I do not think that *ipsum* has the original value of reinforcement, but a 'technical' value proper to these dialectical-theological works, and is analogous to the article in Romance languages. Boethius required it, since it is lacking in the Latin language but present instead in the Greek texts on logic and metaphysics that inspired him, and where the article is commonly found (τὸ εἶναι). Thus, the phrase should be translated simply as: "their being" or "the being of all things."

If *ipsum* served to present being more clearly as subject, in the so-called 'oblique cases' Boethius is forced to resort to real circumlocutions. For example, the most frequently used is the ablative "*in eo quod est*" (125, 148); "*in eo quod est esse*" (128); "*in eo quod sunt*" (74, 137, 141, 146, 151—2), "*in eo quod essent*" (132) or "*in eo quod ipsum est*" (56—7), which is equivalent to ἐν τῷ εἶναι. Or, the causal ablative "*eo quod est esse*" (39), or the ablative of derivation: "*ex eo quod est esse*" (63), which are equivalent to τῷ εἶναι or to ἐκ τοῦ εἶναι.

However, even in this use of *esse* Boethius found a precedent in Marius Victorinus. Not only can we find the same phrases used by Boethius, but also many other similar ones. We must restrict ourselves here to listing only a selected few. For example, for the definitions of being: "*significatur hoc verbo quod est esse, graece quod est* τὸ εἶναι" (*Adv. Arium* IV 19, p. 253,5).[253]

The use of *esse* as a subject: "*et est illis esse quodam modo esse et non esse*"[254] (*Ad Cand.* 9, p. 26,15); "*ipsum esse, ipsum vivere* (scl. *est*)" (*Adv. Arium* IV 19, p. 254,19).

The use of *esse* as a predicate: "*ubicumque est et esse est et actio*" (*Ad Cand.* 23, p. 40,9);[255] "*ipsum esse actio est et agere esse est*"[256] (ibid. 27, p. 43,15 – 6: '*esse*' subject and predicate in the same sentence).

As an object: "*eius esse* (accusative) οὐσίαν *dicimus*" (*Ad Cand.* 28, p. 43,10).

The phrases of the verb *esse* joined to a preposition: the most common is "*in*

252 This problem, regarding the novelty of the terminology, is also present in Boethius' logical works.

253 "It is designated by the word 'to be,' in Greek *to einai.*"

254 "And 'to be' is for them in some way 'to be' and 'not to be'."

255 "Since indeed ,'to be' itself is also 'to act' itself, and 'to act' is also 'to be'."

256 "Since 'to be' itself is action and 'to act' is 'to be'."

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eo quod est esse" (*Ad Cand.* 20, p. 37,11; 23, p. 39,2 – 3 etc.) or in the following: "*secundum quod est in actu esse*" (*Ad Cand.* 19, p. 36,5: κατὰ τὸ ἐν ἐνεργείᾳ εἶναι); "*iuxta id quod est esse* (*Ad Cand.* 31, p. 47,9 – 10: κατὰ τὸ εἶναι); "*ipsum deum iuxta quod est esse, quod dicimus* […] *ipsum esse*" (*Adv. Arium* I 31, p. 110,5 – 7);[257] "*omnium quae sunt ad id quod est esse* (εἰς τὸ εἶναι) *causa est*"[258] (*Adv. Arium* I 34, p. 117,14 – 6); "*ab eo enim quod est esse universale*"[259] (*Adv. Arium* I 34, p. 117,18); "*ab eo est quod est esse*"[260] (*Ad Cand.* 19, p. 36,4 – 5) etc.

Moreover, the phrase *quod est* is employed by Marius Victorinus to indicate, even with different verbs, the equivalent of the Greek article, both for the subject and for the oblique cases: "*quod est operari*" (*Adv. Arium* I 4, p. 59,7 and 11; I 5, p. 60,7 – 8); "*ab ipso quod est vivere*" (*Adv. Arium* I 13, p. 73,38 – 9).

The addition of '*ipsum*,' declined in the various cases, serves to enhance the clarity of the Latin language.

The linguistic freedom that characterizes Boethius in the use of formulas and technical terms in Greek, who wants to give them a new meaning, appears in a passage of chapter two of the *De sancta Trinitate*, where, wanting to distinguish the three parts of theoretical philosophy (natural philosophy, mathematical philosophy, theological philosophy), he states that the first is "*in motu inabstracta*" (168,69), and seeks to indicate with a Greek term what corresponds to the Latin '*inabstracta.*' What is this term? The manuscripts, as we know, are of little help when it comes to choosing from among the various forms of Greek terms. Both Peiper and Rand (and partly Vallinus before them) followed the reading of the ninth-century Laurentianus XIV 15 (L, one of the most authoritative manuscripts), which reads: "*naturalis, in motu inabstracta*, ἀνυπεξαίρετος."[261] The word ἀνυπεξαίρετος reappears with a few changes in the other codices of the Laurentianus family. The forms proposed by the family of Corbie seem even stranger. Finally, the best manuscript of the Fleury family, the Aurelianensis 270 (O), has been corrected by a second hand, while leaving it open to hypothesization what the original reading may have been: it was probably close to that of manuscript Z, the second of the Fleury family; in turn, the reading of the Fleury family agrees substantially with the reading of Laurentianus. This reading, therefore, should be considered the original one. The meaning of the term, as can be understood on the basis of its components, is clear. The problem, however, is that before Boethius it is employed only once by Marcus Aurelius (*Ad se ipsum* VIII 41): εἰ μὲν ἀνυπεξαιρέτως ὥρμας, ἤδη ὡς λογικοῦ κακόν, εἰ δὲ τὸ κοινὸν λαμβάνεις, οὔπω βέβλαψαι οὐδὲ ἐμπεπόδισαι. Marcus Aurelius states quite a different thing: "ohne Vorbehalt" is Theiler's

257 "The substance of God is God himself according to 'to be' which we call […] or 'to be' itself."

258 "But God, as God, is cause both of potential 'to be' and of all existents with respect to their 'to be'."

259 "From the universal 'to be'."

260 "Therefore, to move oneself and to know and to act are from that which is 'to be'."

261 "Physics deals with motion and is not abstract or separable."

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translation of ἀνυπεξαιρέτως.[262] It is likely, therefore, that the word (as an adjective) was coined by Boethius himself, with a second (and new) meaning.

262 Theiler (1951), 193. In the note to the passage (332) Theiler in a quite cryptic way suggests a reference to VI 50,2, where Marc Aurel says: μεθ᾽ὑπεξαιρέσεως ὥρμας (transl.: "du den Trieb mit Vorbehalt hattest"). This means that in both passages Theiler interprets the word as connected to ἐξαίρεσις, i.e. 'free will'.

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3. The *Consolatio Philosophiae*

The *Consolatio Philosophiae* is a dialogue in which Philosophy, personified and appearing suddenly like a vision, shows Boethius, who had been unjustly imprisoned, that the misfortunes befalling him are included, like those of every other man and, more precisely, like any human event, in a reality directed and governed in the best way by divine Providence. Therefore, humans do not require commiseration, but a personal and confident acceptance of its will. Boethius' arguments are initially human, certainly justified by the apparent reality of things, but mostly limited and removed from the truth; those of Philosophy, on the other hand, who had been Boethius' guide since youth, are 'philosophical,' that is, are more profoundly true. All this is developed through a discussion going through a continuous series of questions, eventually losing its dialogical character to be transformed into an unbroken dissertation.

3.1 Was the *Consolatio* completed?

Considering Boethius' peculiar circumstances when writing the *Consolatio*, awaiting a most probable judgment resulting in death, one problem must be discussed first: how could he have had the opportunity to write such a difficult work, which required serenity and a great amount of literary, philosophical, and theological knowledge? Could the *De consolatione philosophiae*, so well-structured in its ascension by degrees to the peaks of the most arduous and abstract questions, indeed, in its literary perfection, actually be the work of a writer imprisoned in the jail of Pavia?

Scholars have further wondered if the work was actually ever completed and underwent a final revision. The *Consolatio*, in fact, ends abruptly, and there is no conclusion allowing either Philosophy or Boethius to exit the scene; after the explanation concerning the harmonious interaction between Providence and free will, Philosophy simply exhorts men to behave righteously, in the belief of being constantly under the eyes of God.

As far as the question of the possibility of writing such a work involving philosophy and literature at the same time, Pierre Courcelle asserted that the exact quotation of Macrobius' *Commentary* on Scipio's dream in II 7,4–8 proves that Boethius was still able to enjoy a certain degree of liberty to consult books in a library: his situation was not that of a man who is imprisoned, but

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who is "dans sa résidence forcée."[1] Chadwick presumes, in the same vein, that Boethius could very well have had the opportunity to read the books of the philosophers he discussed and the works of the poets he imitated.[2]

Obertello, too, has maintained that the *Consolatio* was composed before Boethius was actually imprisoned, even though the numerous details of his experience to which he alludes are evidence that he had already been condemned.[3] According to him, it is unlikely that Boethius had access to all the necessary books for the examination and discussion of the difficult and complicated problems that he was analyzing in his writing while in jail, which required comparisons with Greek texts, quotations from poets and philosophers, translations from philosophical works. On the contrary, the translations are accurate, the quotations precise and not cited from memory, as was frequently the case. In addition, the structure of the *De consolatione* has an internal consistency, which can be better explained by the hypothesis that the writer had enjoyed the necessary comfort to devote himself to problems requiring great effort and full capacity of concentration. Thus, Boethius, before being imprisoned, spent a period of time in which he was deprived of his freedom, but his situation, although not the happiest, was still tolerable. Some allusions within the *Consolatio* suggest that Boethius could still follow the development of his trial: he explicitly mentions the person responsible for the accusations brought against him, although he never names King Theoderic, from whom he awaits the final sentence; more than once he refers to him obliquely when emphasizing the cruelty, interior weakness, and misery of tyrants. 'Free' as he was, we cannot exclude that Boethius was not simply requesting a consolation from Philosophy, but also, indirectly, an intervention in his favor by the public, to which his work was directed.

Regarding the second question, we cannot escape the impression that Boethius abandoned his writing abruptly. The conclusion, which lacks any definitive word, stands in contrast to the attention to form and elaboration which otherwise characterizes the entire work, manifest up to the last sentences. In a word, the *Consolatio* does not end in a manner conforming to the rules of rhetorical composition. Tränkle detected many details that show that the *Consolatio* was never finished, concluding that Boethius was forced to suddenly interrupt his composition – but he does not consider the problem of the liberty he might have still enjoyed while in prison.[4] Tränkle has been criticized by Shanzer, who asserts that the perfectly organized structure of the *Consolatio* does not permit the deduction that it was never concluded. Should we believe, then, that Boethius' execution coincided exactly with the moment of the completion of his work? It is not opportune to insist on this problem,

1 Courcelle (1967), 123.
2 Chadwick (1981), 54.
3 Obertello (1974), 121.
4 Tränkle (1977), 148 – 56.

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because it would be too easy to fall into the trap of tedious hypotheses and misguided biographisms. It is certain, however, that Boethius was fully aware that he had not much longer to live (IV 6,5).[5] But if the hypothesis of Courcelle and Obertello is valid, then we must wonder even more why Boethius' work breaks off so abruptly. Perhaps his execution in the *ager Calventianus* came more suddenly than we imagine.[6]

3.2 The literary genre

The *Consolatio* is a dialogue, both according to the form of Platonic – Socratic dialogue (actually, some sections of *Consolatio* display a perfect imitation of the Platonic style)[7] and to the form that is commonly defined as 'Aristotelian' (that of the exoteric works of Aristotle), namely that of the philosophical tractate used by Cicero and Augustine. Boethius already used dialogue in a work of his youth, the first interpretation of Porphyry's *Isagoge*, but soon abandoned it in his following works. Dialogue was also used by one of his contemporaries, by Fulgentius in the *Expositio Virgilianae continentiae*.

But the *Consolatio* cannot be regarded merely as a dialogue, because it is also characterized by another peculiarity, that is, by the presence of various poetical compositions, which must be considered as part of the discussion. Indeed, they do not have a purely external relationship with the preceding dialogical section, which is sometimes difficult to define, but are an essential part of the work. The *Consolatio*, considered in its apparent structure, can therefore be called a 'prosimetron.'

3.3 The *prosimetron:* poetry in the *Consolatio*

The poems of the *Consolatio* are especially noteworthy, because Boethius introduces himself to his public for the very first time as a poet: the technical character of his previous works, which were logical and theological in content, never suggested such a bold conversion to poetry. What is more important, "Some of Boethius' poems merit comparison with the very best the Latin tradition has to offer."[8] In the same vein, John Magee pertinently observes the

5 Shanzer (1984), 352 – 366, at 364 – 5.

6 Later Shanzer appears to admit that the *Consolatio* remained unfinished, claiming that "increasing haste as the author's execution approached affected the composition" (see Shanzer (2009b), 228 – 54, at 240).

7 This has been demonstrated for the imitation of Plato's *Gorgias* by Klingner (1921), 84 – 88, and recently by Magee (2009), 181 – 206 and (2014 – forthcoming).

8 Magee (2003), 147 – 69, at 148.

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skillful correspondence of the various compositions,[9] and his conclusion on the function of poetry in the *Consolatio* is entirely convincing: "On the eve of his unjust and violent death Boethius, like Plato's Socrates, must have felt the need to honour Beauty as well as Truth, to make Philosophy glorify the *musica mundana.* At the same time, poetry opened up the possibility of a more concentrated perspective, as arias do for an opera, choral odes for a tragedy, and myths for a Platonic dialogue."[10]

Earlier, in accordance with the erudite tendencies of nineteenth-century philology, the interest of scholars was almost exclusively focused on the individuation of poetical reminiscences. This issue seems to be of lesser significance today. Echoes of Virgil, Horace, and Ovid accord with the central position these poets held in the schools and culture of Late Antiquity; the presence of poets from the Imperial age have been detected as well, like Seneca, Statius, and Lucan. Gruber's commentary on Boethius' poems is exhaustive on this topic.[11]

Today, literary criticism is interested in the metrical portions of the *Consolatio*, the structure of the poems and the metrical form employed by Boethius. The meters are unusually varied and numerous: from the most common in epic poetry (hexameter and elegiac couplet) to those of lyrical poetry, taken from the tradition derived from Catullus and Horace, up to those of Seneca's tragedies. Boethius also employs less common verses, some of them apparently even created by himself. It seems, too, that a complicated correspondence is traceable between the poems: the most demanding and important with regard to its philosophical content (III, metrum IX) is placed in the middle of the work, and is written in the verse most suitable for didascalic poetry, in dactylic hexameters. Around this as their center, the other poems – some with evident correspondences, some with less clear ones – appear to be arranged: hence, those of the first two-and-a-half books correspond to those of the second two-and-a-half books. Joachim Gruber has convincingly analyzed the structure of the poems and presented a chart illustrating the correspondences.[12]

Such a correspondence, formerly judged artificial, has now been acknowledged to be of great significance. It suits Late Antique literature well, when rhetorical elaboration and *aemulatio* – that is the effort to compete with ancient models in an attempt to rework and surpass them before an educated audience that was able to grasp the artist's subtlety – appeared to be the most accepted method of writing poetry. Also the variety of meter testifies to the effort of an author who desired to imitate the ancient models by resuming the

9 Magee (2003), 151 – 68.

10 Magee (2003), 169.

11 See also Scheible (1972). Mueller-Goldingen ((1989) 381 – 390) competently examines Boethius' quotations (Homer: four times; Virgil: three times; Euripides: twice; others: Parmenides) and explores their significance in the discussion of the *Consolatio.*

12 Boethius, Gruber (^{2}2006), 16 – 22.

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meters of classical lyrical poetry while at the same time offering more and something new. Certainly, in the poetry of Boethius and in Late Antique poetry in general, artifice sometimes prevails over naturalness of expression, but naturalness was not the aim of the poets of that age (or earlier).

This aim in writing poems is confirmed by the fact that the use of poetry in Boethius not only has an aesthetic function, but also a paradigmatic one, as Anne Crabbe has convincingly observed.[13] In the elegiac verses at the beginning (I metrum I) the influence of Ovid and his elegies of the exile is clear, but it is also evident that Boethius does not intend a mere repetition of literary models. The initial verses appear to be programmatic and, therefore, should prefigure the rest of the work. They also exhibit a strong imitation of the final part of the *Georgica* and the spurious incipit of the *Aeneid*, which certainly was well-known in Late Antiquity.

Philosophy's entry and description follow. Her height is greater than average (this indicates in ancient literature beings superior to humans, such as heroes and demons), but she has suffered insults and abuse; her dress is in poor condition because it has been torn by the hands of brutal men. Imposing as she is, in a manner frankly rude, she drives away the Muses who surround Boethius and rejects the arguments proposed by them and Boethius himself. Such a *recusatio*,[14] even though it is manifest in all the prose passages of the first book, is essentially more suitable to poetry than to prose. Boethius has transformed the question audaciously: he does not ask "what kind of poetry is appropriate?" but "what kind of philosophical meditation deserves to be employed?". Philosophy drives the Muses away, because she wants to emphasize the opposition between two kinds of poetry. This interpretation of poetry derives from Plato, who suggested to exclude poets from the Republic of the philosophers. Cicero too, resuming Plato's view,[15] underlined the danger of 'sweet' poetry. Augustine does the same when he reconnects, with a certain effort, poetry with the lewdness of theater.[16] Boethius' preface to the *De institutione musica* mentions these debates, when he underlines the ethic function of music and condemns the demoralizing effects of poetry, as does Philosophy when highlighting the damage it causes.[17] Rhetorical tractates attributed, nevertheless, a certain dignity to the poetry that was concerned with gods, using arguments appropriate to that topic, so that the poet-theologian could also be superior to the epic poet: many tractates on the philosophy of nature make use of didascalic poetry. Therefore, the complaint of Philosophy in I m. II, in which she expounds the results achieved by Boethius in his study of natural philosophy, describes Boethius' own twofold

13 Crabbe (1981), 237–74, at 244–5, 249.
14 So Crabbe. However, the term *recusatio* has a different meaning in literary criticism.
15 Cf. *Resp.* IV 10; *Tusc.* II 11,27.
16 Cf. *Civ. Dei* II 10–14.
17 Crabbe (1981), 250–1.

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fall, not only philosophical, but also poetical: a fall from the potentially didactic themes, and possibly from the high peaks of astronomy to the degradation of elegy. Philosophy criticizes Boethius for listening to elegiac poems and reproaches him as well for the descent of his mind.

The condemnation of poetry was the object of one of Boethius' models, namely Augustine – which comes as no surprise.[18] Augustine's attitude towards Licentius in the *De ordine* reveals his opinion in this regard. Licentius should abandon poetry to attain, with the help of philosophy, a truly happy life.

Yet this opposition between Augustine and Boethius is not absolute: certainly Augustine, like all Christian writers, does not approve of giving oneself to poetry, but he does not reject Classical poetry, Virgil *in primis.*[19]

Boethius proceeds therefore to devote a large portion of the *Consolatio* to concretely demonstrate that it is not necessary to reject poetry completely, but only to refine it. Lady Philosophy can call his verses "*musici carminis oblectamenta*," even though she frequently proves that their function can be as serious as that of a philosophical discussion, and the rhetoric of the prose passages plays, at any rate, an equal role in the embellishment of the work.

This is the difference between the Christian and Classical view on poetry: traditionally, a Christian should not waste his time on poetry, but devote himself only to the truth (i. e., Christian doctrine),[20] while the Classical theory considered poetry a sweet ingredient to be mixed with *utile.* But in Christian poetry, too, as for *paideia* in general, theory differs from practice: not even the most refined poets, such as Prudentius and Paulinus Nolanus, doubted that Christian truth must be preferred to the sweetness of the Muses. The same can be said for Augustine and Boethius: an ambivalence of love and hate for poetry is perceivable, the predominance of truth and utility is still at work in the *Consolatio.*

3.4 The prosimetron: the *Consolatio* as a *satira*

The *Consolatio*, as we said, is a prosimetron, but prosimetron does not constitute a literary genre. It is simply the exterior form of a type of composition, the *satira:* as, for example, the *satira* by Petronius and, near the age of Boethius, by Martianus Capella.[21] An anonymous *Vita*, most likely from the circle of Cassiodorus, published by Fabio Troncarelli,[22] relates:

18 Crabbe (1981), 251 – 2.
19 See McCormack (1998).
20 See for the theory of a Christian poetry, *inter alios*, Vessey (2007) and Westra (2007) with bibliography.
21 On the *prosimetron* see Pabst (1994), Dronke (1994).
22 It is the *Vita Boethii* we considered at p. 30, published by Troncarelli (1981).

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Sed postquam a rege reus maiestatis convictus iussus est retrudi in carcerem. In quo repositus hos libros per satiram edidit imitatus videlicet Marcianum Felicem Capellam qui prius libros De nuptiis Philologiae et Mercurii eadem specie poematis conscripserat, sed iste longe nobiliore materia et facundia ei praecellit, quippe qui nec Tullio in prosa nec Vergilio in metro inferior floruit.[23]

Therefore the *Consolatio* is considered a *satira* by the anonymous biographer, who certainly was in command of the literary language of his time. As it appears to be in the works of Martianus Capella and Fulgentius, the prosimetron does not signify a mere mixture of various meters, but also "un mélange d'enseignement sérieux et de badinage cruel" (Ricklin).[24] Such a satiric tone can be found here and there in the *Consolatio*, particularly in the words of Philosophy[25] (Boethius appears at first so dull that he is compared to the ὄνος λύρας of the proverb, i. e. "are you like an ass hearing the sound of a lyre?"). The satire permitted Boethius to present himself and Philosophy as almost human characters.[26]

This mixture of prose, verse, and satire became popular in Rome, thanks especially to the works of Varro, author of many *Saturae Menippeae*. Also, the Menippean Satire (a definition in which the term 'satire' does not have the 'satirical' character as understood in modern languages, but simply indicates a mixed structure and a multiplicity of topics) was often a means, a vehicle for a philosophical discussion. Some scholars have therefore concluded that the *Consolatio* belongs to this literary genre.[27] But between Varro and Boethius lies a distance of about six centuries, making it much more appropriate to consider similar compositions with a more specifically and constantly philosophical content. As the anonymous *Vita* observed, before Boethius, Martianus Capella wrote a work that has a similar structure and a distinctly philosophical content, the *De nuptiis Mercurii et Philologiae*. The term 'prosimetron' is typical of Late Antiquity (Ausonius, Sidonius Apollinaris, and Ennodius, who was a contemporary of Boethius, all composed prosimetra). The *Consolatio*, therefore, follows the pattern of the Platonic and Aristotelian dialogue and that of the Menippean Satire, and this variety fits well the artistic trend of the

23 "But after he was convicted by King Theoderic of high treason, he was put into prison. There he wrote these books in the form of the satire, which are an imitation of Martianus Felix Capella. Before him Martianus wrote a book on the Marriage of Philology and Mercury in the same form of a poem, but Boethius is much more excellent than Martianus, both for the content and the eloquence, and he was not inferior either to Cicero in the prose or to Virgil in the poems."

24 Ricklin (2003), 131 – 146, at 135. On the use and significance of the prosimetron in Martianus Capella, cf. Tommasi (2012), 32 – 40. Tommasi shows how the 'hybrid genre' of the prosimetron, which gives the *satira* its structure, allowed the mixture of difficult doctrines (such as the *artes liberales* and the teaching of Philologia) and of 'ridiculous' or 'popular' details – just as, for some particulars, in Boethius' *Consolatio*.

25 Cf. Ricklin (2003), 140 – 1.

26 Ricklin (2003), 145.

27 See recently on this topic Shanzer (2009), 228 – 54, at 233 – 5.

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literature of Late Antiquity, which in contrast to the Classical age, concentrated specifically on the intertwining of the literary genres (the so-called 'Mischung der Gattungen'). Because of this device, that is the use of prose and verse, Courcelle discerned imitations of Martianus by Boethius in: *Cons.* I metr. 7,21 = *De nuptiis*, p. 54,13, Dick (a verse sung by the Muse Euterpe);[28] III metr. IX,22 = p. 79,18;[29] III metr. XII,8 = p. 481,3.[30] The regular structure of the succession of prose and verse, on the other hand, seems to be typical of the *Consolatio*, while in other prosimetra (in those of Martianus Capella as well) this succession is free. The poems that Boethius introduces in the course of his discussion have an essential function, and are connected to the prose part and the arguments included therein that were vital to the development of his reflections. In one passage Boethius asserts (I, 6,57) that the poems are sung by Philosophy with the intention of providing her interlocutor – and therefore the reader too – a break, a pleasing relief to refresh him after the difficulties of the challenging arguments under discussion. In fact, poetry is assigned essentially the function of *delectare* and of *docere*, as was common in Classical Antiquity. The poems often integrate the discussion between Boethius and Lady Philosophy and add tenets previously not considered: no opposition, no contrast between serious (prose) and hedonistic (poetry) elements is to be found in the *Consolatio*.[31] The *Consolatio*, to conclude, is one of the most elaborate and perfect prosimetra of Late Antique literature and it is a masterpiece of the satirical genre – of course, of the *satira* as understood in the age of Boethius, mixing the sublimity of philosophy and the humility of the man Boethius.

Boethius' endeavor to write, for the very first time after the technical works of the past, in a style seeking literary elaboration, is noteworthy and quite successful. In the course of his previous activity he had only composed technical, philosophical and theological, works and appeared to his contemporaries to be a philosopher and a theologian. Literary elaboration had been almost absent in those works. Moreover, when Boethius found it opportune to make certain concessions to literary elaboration, the attempt remained

28 Cf. Tommasi (2012), 60 – 62.

29 More precisely, p. 74,18, Dick. This is certainly the most significative case of Boethius' imitation of Martianus: cf. Martianus II 193: "*Da pater aetherios mentis conscendere coetus*" ("Grant, Father, that I might rise to the aetherial choirs of the Intellect") = Boeth. III metrum IX 22: "*Da, pater, augustam menti conscendere sedem.*" ("Grant, Father, to my mind to rise to your majestic seat"). Boethius, still imitating Martianus, changes, it is clear, considerably the object of the prayer.

30 See Courcelle (1967), 17, n. 2.

31 This has been rightly pointed out by Mueller-Goldingen (1989) 389 – 390, but I am not convinced by his assertion that poetic quotations cannot be explained by the rules of the *prosimetron*, but by the exigences of sublime poetry demanded by Platonism (1989, 390). He observes that Proclus, too, composed sublime poems, such as the Hymns (1989, 377, n. 26), but this is only partly similar to Boethius' *Consolatio* (regarding the exigence of noble poetry), and partly different from it (regarding the literary genre).

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unsuccessful, even though it was in line with the trends of his times, that is with intricate expressions, a verbose and stilted style, far removed from all naturalness. Had he not written the *Consolatio*, Boethius would not deserve to be remembered in literary history. On the contrary, here Boethius was able to write a work exhibiting an unusual ductility and variety of styles, strongly influenced by the use of models (Plato, Cicero, and Seneca). The imitation of the diatribic tone and Platonic dialogue has found a particularly happy form, and is accomplished with extraordinary lightness, so that the development of sentences acquires a clarity, limpidity, and naturalness, which result from long elaboration. Boethius can therefore with good cause be considered, not only for his philosophical ideas but also for his literary production, to be 'the last of the Romans.'

3.5 A satire as a consolation

This being the literary genre of the *Consolatio*, with regard to its content, some scholars have suggested that the *Consolatio* is a consolation only in title, but is in reality a protreptic to philosophy; other scholars have defined it a revelation, or an apocalypse. Courcelle, in a somewhat confused way, states that the *Consolatio* is all three, and names as models Cicero's *Hortensius* (for the protreptic to philosophy), Fulgentius' *Mitologiae* (for the revelation), and the Hermetic *Poimandres* and the *Shepherd of Hermas* (for the apocalypse).[32] We find these lucubrations arbitrary. If Boethius entitled his work *Consolatio philosophiae*, it is an exact designation of what philosophy gave to him while imprisoned and awaiting capital punishment: the consolation he needed and that, besides him, philosophy gives to every man. Therefore Boethius' work, according to its title, fully belongs to consolatory literature, and it is not surprising that he who needs consolation is the author himself, and not someone else: cases of this kind were acceptable since the time of Cicero, who wrote a 'consolation' for himself when his daughter died. That a consolation, which naturally has quite a broad philosophical content (moral and didascalic), should also contain motifs of metaphysical character should be no cause for amazement.[33] Danuta Shanzer comments succinctly:[34] the *Consolatio* is a *consolatio* of death.

32 Courcelle (1967), 18–21.

33 In the preceding pages I expanded what I have previously proposed more briefly and with a different purpose in Boezio (1994) 21–24. I say this because Donato's (2012) recent study confirms the interpretation that the *Consolatio* is indeed a consolation and offers an exhaustive demonstration. Yet I am not convinced of Donato's rejection of the *satura* as the literary genre of the *Consolatio*, both because he interprets *satura* as 'satyre' and because, in his opinion, quoting poems was traditional in consolatory literature. But quoting poems is not the same as composing poems, which is the case of Boethius.

34 Shanzer (1984), 366.

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3.6 Who is Philosophy?

Philosophy, no doubt, is human Wisdom. Is she also Christian Wisdom, as M.T. d'Alverny suggests?[35] Although the *Consolatio* introduces philosophical teaching and apparently does not appeal to Christian religion, is a 'Christian philosophy' entirely excluded? Must we imagine a fundamental opposition between philosophy and religion? Certainly Boethius did not do so. To my mind, this hypothesis, this way of interpreting the *Consolatio* deserves more attention than it has received until now. We concur with Crouse's assertion: "Lady Philosophy is not natural *or* revealed, not philosophy *or* theology; she is simply Sapientia, who can lift her head to pierce the very heavens. […] She is not a Platonist […] she is simply wisdom, old and young, which in its highest speculative form is called theology."[36]

So Philosophy appears suddenly as a woman of venerable aspect, whose identity we cannot yet divine at our first reading. She has a more stately bearing than a human being, revealing her divinity (hence derives the idea that the *Consolatio* may be an 'apocalypse,' a 'revelation');[37] the dimension is superior to the human. Each detail of her figure and her dress is symbolic. Her dress is decorated with the Greek letters 'pi' and 'theta,' which are usually intended to be the initials of *praktikè* and *theoretikè* (scl., philosophy).

Recently other interpretations have been advanced. According to Chadwick,[38] who argues on the basis of a *glossa* by Prudentius of Troyes (died ca. 861 AD)[39] that the *theta* in the garment of Philosophy means death ('*thanatos*'): therefore Boethius sees in Philosophy his death sentence. Shanzer's interpretation is especially sharp and perceptive.[40] She accepts the meaning of the *theta* proposed by Chadwick, i.e. *thanatos*, but she does not hold *thanatos* to be the kind of death appropriate to Philosophy. First, the passage in Prudentius of Troyes simply means that to the name of those who were condemned to death a *theta* was ascribed; second, on the dress of Philosophy *theta* must indeed indicate death, but not Boethius' death. It signifies the 'death' of the passions, i.e. the μελέτη θανάτου (cf. Plat.,

35 D'Alverny (1956), 232 – 44, at 236 (I read the article by d'Alverny thanks to Courcelle (1967), 34 – 35).

36 Crouse (1982), 417 – 21, at 418. See also Micaelli (1995), 28 – 29.

37 Courcelle (1967), 18, 312 – 13. Courcelle followed Klingner's interpretation (1921), 112 – 18.

38 Chadwick (1981), 225 – 6; Ricklin (2003), 137.

39 Prudentius wrote a treatise *de praedestinatione contra Joannem Scotum.* In the preface (PL 115,1012AB) he asserts to have inserted in many passages of his work the very words of John, "*praeposito etiam nomine ipsius cum praecedente illud nota, quae graece dicitur 'theta,' quam sententiis capitalibus damnandorum qui praescribere solebant* ("after having put before [the passage] his name together with the letter which in Greek is said 'theta', which usually was written to mark those condemned to death)."

40 Shanzer (1984), 356.

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Phaed. 67d), which is the object and the aim of philosophy, particularly of Platonic philosophy – the one Boethius followed.

Courcelle states that the ladder depicted on Philosophy's dress indicates the theoretical sciences of the quadrivium, on which Boethius had insisted in *De institutione arithmetica* (p. 9,28, Friedlein = I 1,7 Guillaumin).[41] But according to Shanzer,[42] for the Ancients the ladder indicated routes upward and beyond, it was an image of access to another existence. Therefore, Philosophy reveals the ascent through learning, as it was proposed in Boethius' *De institutione arithmetica.* The *theta* is not merely an actual stigma attached to the dress of a man condemned to death – the meaning envisaged by Chadwick – but has a second, more religious meaning as well: the separation, and salvation, of the soul from the body, i. e. its death, the culmination of the ascent and of the progress on the symbolic ladder. Such a significance is found in Augustine (*De ord.* II 14,39 and 16,44). Philosophy, therefore, is a mirror of Boethius' plan, a philosophical progress that corresponds to the project proposed in the famous passage of the commentary to Aristotle's *De interpretatione* (p. 79,9 – 80,9).[43] She wants to teach Boethius to recognize her first, and consequently himself as a philosopher. But a Christian significance is present as well. Philosophy is Wisdom, to whom Boethius alludes later on (an allusion to the Book of Wisdom 8:1 is found in *Consol.* III 12,22).[44]

So far Danuta Shanzer; her solution is certainly ingenuous, but I am not sure that it is entirely convincing; the traditional interpretation still has a certain amount of probability.

3.7 The structure of the *Consolatio*

The *Consolatio*'s mise-en-scène has been excellently described by Magee, who connects Boethius' description to various scenes of Platonic dialogues. In the *Phaedo*, Plato introduces Socrates composing poems in obedience to a dream ordering him to dedicate them to music: Socrates at first interprets it as an order to dedicate himself to philosophy, but then to composing poetry, so he composes a hymn to Apollo (*Phaed.* 60d–61a). In the *Crito*, Socrates recounts a dream about a beautiful woman who announces to him that in three days he would go to Phthia, i. e. to the underworld. So here "we have the main elements of the mise-en-scène of the *Consolatio:* an unjust imprisonment, a dream

41 Courcelle (1967), 26.
42 Shanzer (1984), 358.
43 It has been quoted extensively above (p. 24 – 25).
44 One of the rarest allusions to Holy Scripture, which is capital for those scholars who assert the presence of a Christian inspiration in the *Consolatio.*

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vision (one a female apparition), swan songs, and of course Philosophy and the anticipation of death."[45]

Summaries of the discussion of the *Consolatio* have been provided by Joachim Gruber in his commentary and (with greater attention to the philosophical problems) Thomas Jürgasch.[46] The best exegesis has been provided by Giulio D'Onofrio, who underlined many correspondences between the *Consolatio* and Boethius' previous works.[47] Here, we only wish to briefly consider a few issues.

3.8 *De remediis utriusque fortunae* (Petrarch)

Since Philosophy is identified with Wisdom, her aim is to console her disciple, who had previously dedicated all his energies to investigating the most arduous and difficult problems, such as natural science and astronomy, the latter being a symbol of disinterested studies on sublime topics (I metrum II), in his present state of affliction and dejection. Like the Muses, Philosophy, too, pities Boethius, but shows this in a different way, by intoning a severe – but still pleasant – chant and by filling his verses with moral, philosophical, and theological content. Boethius is now immersed in matter and darkness, and the pain and grief consuming him are nothing but the external symptom of his error; yet, the studies he had practised in the past had made him equal to God. Philosophy recognizes her disciple, no matter how he has changed, and immediately assumes her function of comforting, that is of healing the illness of his soul. Real consolation, in fact, does not consist in offering superficial poultices, which might abate the pain with their ephemeral sweetness, but in true healing, in curing the reasons, not just the effects. In Antiquity, philosophical consolation was considered to be a cure, which observed specific symptoms in the soul and applied to them appropriate remedies, being thus similar to the cure of the body. It was therefore not strange that the same technical terms were commonly applied to the cure of the soul as in medicine (this is also the case in the *Consolatio*). Thus, the reasoning of Philosophy as it develops the different problems also becomes increasingly difficult and arduous. Her suggestions and considerations are compared to cures applied to the sick: at first they are milder, then more and more severe, until they reach the depths. Philosophy touches the eyes of the sick, and immediately the cloud obfuscating them is removed: I metrum III expounds this psychological process, by comparison with the sun that appears to enlighten the earth after a storm.

45 Magee (2003), 148 – 50.
46 Jürgasch (2013), 345 – 97.
47 D'Onofrio (2008), 77 – 142, at 131 – 42.

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The cure of the soul begins in I 3. First, Philosophy shows Boethius that the persecution he is suffering is no different from that which had befallen her or other philosophers in the past (the Greeks Socrates, Anaxagoras, Zeno and the Latins Canius, Seneca, and Soranus) (I 3,9). These observations were common in ancient consolatory literature (for instance, the death of a dear person is a fact that occurs in the entire universe according to the law of nature).[48] Yet, no matter how violent and insolent the enemies who attack and maltreat philosophers may be, these can safely take refuge in the tower of wisdom, allowing the assailers to pillage things of small worth. This means that the violence cannot deprive the philosopher of the most precious thing, his internal values, and he can serenely leave to the plundering of the violent his material goods, which are of little value. The next poem confirms the superiority of the philosopher, presenting a glimpse of the tyrant (who is violent by nature) in the grip of emotions, while the philosopher remains serene. The mention of tyrants, encountered several times in the *Consolatio*, certainly contain references to the threatening tyrant Theoderic.[49] In I 4, where Boethius recalls his past and reasserts with pride the noble feelings that always inspired his behavior according to the purest precepts of Platonic philosophy, when for the common welfare he opposed the brutalities and snares of despicable people, the king is prudently not named.

In reaction to such human baseness, Boethius himself intones the next poem, differently from the usual pattern in the *Consolatio*, where Philosophy clarifies further on and synthesizes by a poetical composition the results achieved in the dialogue. Boethius addresses the creator and ruler of the universe, underscoring the contrast between the disorder that dominates in human life and the order that governs natural phenomena, and prays that human beings may also be ruled by the laws of cosmic harmony. Boethius' emotions lead Philosophy to intervene once again to correct the errors of her disciple. The true homeland of man is elsewhere, she says in prose five, within the limits fixed by philosophy, and from this homeland Boethius has wandered away entirely by his own will, he was not driven away by the wicked. For this reason, the supposed disorder troubling human life does not really exist, because it is each single person who of his own accord abandons his own condition of balance and ataraxy and allows external events to trouble him. The true man does not belong to the kingdom of disorder, but to that kingdom in which there is one single lord and monarch, as a famous Homeric verse says (*Iliad* II 204 – 5), which Aristotle himself had reviewed and given a theological meaning in his *Metaphysics* (1076a4).

This general conclusion seals the thought of I 5; and Philosophy, before applying to Boethius the remedy he needs, wants to emphasize how serious his

48 Cf. Seneca, *consol. Marc.* 9; *consol. Helv.* 5; *consol. Pol.* 11; Plut., *de exilio* 599D; Ps. Plut., *consol. Apoll.* 112D; Gruber, *ad loc.*

49 On the topic see Magee (2005), 348 – 64.

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illness is, so she questions him to bring to light his state of ignorance, confusion, and torpidity. In fact, Boethius does know very little, only that the world was created by God; he has forgotten himself and reduced himself to knowing only the Scholastic definition of man: "*animal rationale atque mortale*" (I 6,15). Even though this is elementary knowledge, it still constitutes a spark of health, which Philosophy must nourish and corroborate, so that Boethius may reach his first healing. Afterwards (but Philosophy asserts it as the first problem) it will be necessary to investigate the purpose and goal of the universe and the nature of man, who lives in it (I 6,1–14): this Philosophy will do in the second part of the work (from book III metrum IX to book V). With this motif of cosmic harmony, which must also reign in the soul of man, the first book ends with a poem of extreme significance (I metrum VII). Therefore, this seems to be the central motif of the first book.

The second book is more compact and is entirely centered on the moral and philosophical theme of human vanity: while this constitutes the first remedy for Boethius' infirmities, it is still an insufficient consolation, which will have to be replaced in the second part of the work by an explanation based on the principles of metaphysics. Since the first book appears to be essentially divided into two parts (a pressing request from Philosophy that Boethius remove himself from earthly affairs, and a self-defence by Boethius, who now requires a spiritual cure), so also may the second be divided into two sections. In the first, the fact is considered that human life is subject to fortune, whose constant unpredictability is underlined, even though it is still part of the things established by God; in the second, the conclusion is drawn that the error of trusting 'the wheel of fortune' can only be ascribed to Boethius himself. Boethius attributes an excessively great ontological dignity to fortune, which is commonly considered to be a reality with uncertain contours, so that it becomes the particular object of moralizing or literary observations. Stoicism, which Boethius was certainly familiar with, had already assigned to fortune a precise role in the universe. An examination of fortune as a metaphysical entity will be the object of the successive discussions of the fourth and fifth book: for now (certainly intentionally, in view of the structure of Boethius' doctrine ascending by degrees), it is developed at a lower level, in line with the many ancient diatribes on the theme of fortune, its blind will, and the mandatory necessity for the wise not to be troubled by it. Such themes had become trite especially in Stoic and Cynic philosophy, and the moralizing prose of the Imperial age: several echoes of these diatribes, often used for the purpose of consoling, can be noticed in the *Consolatio:* besides Seneca, the presence of Cicero is strong, who used the same motifs especially in the *Tusculanae* and probably in the *Consolatio* as well, which was written for the death of his daughter. After all, right at the end of the second book the references to Cicero, and more specifically to the *Somnium Scipionis* become particularly evident. The first two prose passages of the second book are developed by means of pathetic allocutions and exhortations to distrust

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fortune, and by means of the justifications fortune itself might put forward to defend its actions: they can appear to be blind and unfair to him who is always centered on the insatiable search for his own profit, but never really absurd. This consideration introduces a *prosopopoeia* (II 2), a rhetorical figure quite frequent in the moralizing prose of the Hellenistic and Imperial age; then, to each of these prose passages the relevant poems are added without providing new motifs but rather as a confirmation. Thus the first part, devoted to investigating the reality of fortune, its dominion over human beings, the attitude the wise must assume before it, concludes.

Then the attention is shifted (II 3 and 4) to the particular case of Boethius, who had been greatly favored by fortune in previous years: even at the present moment when he complains that he is in jail, those dearest to him are safe and thriving. Boethius, therefore, has no reason to complain: fortune has behaved according to its practice, that is, it has been fickle and blind, but has done nothing against its own nature – even though the assumption seems inevitable that there was some 'wishful thinking' on Boethius' part.

With the second part of the book, beginning with II 5, Philosophy proceeds to the second stage of her cure by applying stronger remedies. They consist in demonstrating how all the things humans believe to be good, such as power, wealth, dignity, are in reality not so, when observed in their essence, or are ephemeral, even though they may possess, at least in part, a positive value, like glory and fame. This discussion introduces a series of remarks not particularly new, which progress, just like the previous ones, in the context of philosophical precepts; once again, Seneca and Cicero were probably the models for Boethius.[50]

At this stage, the discussion could be considered finished, but Boethius wishes to examine one final issue, which was usually condemned in the moralistic treatises of ancient philosophy and criticized together with the previous ones: the desire for glory. Therefore the quality of the discussion (II 7) suddenly increases, abandoning conventional and topical motifs to assume a quite personal connotation. It is Boethius himself speaking, a former consul: he had begun his *cursus honorum* in his early youth and held important offices, as he recounts with a certain complacency and abundant detail in II 3 and 4. The fame and political power that he once enjoyed greatly contrast the present sad situation. It is natural, therefore, that in Boethius' words on glory personal motifs emerge, not present in the banal diatribes of the ancient moralists, addressed to all and without reference to concrete cases. Seneca might represent an exception, because he devoted himself to philosophy during and after exercizing the power of his office. Boethius openly confesses that he had looked for glory, albeit not because of a desire for power or out of

50 These are *topoi* which can be found everywhere in the moral literature; see Cicero, *Tusc.* III 75 – 77; Seneca, *consol. Pol.* 18; *consol. Helv.* 5; Pseudo-Plut., *consol. Apoll.* 103F; 121F–122 A etc.; Gruber's annotations *ad loc.*

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vanity, but in order to allow virtue to manifest itself in him, while he engaged himself in political activities. But also human glory is limited in space and temporary, Philosophy replies. With this Boethius echoes many remarks already developed by Cicero in the *Somnium Scipionis*, to which he connects himself explicitly. But what may appear as a purely literary and erudite link is vivified by the personal adhesion of the writer to a pessimistic vision. Certainly Cicero, too, had asserted in the *Somnium Scipionis* how short the duration of human glory is and how limited its extension in space, but had also indicated to political men its real purpose, the welfare of their homeland, which helped to overcome the dejection that the consideration of the vanity of fame would have produced. Philosophy, however, does not propose any future to glory, which is destined to meet the same end as all other human things.

Such being the case, the philosopher dedicates his considerations to a nobler issue and considers human life as the object of divine Love, just like all parts of the universe (II metrum VIII). In this poem, Boethius exalts cosmic love, which is present in sensual reality where the opposing forces are bound by an eternal accord and harmony producing peace and balance, but unfortunately not in the world of human beings: it is their duty, therefore, to conform to the universal harmony. According to Boethius, the "amor che muove il sole e l'altre stelle," as Dante concludes his Paradise, is a metaphysical force, is the effect of the aspiration of the entire universe towards God in conformity with the teachings of Proclus and Dionysius the Areopagite (cf. *De div. nomin.* 4,10). The poem intends to demonstrate that the power of fortune, on which the second book had so insisted, is by now overcome: the dominating force over the entire universe is the love of God; to it Boethius' reflections will have to turn now, and rationally justify what poetry had claimed.[51]

Now the time has come to apply to the sick the strongest cures (III 1 and III metrum I). If the doctrines of the second book belong especially to Cynic-Stoic philosophy and protreptic and consolatory literature, those of the third introduce us to the heart of the matter, that is, they wish to establish the '*telos*,' the final purpose of human beings according to Platonism: thus, Boethius gradually arrives at his own philosophy. The third book is divided into two

51 Klingner (1921, 26 – 27), was the first to perceive a link, with regard to the Boethian doctrine of love, between Boethius on the one side and Dionysius the Aeropagite and Dante on the other. De Vogel (1963, 2 – 34, (1981), 193 – 200) expanded Klingner's short explanation: Dionysius, she stated, also underlined the strength of cosmic love in *div. nomin.* 4,13 and 16, and, most importantly, a correspondence between Boethius and Proclus (*comm. Alcib.* 45,4 and 55,12 Westerink, = p. 36 and 45 Segonds) can be found. Such a new meaning of cosmic love is, in de Vogel's opinion, the consequence of Neoplatonic speculation on the topic of love, which had been discussed already by Plotinus. I find her arguments quite convincing.
The incipit of II metrum 8,1 – 4 echoes the *Hymn to Hymenaeus*, right at the beginning of the *De nuptiis* by Martianus Capella (cf. Tommasi (2012, 153 – 4).

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sections by poem IX, thereby dividing the entire *Consolatio* into two parts.[52] Before III metrum IX the issue of '*telos*' is treated from a negative perspective, that is, Boethius examines those things that do not constitute the true purpose of man, whereas after that poem, the ensuing discussion is focused precisely on defining what this purpose actually is.

Poem IX of book III is sung by Philosophy, a hymn of invocation to the God of the universe, so that he may concede the knowledge of the loftiest realities; Plato had already stated, after all, that before any enterprise it is necessary to invoke God (cf. *Tim*. 27c). After exploiting the simpler considerations on fortune and on the sickness of men, III metrum IX sets out the true doctrine (namely, the Neo-Platonic) as the basis for a new investigation and for any further discussion. Neo-Platonic doctrine dominates the second part of the work, the *construens* one. Poem IX is a hymn of invocation to the God of the universe and celebrates his praise; it is the last and splendid example in the long Greek and Latin literary tradition of hymns to divinities, dating back to Homer. The Christian Boethius addresses God, writing his prayer in the style of pagan poetry in which he was educated. Poetical hymns of philosophical and religious content were part of Hellenistic and Roman culture; philosophical hymns exalting and adoring the Christian God were composed by Synesius of Cyrene; closer to Boethius, and probably well-known to him was the work of Martianus Capella, the *De nuptiis* (see II, 185 – 93). The philosophy professed by Martianus in his extremely obscure and nebulous work was a mixture of Chaldaean theurgy and Iamblichus' Neo-Platonism. Important was also the hymn IX 911 (the '*egersimon ineffabile*' 'unutterable awakening song') sung by Harmony in the *De Nuptiis:* Harmony directs her prayer to Jupiter, the supreme deity of paganism, just as Philosophia invokes the Neo-Platonic God.[53] But none of the fogs of Martianus have flowed into the limpid poetry of Boethius, who concentrated in thirty verses the Platonic doctrine of the *Timaeus*, together with Neo-Platonic exegesis of the *Timaeus* taken from Proclus and other philosophers of his time.

3.9 Philosophy and Religion in the *Consolatio*

3.9.1 The Neo-Platonism of the *Consolatio*

The philosophical content of III metrum IX can be summarized as follows: God the Creator, remaining motionless, is the engine of the universe, and governs all with eternal and rational laws; such a governance of the world is

52 Gruber has observed (Boethius (^{2}2006), 266) that the metrical structure of this poem, in glyconic, corresponds to that of I metrum VI, to which it ideally refers.

53 This has been explained by Tommasi (2012), 210 – 3.

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determined solely by goodness and manifests itself through an unbroken harmonious relationship between the individual parts, made possible by the presence of the cosmic soul, which pervades all. The cosmic soul, which is inside the world, is understood in the Platonic sense as the eternal principle of life and motion (cf. the passage, fundamental to all Neo-Platonic exegesis, in *Phaedrus* 245c: ψυχὴ πᾶσα ἀθάνατος· τὸ μὲν γὰρ ἀεικίνητον ἀθάνατον).[54] The Neo-Platonists combined the doctrine of the *Phaedrus* with that of the *Timaeus* (36b–37a), asserting that the soul is divided into two parts, each of which returns to itself in a circular motion: it is the motion of 'conversion' (ἐπιστροφή), which allows the return of all things to their principle of life, after they had 'come out' of it (πρόοδος). From the cosmic soul descend the souls of individual living beings, which possess an 'aerial chariot,' that is to say a material vehicle, very lightweight, with which they traverse the regions of the sky.[55] The same requirement of 'conversion' is present in human souls: they all aspire to this 'return' to the God who created them. Therefore Boethius, through the mouth of Philosophy, prays: "*Da, Pater, augustam menti conscendere sedem*," (III metrum IX, 22), most likely adopting an expression taken from the epic and didactic poet Tiberianus (*Carmen* 4,28): "*Da, pater, augustas ut possim noscere causas*,"[56] and also from Martianus Capella (*De nuptiis* II 193): "*Da pater aetherios mentis conscendere coetus.*" Only on God, in fact, must we keep our eyes fixed, because he is our principle, guide, way, and ultimate goal.

Boethius' successive reasoning develops through a series of postulates. It is necessary to see whether that highest good, of which Philosophy and Boethius were speaking at the beginning of book three, exists from an ethical point of view in the cosmic reality, too, being a metaphysical principle. Its existence is asserted by means of a postulate, it is not demonstrated *a posteriori* (III 10). If the "*fons bonorum*" is God, whose existence both for the Christian and the Neo-Platonist needs no demonstration, what requires proper interpretation is the meaning of material reality. In the preceding discussion, it was demonstrated that the highest good of men consists in happiness, and that other worldly goods are only partial goods and are not identical to happiness nor able to procure it. Precisely because two highest realities cannot exist, it must be concluded that God is the "*summum bonum*" not only as the '*telos*,' but also on an ontological level. Therefore, God is identical to happiness and the ultimate goal is the good (III 11). Earlier it was said that the good is really

54 "Every soul [or: soul in its entirety] is immortal, for what is in everlasting movement is immortal."

55 See, for instance, Procl., *element.* 196 and 205–209; *comm. Tim.* III 268,26. The doctrine of the vehicle of the soul is asserted also by Hermetism, see *CH* I 25–26 and had a revival in the Platonism of the Renaissance. Marsilius Ficinus followed Proclus for this topic and discussed it extensively in the *Theologia Platonica.*

56 "Grant, Father, that I might know the venerable causes of the universe". The *locus parallelus* of Martianus Capella and Boethius was considered above, note 29.

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one and transcendent, as none of the worldly goods was such as to exclude any other; then, the real good was identified with happiness and with God; now it is asserted that the real good is God, and that it is one. For God bestows on all things their subsistence, not because he creates them materially or preserves them in life, but by giving them the possibility to exist, which consists in being one thing. This was already asserted in the *Contra Eutychen et Nestorium* (3,250 – 2): God is, according to Porphyry, the Good (τἀγαθόν), and since beside it there cannot be another First Principle which is good, for Boethius, God is one and good and allows all things to exist. Therefore, all things, both animate and inanimate, tend to the One/Good, because without it they would not exist.

What follows is another basic tenet of Neo-Platonism, that of the non-existence of evil. Once it is established that God is identified with the highest good, it follows that, in the first instance, there cannot be a principle of evil, because otherwise two principles would exist (and this fixed point of Neo-Platonic doctrine on the non-existence of evil was also emphasized by Christian writers, especially in opposition to Manichaeism). Seeing also that all things derive their existence from the One, that is from God (also the tenet of the *De hebdomadibus*), consequently nothing is evil. Finally, if God, who is the supreme good, is being *par excellence*, it follows that what is evil has no existence. This was a fundamental doctrine in the Platonic tradition, both pagan and Christian: it is found, for example, in Plotinus, Origen, Gregory of Nyssa, and Augustine.[57]

The third book ends (III metrum XII) with the retelling of the myth, of the descent of Orpheus into the underworld, interpreted in a Neo-Platonic perspective. It symbolizes the descent of man into the darkness of the material world, from which he can and must re-emerge. But man must take care not to turn back again to matter, so as not to fall into it, as it happened to Orpheus, who, having turned his gaze back to Tartarus, lost Eurydice. The interest of the Neo-Platonists in myths, especially those of Homer, which they believed should be interpreted allegorically, is well known. Moreover, given the centrality of the Homeric poems in classical culture, it is no wonder the Neo-Platonists had no intention of excluding them from their thought (as Plato had proposed to do), but rather turned to them instead to find, through an appropriate allegorical interpretation, a confirmation of their doctrines.[58]

57 Cf. Plot. I 8,1; Orig., *princ.* II 9,2; *comm. Ioh.* II 13,99; Greg. Nyss., *an. et resurr.* PG 46, 93B; *orat. catech.* 5,11 – 12; *Eccl. Hom.* V 2 and VII 7; Ambros., *Isaac* 7,60; August., *vera relig.* 11,21 ss.; *conf.* III 12; VII 12,18 – 19 etc. Of course, this assertion does not imply the consequence that evil does not exist absolutely: the non-being of evil is not an absence in the sense of nothingness, like the non-being out of which God called the creation into being, but a negative condition within being that results from a withdrawal from a being that is already present (cf. A. A. Mosshammer (1990), 140).

58 On this topic the bibliography is extensive; see, for instance, R.L. Lamberton (1986), on Boethius 276 – 9.

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The fourth book deals with another fundamental element of Boethius' theodicy. Evil, as admitted, does not exist: it is a fact, however, that men commit evil, and therefore it exists, if not on the ontological level, certainly on a moral level; hence the need to consider it as existing in some way, so as to cancel its damage and efficacy. It is a fundamental tenet of ethics, demonstrated by Plato in the *Gorgias*, that one who commits evil is, contrary to the common convictions of men, weak, unhappy, and worthy of pity, unlike the honest man. Men, in fact, tend to the good by nature, both to that which is true and also to that which is only visible. However, while someone who is good will act well in any case, a bad man cannot, either because he is bad, and therefore intentionally does not want to act well, or because he is blinded by error and commits evil, mistaking it for good. He who cannot do what he wants must be considered weaker than the one who can, and this applies even more to the man who cannot do the most excellent thing of all, namely what is good. He who is convinced of this truth can now complete by his own strength his return towards the heavenly homeland, because he will no longer be troubled by the violence and disorder in the world, as is asserted at the end of book IV 2 and confirmed in IV metrum II. All this derives from Plato's *Gorgias* (466b–470e). The good, then, possess their own goodness as a reward, and no one can take it from them; thus they are destined to become, in a sense, God, thanks to the presence of the good in them, which is God himself. The wicked, on the other hand, are sinking deeper and deeper into a feral state and lose their human characteristics: a doctrine dating back to Plato's *Phaedo* (81e–82a; see also *Tim.* 42c) and common to Neo-Platonism, too. This conviction is supported, once again, by the allegorical interpretation (IV metrum III) of a myth, that of Circe, who had turned Odysseus' companions into swine (*Odyss.* X 133–77). Only Odysseus, thanks to the help of the god and his own intelligence, was saved: the emblematic and didactic function of the Homeric myth is evident. Continuing in the argument inspired by Plato's *Gorgias* (472e–480a), Boethius asserts that the wicked are unhappy precisely for being so, and that they receive some relief from their misery only by paying the appropriate penalty for their wickedness. He who manages to avoid it deserves more compassion than he, who, on the contrary, pays the due penalty, because the latter can, at least in part, free himself from evil.

We shall now return to the starting point: how to harmonize the certainty of the existence of good and evil with the unfolding of God's providence? If, as is evident to all, worldly goods, which although not true goods are such at least in part, as Aristotle says (*Nicomachean Ethics* 1178a25–b3), come to men at random, then one must conclude that their distribution is unjust. If, however, there is a God who guides all things, even the dispensation of good and evil must be due to certain causes, which must be explained.

Therefore one must proceed to the examination of those two forces, apparently contradictory, that govern the affairs of all: Providence and Fate. Providence and Fate are two sides of the same reality: the first is reason,

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grounded in God, that orders all things in a manner consistent with the simplicity and the immobility of God's very being; fate is of the same order, yet is considered by its influence on the world. It refers to the multiple intertwining of all things that come into being and move: all that is subject to fate is also subjected to providence, because fate is subordinate to providence. Providence and fate dispose of a man's life, because God knows in advance good and evil. Even if man does not know the difference between the two, he should still have faith in the guidance of God. Destiny is effectuated by one of six different entities, intermediate between God and man: the spirits, which oversee divination, the world soul, the nature of the whole, the movement of the stars, the angelic powers, or the demons. However, any destiny, good or bad, is assigned to men either in order that the good exercize themselves in the practice of virtue and endurance of material evil, or in order that the wicked derive from it the means for their improvement. Therefore, any destiny is basically good, even if men do not consider it as such: but they are not able to perceive, on account of their limitations, the intrinsic reality.

The fifth book immediately connects to these problems. It constitutes the summit of Boethius' thought, now confronting two issues considered closely related to the previous (providence and fate), namely those of providence and free will. One must keep in mind that Boethius frequently uses the term 'foreseeing' or 'foreknowledge' ("*praescientia*") to designate the providence of God when he wishes to emphasize not so much his providential activity, which disposes of things for the good of man, but the fact that he knows in advance the outcome of various events. This book gathers, through an ideal internal reference to the earlier parts of the work, the answers to many questions that Boethius posed at the beginning of his discussion with Philosophy, on the meaning of human misery and the disorder that reigns on earth. In V 1 the meanings of the words 'random' and 'accidental' are defined according to Aristotle (*Phys.* II 4–6). As observed by Courcelle, two theories collide here: one, supported by a Boethius not yet properly informed on the problem, which tends to emphasize the contradiction between divine foreknowledge and free will, and the other, that of Philosophy, which seeks to resolve it.[59] Chance does not exist in an absolute sense, and its usual meaning of 'event not produced by its own cause' is actually a contradiction in terms. Nothing originates from nothing, the ancient philosophers already observed, although they had proposed this statement only for physical reality. Chance exists only in appearance, and is owed to the fact that men do not know the causes of events.

After denying, therefore, the existence of chance, the existence of free will and the providence of God is confronted, that is the 'previous knowledge' God has of all future things, of what will come to pass, and of the chain of causes that has led to it. Every rational being has the freedom of his own will, and God

59 Courcelle (1967), 208–21. The problem has been re-examined at length by Sharples (2009), 207–27 (with bibliography).

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possesses it more than any other. In proportion to its distance from God, reality, according to the interpretation of the Neo-Platonists, descends by degrees into an indeterminate state and lack of freedom. First are the souls who contemplate God, then those that are in a body, next the souls that are chained inside the limbs of the body, and finally those that have moved away from reason and have abandoned themselves to vice. Providence, however, dominates them all. In what sense does God know human affairs? It is necessary, in fact, to safeguard the foreknowledge of God and together not to predetermine the future, for if human activity were previously known by God, as the knowledge of God is infallible, it would be predetermined, inasmuch as what God knows cannot but come to pass. First it is necessary to discard the wrong solution (which was proposed by Origen,[60] not mentioned by Boethius): God knows in advance the things that will happen, but not because they will occur and then will determine God's previous knowledge.[61] This explanation is wrong, because, even if it apparently saves man's free will, it makes God (or God's knowledge) depend on things that are to happen, and not vice versa.

The problem of God's knowledge and a man's free will had already been treated by Cicero and Boethius himself in his logical works, and the solution is as follows. The apparent contradiction is caused by the fact that men confuse the chain of causes and the foreknowledge of God. The relationship between knowing that something is coming to pass and its real fulfilment depends on how one defines 'knowing.' Men are not able to see and to know reality in the same way God does. Reality, in fact, is not known according to its essence, but according to the nature of those who know it. These cognitive faculties, in turn, are arranged as an ascending gradation of values and functions, corresponding to the place the knower occupies in cosmic reality. One way is how an animal knows, purely sensory and imaginative, another that of man, who also adds the rational faculty to sensation and the imagination. Its highest degree can incorporate the lowest, but never can, conversely, the lowest make use of the highest.[62] The hierarchical structure of the universe, in short, is also reflected in the gradation of knowledge. Thus men can see on a temporary and limited basis, while God, on the other hand, possesses because of the '*simplicitas*' of his nature the ability to see the universe in its entirety. Eternity is a specific prerogative of God, which consists in the reduction to '*simplicitas*' of the multiplicity that winds through the course of time, within which man finds himself, lives, and, finally, comes to know (and he does that over time, in a fragmented way, moment by moment). Thus, God knows eternally, that is in a total and immediate way. If, therefore, divine providence sees in advance the

60 See Origen, *Philocalia*, 25.

61 This assertion contradicts Origen's doctrine of the 'future contingents' and the knowledge God has of them, although it is not clear how Boethius could have known Origen's opinion.

62 This statement, that the nature of knowledge is determined by the nature of the knower rather than by that of the thing known, goes back to Iamblichus (cf. Sharples (2009), 216).

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events produced by the free will of man, it does not on account of this determine them, but limits itself precisely to seeing them from eternity. This was asserted by Proclus, *Element*. 52: πᾶν τὸ αἰώνιον ὅλον ἅμα ἐστίν ("all that is eternal is simultaneous wholeness"); '*simplicitas*' is another Neo-Platonic tenet already asserted by Boethius in his theological works.

Eternity, therefore, is proper to God, time to the human condition. Eternity is pure presence, not the fragmentation of the infinity of time into past, present, and future; it is not an infinite persistence in time, which is what Plato had attributed to the world (a doctrine that Boethius, though Christian, adopts from Plato). The condition of the world is to have a beginning (even if not in time, nevertheless a principle of ontological dependence), but not a determinate ending point in time; it constitutes perpetuity ('*perpetuitas*'), not eternity, which is God's quality.

It follows that it is absurd to think of a determination of the future by the foreknowledge of God, because everything happens in his presence in an eternal present, both what happens by necessity and what happens as a result of human free will. God sees in the same way both what is necessary (for example, the result of physical laws) and what is contingent (events resulting from man's free will). Of course, what God knows must happen happens; yet this knowledge of God is knowledge of the present, not a determination of the future, whereby God also knows all the possibilities that a man weighs prior to taking action, those on account of which the man decides as well as those which he decides against. Therefore, man's freedom of will is preserved, even if foreseen by God.[63] And here is the final exhortation of a man who is about to be executed: if God sees all the actions of men, they must be aware that they live and act always before His eternal presence, and must therefore act accordingly.

These two important problems, concerning God and eternity – perpetuity on the one hand, and God and the human free will on the other, were treated by Boethius in the *Consolatio* according to two basic tenets of Neo-Platonism and Aristotelianism. Boethius solves the first following the doctrine of Ammonius.[64] The problem of the so-called 'future contingents' depends on Boethius' own discussion in the *In Aristotelis de interpretatione editio secunda* (pp. 222,9 – 224,26 and 224,27 – 227,4, Meiser): so we find ourselves here in the field of the Neo-Platonic interpretations of Aristotle.[65]

In conclusion, Boethius follows in the *Consolatio* contemporary Neo-Platonism, supplemented by the own teachings of Plato and Aristotle. Some

63 We have summarized here the entire body of problems of the so-called '*futura contingentia*.' For a more thorough examination of the topic see Galonnier (2003), 571 – 97 and Marenbon (2003a), 531 – 46, (both with bibliography).

64 This is an important demonstration provided by Courcelle (1967, 215–29), whose arguments have been generally accepted by other scholars (see for instance Obertello (1974), 540 – 4, (2003), 465 – 79).

65 Courcelle (1967), 208 – 21, (in particular 217 – 20), Obertello (1974), 536 – 40.

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elements are attributable to Iamblichus[66] or Alexander of Aphrodisias:[67] they were probably already present in the works of Ammonius or Proclus, which Boethius used. Just as Marius Victorinus had reworked the speculations of Porphyry in his writings on logic and theology, Boethius revises in the same manner the teachings of Ammonius and Proclus; he prepares a complex of homogeneous and well-organized doctrines for the Latin Middle Ages, which will prove particularly stimulating and fertile in later developments. His sources were Marius Victorinus in theology, and Proclus and Ammonius in metaphysics. Latin philosophy is represented in particular by Cicero, Seneca, and Augustine. We shall consider the presence of Latin philosophy in greater detail shortly.

The Neo-Platonism of the *Consolatio* emerges in degrees. It is located in the second half of the work, almost as the summit and culmination of the argument, to which one ascends with difficulty by way of other non-Platonic doctrines, such as the Cynic-Stoic contempt for earthly things and of fortune, contained in the first two books, or the argument taken by Philosophy from Plato's *Gorgias*, which, although Platonic, is still not essential to the cosmic vision. The *Consolatio* has, therefore, a clear structure according to the scheme of the ascent to the highest truth.

Until the mid-twentieth century, Boethius was generally considered (although with some exceptions) especially as a writer who 'drew' (to use the terminology proper to 'source criticism') from Cicero or the exoteric writings of Aristotle (the lost ones) or from a Neo-Platonist posterior to Plotinus (for example, Iamblichus). These attempts, which have resulted in a dismembering of the philosophy of the *Consolatio*, now appear for the most part inconclusive. It was the achievement of Pierre Courcelle to identify in the Neo-Platonism contemporary to Boethius – more precisely in that of Ammonius and Proclus – the origin of the doctrines of the *Consolatio*. It is interesting to observe that Boethius' quotes of Parmenides (certainly not accessible in Rome in the original) and of Homer can also be found in Proclus.[68] The verse attributed by Boethius to one "*excellentior*" than Philosophy (IV 6,38: ἀνδρὸς δὴ ἱεροῦ δέμας αἰθέρες οἰκοδόμησαν) also belongs to one of the anonymous collections of Orphic or Chaldaean poems, such as those so frequently employed by Proclus.[69]

66 The doctrine of the different degrees of knowledge, discussed by Boethius in *consol.* V 6,53 ss. has a parallel in Ammonius, *comm. de interpr.* pp. 135 – 136, but Ammonius attributes his explanation to Iamblichus (cf. Klingner (1921) 107; Courcelle (1967) 217 and 221).

67 The question of whether to know the future means to determine it (see *consol.* V 2 ss.) had been discussed by Alexander Aphrodisiensis, *de fato* 30, and Ammonius (*comm. de interpr.* p. 137, 1 ss.) followed him (Courcelle (1967) 213 – 216).

68 Courcelle (1967), 166 – 7.

69 Courcelle (1967), 167. Danuta Shanzer suggests instead a Hermetic origin of this verse (cf. Shanzer (1983), 277 – 83). Hermetic verses have not yet been found elsewhere, however. Mueller-Goldingen concludes by a *non liquet* (1989) 388, n. 51.

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Certainly, some details of Courcelle's analysis have since been disproven (which is always unavoidable), for example, that Boethius allegedly attended the school of Ammonius in Alexandria.[70] The long passages in the third and fourth books, which expound Platonic doctrines, are not necessarily derived from Neo-Platonic commentaries on Plato's dialogues, as supposed by Courcelle. John Magee's studies have demonstrated the direct imitation of Plato's *Gorgias* by Boethius.[71] There is nothing to prevent us from believing that Boethius possessed, along with works of the Platonists of his day, some of the most widely read dialogues of Plato, like the *Protagoras*, the *Gorgias*, and the *Timaeus*.

Among Boethius' Latin sources, indicated by Courcelle, is Macrobius' *Commentary*, which expands and modifies in some details Cicero's *Somnium Scipionis* (6,22).[72] Yet Boethius does not seem to have adopted a real philosophical (or specifically Neo-Platonic) doctrine from Macrobius, but merely certain details about the geography of the Roman Empire, connected to his depreciation of human fame. But we shall return to other (more philosophical) tenets of Macrobius later.[73] Subsequent scholars have also conducted a series of studies on the origin of the doctrine of Boethius, so that currently we concur with Obertello that research on the sources can be considered completed.[74]

70 Besides Courcelle's innovative work from (1948), we consider definitive as well Courcelle (1967). For this topic see in particular 161 – 76.

71 Magee (2009), 181 – 206. See also, by the same scholar (2014 – forthcoming).

72 Cf. Courcelle (1967), 116 – 8, 120 – 7. Courcelle examines some details that have no real philosophical significance. Boethius quotes Macrobius also at the beginning of his career (*In Isag. Porph.* I 11, CSEL 48, p. 31,19), with an exact reference to the *Commentarii in Somnium Scipionis* (I 5,5) and calling Macrobius "*doctissimus vir*".

73 Anne Crabbe, referring to the problem we considered above, of the freedom Boethius might have enjoyed in Pavia after his sentence and before his execution, supports an innovative argument: "How can it be legitimate to talk in terms of such a mosaic of sources and inspirations for a work whose author was incarcerated at Pavia under sentence of death without access to his library?" Crabbe tends, therefore, to reduce the number of sources, both literary and philosophical. Imprisonment allows Boethius to use only the most essential themes of that philosophy. Her aim is to reduce the influence of pagan philosophy and to bring Boethius back to Augustine only, as his '*fons unicus*' (see Crabbe (1981), 241 – 2, 253 – 6). It is possible that some Augustinian doctrines (which are also Neo-Platonic in origin) provide the basis for several of Boethius' discussions, such as that on the highest good and the identification of it with God and happiness, in which the Christian Neo-Platonic tradition unites with the Latin one, as we shall see later on, but the evidence for the Neo-Platonic origin of Boethius' doctrine and its sources cannot be dismissed.

74 Obertello (1974), 447.

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3.9.2 The *Consolatio* and the tradition of Latin Neo-Platonism

This problem, as we state it, rules out *a priori* any further research into sources, and not without reason. The list of the sources of the *Consolatio* is fully established.[75] However, is the presence of Latin philosophy in Boethius to be excluded? This is the opinion of Courcelle, "Boèce fait peu de cas des traducteurs et commentateurs latins qui l'ont précédé; s'il les a connus, il ne les a guère utilisés […] en ce sens, Boèce a le droit de dire qu'il apporte quelque chose de neuf au monde latin."[76] This assertion deserves to be re-examined. Once the possibility of finding new 'sources' for the philosophy of the *Consolatio* is denied, it is useful, in our opinion, to situate it within the history of Latin Platonism. It answers, in fact, a number of issues that have long been discussed. Should Boethius' interest in Greek philosophy, for Aristotle and Plato, whom he wanted to translate and comment, be regarded completely isolated from all historical consideration? Did it arise entirely without previous preparation by a Latin tradition? The necessary adjustment in perspective, in our opinion, is to regard the contemporary Greek Neo-Platonism as not being Boethius' only source.

Research in the Latin Neo-Platonic tradition predating Boethius is particularly uncertain, though necessary, in order to shed as much light as possible on Boethius' personality. With regard to logic, it is known that in his translation of Porphyry's *Isagoge* he first followed Marius Victorinus, but then abandoned him to proceed independently. Apparently, Boethius does not make use of Latin sources; it is therefore necessary to determine which of the problems he treated were traditional and which altogether new.[77] Do the solutions he provides to those problems derive from Latin Neo-Platonism (Apuleius, Calcidius, Macrobius, and Martianus Capella)? In short, we will attempt to determine Boethius' position within Latin Neo-Platonism, as the last link of this tradition, however independent he may have been. We shall proceed to consider some of Boethius' doctrines that have a precedence in Latin Middle and Neo-Platonism.

Philosophy in a Roman environment is characterized by a peculiarity. Latin

75 Yet this does not mean that Boethius depends on his sources uncritically. As it has been stated by Micaelli (1995, 73), "his wide and meditated readings can sometimes give rise to the opinion that he depends on a particular source, but the frequency and the variety of his intertextual references are proof of a complex and personal elaboration."

76 Courcelle (1967), 229.

77 With regard to the Roman tradition, cf. Maurach (1968), 126 – 41. Courcelle's observations on the 'sources' of Boethius are convincing (cf. (1967), 334); I do not agree, however, that Boethius had not read Plato to the point of knowing the *Gorgias* only through the commentary of Olympiodorus, which is central to the course of the discussion in the fourth book of the *De consolatione*; on this point I entirely welcome the objections of Dronke in his review of Courcelle's work (cf. (1969), 123 – 8, in particular at 125 – 6).

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philosophers, perhaps because they were well aware of the substantial weakness of their speculations and of the lack of a real philosophical tradition in Rome, always preferred to turn to Greece, even when faced with fresh considerations of problems to which their predecessors had already dedicated themselves. Therefore (apart from the diversity of opinions) Cicero does not turn to Lucretius to learn the Epicurean doctrine, Seneca takes very little account of Cicero; neither Apuleius, when commenting on the *Timaeus* in *De Platone et eius dogmate*, nor Calcidius in his translation and commentary on the *Timaeus* used Cicero's translation and Platonism, but composed their commentaries from the Greek tradition. It can therefore be said that an awareness of a school and of belonging to a local tradition never formed among Latin philosophers. The philosophy of Rome is thus represented by isolated figures, and not by specific currents of thought. This is true even for the Latin Neo-Platonists: although they were all formed in Platonism, Apuleius, Calcidius, Macrobius, and Martianus Capella do not exhibit any common point of contact: all have turned, with different results, to Greek Platonism, and never constituted a Latin 'Neo-Platonic school.' All this is demonstrated in the definitive work by Stephen Gersh that examines the individual Latin philosopher more than the Platonic tradition – which perhaps did not really exist as a true 'tradition'.[78]

3.9.3 The doctrine of the *summum bonum*

One fundamental aspect of Boethian theology is the definition of God as the '*summum bonum*' and the '*beatitudo*'. It is reached through a discussion in the third book of the *Consolatio*, which we summarized above in this way: the '*bonum*' is equivalent to the '*beatitudo*', but God is '*beatitudo*', therefore God is '*bonum*';[79] and again: the '*bonum*' is '*unum*', but God is '*summum bonum*', therefore God is '*unum*'. The Neo-Platonic triad, according to the teachings of Plotinus and prior to the complex gradations of the later Neo-Platonists, culminates in the One. Based on a long tradition, reaching back to Plato's *Republic* and Neo-Pythagoreanism, Plotinus identifies in one of his most famous treatises the One with the Good (cf. VI 9,46; 62 – 63), leading scholars to note that Boethius moves within the Neo-Platonic tradition.[80] Even more than Plotinus, Porphyry developed the identification between God and the supreme good (τἀγαθόν), which also reappears in Boethius' *Opuscula*

78 Gersh (1986).

79 Cf. *Consolatio* III 10,17: "*sed summum bonum beatitudinem esse concessum est* […] *igitur* […] *deum esse ipsam beatitudinem necesse est confiteri*" ("But we have granted that the highest good is happiness […] therefore it must be confessed that happiness is itself God"); 10,42: "*ex quo liquido apparet ipsius boni et beatitudinis unam atque eandem esse substantiam.*" ("From this it clearly appears that the substance of goodness and of happiness is one and the same").

80 Cf. Scheible (1972), 179.

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Theologica, as pointed out above. A passage of Porphyry's *Historia Philosopha* (or *History of Philosophy)*, quoted by Cyril of Alexandria (*Contra Iulianum* VIII, PG 76,916B), states that

ἄχρι γὰρ τριῶν ὑποστάσεων ἔφη Πλατων τὴν του θεοῦ προελθεῖν οὐσίαν· εἶναι δὲ τὸν μὲν ἀνώτατον θεὸν τἀγαθόν, μετ᾽ αὐτὸν δὲ καὶ δεύτερον τὸν δημιουργόν, τρίτην δὲ τὴν τοῦ κόσμου ψυχήν.[81]

But already in the fourth and fifth centuries, the Latin Neo-Platonic tradition had reached this identification, which, after all, must have appeared obvious, especially in a milieu like the Latin world, not known to be particularly sensitive to the abstract speculations of the Greek Neo-Platonists. The identification of the One with the supreme God was not a difficult step for pagans to take in an era of widespread theism, as the Imperial age had been from the second century onwards; thus the identification of God with the highest good was quite a natural conclusion.

The very proof that Boethius presents to identify the highest good with God is Platonic in nature: particular goods are such because they possess unity or because they participate (the term is significantly Platonic) in the good:

Quae igitur, cum discrepant, minime bona sunt, cum vero unum esse coeperint bona fiunt, nonne, haec ut bona sint, unitatis fieri adeptione contingit? […] *Sed omne quod bonum est, boni participatione bonum esse concedis an minime? Ita est. Oportet igitur idem esse unum atque bonum simil ratione concedas* (III 11,7 – 9).[82]

But already this relationship of participation in the first good, and the parallelism between the '*summum bonum*' and the '*secunda bona*' were doctrines proper to Middle-Platonism and already appear in Apuleius:

prima bona esse deum summum mentemque illam, quam voûv idem (scl. *Plato*) *vocat; secundum ea quae ex priorum fonte profluerent esse animi virtutes* […] *bonum primum est verum et divinum illud, optimum et amabile et concupiscendum, cuius pulchritudinem rationabiles adpetunt mentes* […] *Et quod non omnes id adipisci queunt neque primi boni adipiscendi facultatem possunt habere, ad id feruntur quod hominum est, quod secundum nec commune multis est nec omnibus similiter bonum* (*Plat.* II 1,220 – 1).[83]

81 "Plato asserted that the divine substance proceeds to three hypostases, and that the first is the supreme god, i. e. the good; after him, the second, the demiurge, and third the cosmic soul." (See fr. 16 Segonds (in des Places (1982), pp. 190 – 191) = 221F Smith).

82 "Now those things which are not good, since they differ, but become good when they begin to be one, does it not happen that they become good by the acquisition of unity? […] But do you agree or not, that everything which is good is good by participation in the good? – That is so – Then by the same argument you must agree that the one and the good are the same." This is the fundamental principle of Boethius' Christian Platonism: the identity of the One with the good (cf. Gruber (^{2}2006), 299.

83 "The first goods are God and the supreme Intellect, which Plato calls *nous*; then are those goods which derive from that source, I mean the virtues of the soul […] the first good possesses true

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The distinction between ἀγαθός and τἀγαθόν is found in Apuleius as well, because when Apuleius calls god *optimus* in a passage of *De Platone* (I 6,194), in the *De magia* (c. 27) he recognized that Plato's supreme god is τἀγαθόν.

Of course, Apuleius does not rationally explain the difference between the highest good and partial goods, insofar as these are good due to a greater or lesser participation in the first good; neither does he interpret – as Boethius does – the desire of men to attain what they consider good as the same instinct of returning back to the One, which is the principle of life not only for men, but for all existent beings.[84]

This view, united with the assertion of the supreme transcendence of God, is also found in another Latin Middle-Platonist, Calcidius:

principio cuncta quae sunt et ipsum mundum contineri regique principaliter quidem a summo deo, qui est summum bonum ultra omnem substantiam omnemque naturam, aestimatione intellectuque melior, quem cuncta expetunt, cum ipse sit plenae perfectionis et nullius societatis indiguus (c. 176).[85]

Finally we come to Macrobius. Boethius rarely quotes Macrobius (or other Latin philosophers), but most likely he knew him, since he is familiar with details of his geography, as Courcelle has shown.[86] Macrobius thinks (*Comm.* I 2,14–16) that 'the Good' (τἀγαθόν) and First Cause (πρῶτον αἴτιον) should be rendered in Latin with the words '*summus et princeps omnium deus:*'

ceterum cum ad summum et principem omnium deum, qui apud Graecos τἀγαθόν, *qui* πρῶτον αἴτιον *nuncupatur, tractatus se audet attollere, vel ad mentem, quam Graeci* νοῦν *appellant, originales rerum species, quae dictae sunt, continentem, ex summo natam et profectam deo: cum de his inquam, loquuntur summo deo et mente, nihil fabulosum penitus attingunt, sed si quis de his adsignare conantur quae non sermonem tantum modo, sed cogitationem quoque humanam superant, ad simili-*

reality and is divine, excellent and lovable and desirable; his beauty rational intelligences want to reach […] Since neither can everybody obtain that good nor does everybody have the possibility of obtaining it, they move towards a human good: this comes after the first and is not common to many nor is it good for all in the same way."

84 Cf. Schmidt-Kohl (1965), 11. Schmidt-Kohl understands in this sense the passages in the *Cons.* III, 2,2 ("*Omnis mortalium cura* […] *ad unum tamen beatitudinis finem nititur pervenire. Id autem est bonum, quo quis adepto nihil ulterius desiderare queat*;" "The whole concern of men […] strives to arrive at one and the same end, that of happiness. Now that is the good which, once a man attains it, leaves no room for further desires") and IV 2,10. Cf. his observations with respect to the desire of returning to unity (12–13).

85 "In the first place, all things and the world itself are sustained and governed principally by the highest God, who is the supreme Good, beyond all substance and all nature, above all appraisal and intellect, towards whom all things strive, while he himself possess total perfection, not needing the association of another." – trans. Gersh (1986), 439. An interpretation of Calcidius' doctrine is also given by Gersh (1986), 439–41.

86 Cf. Courcelle (1967) 116–24.

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tudines et exemplа confugiunt […] *Sic Plato, cum de* τἀγαθῷ *loqui esset animatus, dicere quid sit non ausus est.*[87]

Quod autem hunc istum extimum globum, qui ita volvitur, summum deum vocavit (scil. *Cicero*), *non ita accipiendum est, ut ipse prima causa et deus ille omnipotentissimus aestimetur* […] (I 17,12).[88]

Macrobius introduces the theology of the three hypostases, which somehow must have appeared antiquated and uninteresting to the Christian Boethius. However, Plotinus usually referred to 'God' as the 'first principle,' more often than 'One,' and this is apparently repeated by Macrobius.[89] Both Calcidius and Macrobius insist on the apophatic character of God, which remains largely undeveloped in Boethius.

Among the Christians, the identification of God with the '*aeterna pulchritudo*' is found in Ambrose (*De excessu Satyri* I 42,1):

bonorum primum esse Deum scire et verum illud atque divinum pia mente venerari, illam amabilem et concupiscendam aeternae pulchritudinis veritatem.[90]

The statement is certainly Middle Platonic and has been identified by Courcelle as deriving from Apuleius (*De Platone et eius dogmate* II 2,219).[91]

Ambrose came in contact with the '*Platonicorum libri*' (if we may apply the Augustinian designation to him). In the *De Isaac vel anima* he asserts that God is the *summum bonum* (8,78 – 79):

pulchritudo autem animae sincera virtus et decus verior cognitio superiorum, ut videat illud bonum ex quo pendent omnia, ipsum autem ex nullo […] *vitae enim fons est summum illud bonum, cuius nobis accenditur caritas et desiderium, cui adpropinquare et misceri voluptas est* […] *hoc est quod subministrat universis substantiam, ipsum autem manens in semel ipso dat aliis, nihil autem in se ex aliis suscipit* […] *fiat ergo bonus qui vult videre dominum et quod est bonum* […] *hoc est*

87 "But when the investigation aspires to elevate itself to the highest and supreme of all the gods, called τἀγαθόν and πρῶτον αἴτιον by the Greeks, or to Intellect, which the Greeks call νοῦς, generated and proceeding from the highest God, and containing the originative Forms of things known as ἰδέαι; when indeed philosophers discuss these, the highest God and the Intellect, they totally avoid mythical narrative. If they wish to attribute something to these principles which transcend not only human expression but human thought, they resort to analogies and similes. Thus when Plato was moved to speak about τἀγαθόν but did not venture to say what it was […]" – trans. Gersh (1986). An interpretation of this assertion in Gersh (1986), 524, n.1, 530 – 8.

88 "When Cicero called the outmost sphere which revolves in the way the 'highest god,' the latter is not to be understood as though it were equivalent to the first cause and that God who is omnipotent […]" – trans. Gersh (1986), 528 – 9.

89 See Gersh (1986), 532; Armisen Marchetti (2001), 8.

90 "The first good is to know God and to worship that true divine good, that truly lovable and desirable substance of an eternal beauty."

91 Courcelle (^{2}1968), 319 – 46, at 321.

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bonum, quod supra omnem operationem est, supra omnem mentem atque intellectum. Ipsum est quod semper manet et ad ipsum convertuntur omnia.[92]

Here the Neo-Platonic doctrine of the return (ἐπιστροφή) of all things to their origin is introduced, interpreted by Ambrose as the return of the soul to God from whom it had been separated. In another sermon with Neo-Platonic overtones (*De Iacob* I 8,35) Ambrose underlines the happiness of being in touch with the '*summum bonum:*'

virum iustum nihil velle nisi illud solum et praeclarum bonum, huic soli intendere, hoc unum in bonis ducere, non aliud cum illo, sed solum ipsum semper desiderare, hoc delectari.[93]

This doctrine of the '*summum bonum*' is considered again in Epistle 11, in which Ambrose exhibits frequent parallels with Plotinus I 6,7 – 8, as Faller has shown in his critical apparatus. When "the eye of our mind" gazes at the '*summum bonum*' and remains with it and never abandons it, it becomes brilliant and shines. This highest good is in God's house, in His secret (11,5), as Plotinus stated that the highest good "is inside, in the sacred temples, and does not come out" (I 6,8,1 – 3). It does not need anything and is abundant in all good things (11,9, cf. *Isaac* 8,78: "*ex quo pendent omnia, ipsum autem ex nullo*"). And when the soul has tasted the highest good by its faculty that desires and enjoys pleasure and will have reached it thanks to it, it no longer feels pain, but rejoices in an incredible way (Plotinus in VI 7,12 – 4 refers to incredible love and desire, which the intellect experiences because it wants to be united with the highest good, and so feels intense pleasure).

It must be kept in mind that for most Christian writers, the transcendence of God is not of a Neo-Platonic type, going beyond being, but is based on the equivalence between God and the fullness of being.[94] In another passage, Ambrose (*Epist.* 55,8 = 8, Migne), explaining Ex. 3:14 states: "*Hoc est verum nomen Dei, esse semper.*" Étienne Gilson observed,[95] with regard to this biblical passage, that Ambrose always underlined the full ontological meaning of the sentence "*ego sum qui sum*" of Ex. 3:14:

92 "The beauty of the soul is the true virtue and its still nobler honour is the knowledge of supreme substances, so that soul can see that Good on which all [goods] depend – but that Good depends on nothing. […] For the source of life is that supreme Good, to which our love and our desire are excited, to which having access and with which having union is pleasure. […] This Good is the Power which gives everything its being; remaining in itself, it gives to others and it receives nothing for itself from others […] So let he who wants to see God and the Good be good […] This is the Good which is above every energy, above every mind and every intellect. It is that which remains for eternity and to which all want to return."

93 "The right man does not desire but that only and splendid Good, he is turned only toward it; he considers only this among goods, not another good together with it, but he always desires only it and only in it he feels pleasure."

94 Cf. Moreschini (2008), 3 – 19, at 5 – 11.

95 Gilson (^{2}1944), 112, Madec (1974), 64, Moreschini (2012), 193.

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nomen ergo proprietas uniuscuiusque est, quo possit intellegi. Unde arbitror quod et Moyses, volens propria Dei et aliquid de eo speciale cognoscere quod non esset commune cum caelestibus potestatibus, interrogavit: quod est nomen tuum? Denique cognoscens mentem eius Deus non respondit nomen, sed negotium, hoc est rem expressit, non appellationem, dicens: ego sum qui sum, quia nihil tam proprium Dei quam semper esse (*In Psalm*. 43:19 — actually, 43:20,1 – 2).[96]

The statement that being is always proper to God is directed against the Arians (*Fid.* III 15,127; *Incarn.* 9,100), as Madec observed.[97]

For Christian Platonism, the identification of God with being while underlining the transcendence of the One over being is current at least up until Dionysius the Areopagite. Drecoll[98] examines six passages of *Isaac* (8,78 – 9) in which the use of certain biblical texts influence the echoes of Plotinus. The '*summum bonum*,' which is discussed there, bestows being upon all things, a statement confirmed by Psalm 15:2.[99]

It is not likely that Boethius read Ambrose, but it is certain that he read Augustine. What Augustine says in *De doctrina Christiana* (I 3,3 – 7,7) appears very similar to the discussion concerning the definition of the '*summum bonum*' developed in the *Consolatio:* all men tend towards the good, but go astray because of false appearances and, believing that many things are good that are not, or constitute only a limited and partial good, divide the '*summum bonum*,' upon which everything depends, into many alleged goods, which are not actually such but are in fact illusory: God is the only '*summum bonum*' (I 7,7). For Augustine, God is goodness and being, and is not beyond actual existence. God is the "*ipsum esse*", the Good, whereas for everything else in the universe, which is good, good is only an adjective (*Enarr. Psalm*. 134,4). In God, being and existence are one and the same thing.[100]

Also, the very identification of God as the '*summum bonum*' predominates in Boethius, compared to the identification of God as the '*unum*.' Whereas in Plotinus and the Greek Neo-Platonists this identification, which defines (and therefore limits and circumscribes) the One, is accompanied by the concomitant tendency to deny in an apophatic way every attribute of the

96 "Therefore the name is the characteristic of each thing, and helps to understand it. I think that Moses too, when he wanted to know God's characteristics and something which is peculiar only to Him and not common to heaven's powers, asked Him: Which is your name? And God, knowing Moses' intention, did not answer uttering His name, but manifested His activity, that is, a real thing, not a name, asserting: 'I am who I am', because nothing is more peculiar of God than to be eternally."

97 Madec (1974), 64 – 65.

98 Drecoll (2001), 104—30, at 126 – 8.

99 Drecoll (2001), 128) refers to the well-known position of H. Dörrie that Christians could never have truly been Platonic. This case constitutes one example. The differences between Plotinus and Ambrose, therefore, must be understood on the basis of the premises of the same thought in Ambrose. Also Dassmann (1978, 362 – 386, at 374) speaks of a "Neo-Platonic coloring of certain theological concepts" in Ambrose.

100 Cf. Chadwick (1981), 207.

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One, exactly the opposite is true of Boethius: the God of the *Consolatio* is the personal God of the Christian tradition and the supremely good God.[101]

3.9.4 God is a monad

In *Epist.* 1 (= 7, Migne), par. 21, Ambrose shows himself informed of the definition of the monad,[102] on which the Neo-Platonists insisted. He notes that the monad belongs to God, who is the One: therefore the monad is not a number, but the principle ('*elementum*') of numbers:

[…] <*monas*> *unius est Dei ad imitationem ipsius; ab uno incipit et in infinitum diffunditur, et iterum de infinito in unum, quasi in finem, omnia revertuntur, quia Deus et principium et finis omnium est. Unde nec numerum monada, sed elementum numeri, quibus ea cura est, appellaverunt.*[103]

On this subject Macrobius writes (*Comm.* I 6,8):

haec monas initium finisque omnium, neque ipsa principii aut finis sciens, ad summum refertur deum eiusque intellectum a sequentium numero rerum et potestatum sequestrat nec in inferiore post deum gradu frustra eam desideraveris. Haec illa est mens ex summo enata deo, quae, vices temporum nesciens, in uno semper quod adest consistit aevo, cumque utpote una, non sit ipsa numerabilis, innumeras tamen generum species et de se creat et intra se continet […].[104]

101 I. Hadot has raised objections to my reconstruction of the tradition of Latin Neo-Platonism, noting that there is no reason to think that Boethius has reused formulas taken from Latin writers, since Simplicius, in his *Commentary on the Manual of Epictetus* (6,52 – 7,4; 5,4; 5,12, Dübner), often uses analogous formulas, such as: ταὐτὸν γάρ ἐστιν ἓν καὶ ἀρχὴ καὶ ἀγαθὸν καὶ θεόν (cf. I. Hadot (1984), 206, repeated in ^{2}2005). But Hadot's citation only means that the same tendency of identification between God, the One, and the good, is also proper to Greek Neo-Platonism, not that Boethius could not have considered Latin formulas (especially since Simplicius wrote his *Commentary* after Boethius' death). With respect to this problem, Micaelli adds that it is not the same thing to identify the highest good with the supreme God, as Boethius does, and identifying the highest good with God in a generic sense, as Simplicius does (see Micaelli (1995), 66).

102 Cf. Courcelle (1973), 25 – 33, at 30 – 31, Moreschini (2012), 192 – 3.

103 "[…] for <the monad> is [the image] of the one and only God and modelled after God Himself. Beginning from One it is infinitely diffused, and again, from the Infinite all things go back to one, as their end, for God is both the beginning and the end of all things. Wherefore arithmeticians who attended to this topic, did not call the monad a number, but the origin of number."

104 "This monad, which is the beginning and end of all things but itself knows neither beginning nor end, is applied to the highest God and distinguishes our understanding of him from the plurality of things and powers subsequent to him. Nor would you seek this monad in vain among the ranks below God, for it also corresponds to Intellect generated from the highest God which, unaware of temporal changes, exists always in that single eternity co-extensive with it. Although the monad is itself not numbered, since it is unity, it nevertheless generates from itself and contains within itself innumerable forms of things" – trans. Gersh (1986), 525. The

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But Ambrose points out that this claim is based on what is written in Apocalypse 1:8: "I am Alpha and Omega, the beginning and the end" and in Deut. 6:4: "Hear, O Israel: the Lord our God is one Lord" and in this passage '*unus*' is not 'one god,' but 'the unique God.' Thus the monad means God, as the beginning and end of all things: Ambrose transforms the "*summum bonum*" and the uniqueness of the divine monad into Christian concepts.

3.9.5 The cosmic soul

It is by no means irrelevant that Boethius does account within the Neo-Platonic triad for the cosmic soul, which was entirely incompatible with Christian theology, causing some medieval writers, as we shall see, to be 'scandalized' by the reference to the cosmic soul in III metrum IX, 13 – 17:

tu triplicis mediam naturae cuncta moventem / connectens animam per consona membra resolvis; / quae cum secta duos motum glomeravit in orbes, / in semet reditura meat mentemque profundam / circuit et simili convertit imagine caelum.

The doctrine of the cosmic soul is found not only in the pagan Macrobius, but also in Christian writers like Calcidius: he refers to it more than once,[105] because it was contained in his Neo-Platonic sources, without giving any thought to framing it in a Christian interpretation of Neo-Platonism.

3.9.6 The simplicity of God

Another aspect of the highest good according to Boethius is to be '*simplex*,' namely, in everything identical to itself: in it there is no foreign element, which would be by necessity inferior to it, being the good, by definition, '*summum*.'[106] On this topic we wish to add a few considerations to previous observations made above.

The simplicity of God is asserted in several passages of the *Consolatio:* when Boethius says that God is one, he complains that the First Principle, which is "*simplex indivisumque natura*," has been falsely divided by humans (III 9,4).[107] The divine Mind resides in the fortress of its simplicity ("*in suae simplicitatis arce*," IV 6,8; also 6,20).

The doctrine of the *simplicitas* of God, that is of the one and only being by

monad is, in Macrobius' description, identical with the *nous*, as it assembles into unity all ideas. This is an ancient tenet of Platonism, asserted also by Clement of Alexandria, *Strom.* V 93,4 – 95,1 (cf. Lilla (1971), 191).

105 Cf., for example, c. 40 – 41, 119 – 20, etc.

106 It is accurate perhaps to say here, along with Schmidt-Kohl (1965, 12), that the term *simplex* is a designation of *unus.*

107 Again: "*unum simplexque natura*" (III 9,16)

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nature, can indisputably be traced to Plotinus (cf. *Enn.* II, 9,1: V 5,6; V 5,10 etc.). But it is encountered very frequently in Marius Victorinus, who asserts (*Candidi epist*. 2, p. 3,1): "*simplex enim quiddam deus*" and states that God, since he is '*simplex*' has no substance (8, p. 10,26 – 7). "*Simplex enim omne ibi*" (*Ad Cand*. 22, p. 39,9), and analogous expressions are found in *Adv. Arium* I 4, p. 59,13; 19, p. 85,49; 20, p. 86,10; 87,41. *Simplicitas* is mentioned in *Ad Cand*. 20, p. 37,15, and "*prima simplicitas*" in *Adv. Arium* IV 13, p. 244,20 (cf. IV 16, p. 248,10 – 11).

This doctrine is found, moroever, in Ambrose, who notes that God is the "*substantia simplex*" (cf. *De Fide* I 16,106; *De Spiritu Sancto* I 5,72), and, in all likelihood imitating Ambrose also a poet, Prudentius (*Symm.* II 239).

3.9.7 On 'becoming God'

In the same way, the concept of "*deus fieri*" is not necessarily derived from Proclus or Ammonius, the acknowledged teachers of Boethius. The doctrine of the ὁμοίωσις θεῷ ('assimilation [of the philosopher] to God', according to the assertion of Plat., *Theaet.* 176b) was common in both Greek and Latin Platonic tradition; we shall refrain from going into a detailed investigation of the Greek Platonic tradition on this occasion, but do wish to recall that it had already been professed by Apuleius (*De Platone* II 23,253):[108]

Sapientiae finis est, ut ad dei meritum sapiens provehatur, hancque futuram eius operam, ut aemulatione vitae ad deorum actus accedat […] *sapientem quippe pedisequum et imitatorem dei dicimus et sequi arbitramur deum: id est enim* ἕπου θεῷ.[109]

It is found in *Cons.* I 4,39:[110]

nec conveniebat vilissimorum me spirituum praesidia captare, quem tu in hanc excellentiam componebas, ut consimilem deo faceres […] *instillabas enim auribus cogitationibusque cotidie meis Pythagoricum illud* ἕπου θεῷ.[111]

Boethius did nothing else than simply transfer what was a Platonic doctrine to a different context, integrating it into his Christian faith. It is another example of Christian Neo-Platonism. Consequently, other statements as well can be referred to this teaching, like *Consolatio* III 10,23 and IV 3,10. The very same

108 Cf. Moreschini, Apuleius and the 'Metamorphoses' of Platonism, forthcoming.

109 "The goal of the wisdom of the sage is to reach God's loftiness, and his activity will be that of reaching the operations of gods thanks to the imitation of God he displays in his life […] we assert that the sage is a disciple and an imitator of God and we think that he follows him: this is the meaning of the Greek sentence: ἕπου θεῷ."

110 Cf. Schmidt-Kohl (1965), 41, 51 – 52, Boethius, Gruber (^{2}2006) 135.

111 "For daily you instilled into my ears and my mind the Pythagorean saying, 'Follow God'." I inverted the quotation to obtain clearer evidence.

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synthesis of the doctrine of the 'assimilation to God' with that of 'following God' (attributed to Pythagoras[112]) is present, as we can see, in both Boethius and Apuleius.

3.9.8 God, the supreme intellect

Boethius' vocabulary reserves for God the very common definition of *mens: Consolatio* IV 6,7; 6,16; 6,20; "*vos deo mente consimiles*" (II 5,26). This definition of God as 'supreme intellect' may derive from Middle Platonism, which customarily attributed to God not only the concept of One, but also that of Intellect. It is possible, then, that Boethius is Platonic in considering God the supreme mind; there are, on the other hand, examples of Christian writers who were inspired by Platonism.[113] But the cultural background in which Boethius was formed was broader than that represented by the Platonic schools of his time. To our mind, it was not necessary for Boethius to learn the identification between God and *mens* from contemporary Greek Neo-Platonic sources, because it had already been well established for some centuries in Western culture.

We cannot claim for certain that Boethius drew this theological concept from a Latin Neo-Platonist. Nevertheless, certain theological problems (specifically identifying and qualifying the deity as a rational substance, whether Christian or pagan) are discussed in the fourth to sixth centuries, employing terminology common to both Christian and pagan, corresponding to a widespread trend. The word *mens*, which corresponded to the Greek *nous*, was also appropriate for Christian theology, because it summed up the supreme rationality in the Son. Besides, in Trinitarian theology, the Father could never have been without the Son and without his Logos:[114] therefore *mens* properly expresses an essential quality of God.

The identification between God and *mens* had become common for some centuries in Western culture, after the polytheism of traditional religion was abandoned. This itself had tended, also under the influence of Neo-Stoicism and Cicero, towards a generic theism, which conceived of an impersonal deity furnished with supreme reason. This is the god spoken of by Latin panegyrists, who often conformed their political doctrine of the divinity of the emperor to

112 Cf. Stob. II 49,16 (doctrine of Arius Didymus?); Iambl., *vit. Pythag.* 18,86; Moreschini (2014), forthcoming.

113 Cf. Clem. Alex., *Strom.* II 131,5 (Lilla (1971) 106–8); Orig., *princ.* III 6,1; Greg. Naz., *orat.* 6,14; Greg. Nyss., *vit. Moys.* II 251–252; 318 etc. For Christian writers the *imitatio Dei* is a development of Gen 1:26 (God created man as His image and resemblance).

114 It was during those centuries that the anti-Arian polemic insisted, in fact, on this postulate, in order to demonstrate the existence of the Son *ab aeterno*, contemporary to the Father. This concept is expressed very frequently in the Nicene writers such as Athanasius (cf. *Contra Ar.* I 19,52D; 24,61B etc.), Gregory of Nyssa (*orat. catech.* 1,2–3 etc.); Gregory of Nazianzus (*orat.* 12,1 and 30,20 etc.); Marius Victorinus (*Contra Ar.* I 19; I 52 etc.).

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the philosophical and religious doctrine of the "*summum numen*," and the "*mens divina*." In their praise of the emperors, the panegyrists express themselves in terms similar to those employed for the supreme deity; the *summum numen* and the *mens* of Maximianus Herculius are no different from the deity who rules the universe and administers it rationally and providently.[115] The same concept can also be found in Ammianus Marcellinus: his vague religious ideas, inspired by a henotheism, frequently mentions the *divina mens* and the *superna mens*.[116]

3.9.9 Providence and Fate

The bond linking Boethius to the Latin Platonic tradition preceding him is also undeniable regarding the doctrine on providence and fate. Boethius' reflection, contained in the fifth book of the *Consolatio*, is the most thoughtful and coherent treatment of an issue that in the Latin Platonic environment had been debated for at least three centuries.

Displaying greater speculative faculties than his Latin forerunners, Boethius subjects providence to the eternal vision of God over human affairs, and sees fate in the unfolding of the events of this world. This subordination, unknown to the Stoics, only makes sense, as Courcelle noted,[117] in a philosophy that establishes a clear hierarchy between beings, and only among the Neo-Platonists is this done. It is also found, as I. Hadot likewise observes,[118] in Hierocles of Alexandria (*Apud Phot.*, *Biblioth.*, cod. 251, p. 462, 630 – 5, Bekker).

This issue had been a matter of debate for at least three centuries. The fundamental difficulty was to resolve the contradiction between free will and fate, while preserving at the same time the function of divine providence. The defence of Platonism had to be accompanied, therefore, by a rejection of Stoic determinism: Apuleius, the first of the Latin Platonists to address the problem, who lived in an era when the cultural domination of Stoicism was still of the utmost significance, was unable to arrive at a solution between determinism,

115 The language of the *Panegyrici Latini* is very indicative in this respect: it is enough to cite, for the concept of the *divina mens*, *Paneg.* VIII 10,2; IX 2,5; IX 16,2; for the concept of the *summum numen, Paneg.* XII 21,1. See also Moreschini (1983), 135 – 61, at 138 – 9, (1989), 89 – 120, at 111 – 2, and Apuleius and the 'Metamorphoses' of Platonism, forthcoming. On Late Antique pagan 'monotheism' see also Tommasi (2012), 192 – 210.

116 The religious-philosophical attitude of Ammianus Marcellinus is evident from these expressions, which are common to those of the panegyrists, and one could say, to all the writers of the time: "*numen caeleste*" ("*deus caelestis*") in XXVII 6,8; XXVI 1,5, etc.; "*summum numen*" in XXVI 6,9; XXI 13,14; XXV 8,3, etc.

117 Courcelle (1947), 287. Courcelle observes, Boethius derives this problem from Proclus (he writes of it at length, in (1948) and in (1967), 203 – 31).

118 I. Hadot (1978), 129 – 30.

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providence, and free will, and limited himself to merely juxtaposing the Platonic and Stoic definitions (cf. *De Platone et eius dogmate* I 12).

Also Calcidius, in a long and well-articulated section of his commentary on the *Timaeus* (c. 142 – 90), devotes himself to a discussion on fate.[119] It may be noted that both Calcidius and Boethius, following Platonism, reject the Stoic arguments, which deny free will in the context of a universal determinism (Calcidius, c. 160; Boethius, *Consol.* V 3), and assert that fate depends on providence. This is the act whereby God embraces in a single instant the infinity of beings outside of space and time and regulates in detail everything that moves through space and time. Calcidius defines fate as follows:

initium divinae legis, id est fati, providentia, fatum vero, quod et parendi sibi obsequium et non parendi contumaciam velut edicto complectitur (c. 151);[120]

sequitur hanc providentiam fatum, lex divina promulgata intellegentiae sapienti modulamine ad rerum omnium gubernationem […] *iuxta hanc legem, id est fatum, omnia reguntur, secundum propriam quaeque naturam, beata quidem necessitate incommutabilique constantia cuncta caelestia* […] *quae vero reguntur hac lege, ratione, ordine ac sine vi reguntur.* (c. 177).[121]

Calcidius attributes the distinction between providence and fate to Plato (c. 145), but the discussion unfolds in the manner of the juxtapositions of thought found in the doxography of Apuleius, and not according to clear and dense reasoning.

Another interesting issue is that of God's *praescientia*, which takes place, according to Calcidius, in relation to the nature of known things. Calcidius explains it as follows:

quod deus sciat quidem omnia, sed unumquidque pro natura sua ipsorum sciat: necessitati quidem subiugatum, ut necessitati obnoxium: anceps vero, ut quod ea sit natura praeditum, cui consilium viam pandat; neque enim ita scit ambigui naturam deus, ut quod certum et necessitate constrictum (sic enim falletur et nesciet), sed ita ut pro natura sua vere dubium sciat (c. 162).[122]

119 On this section of the commentary of Calcidius, see den Boeft (1970).

120 "So, the origin of divine law, which is fate, is providence; fate, on the other hand, is that which contains both the obedient yielding and the disobedient arrogance as by an ordinance" (trans. den Boeft (1970), also for the following quotations).

121 "This providence is followed by fate, which is divine law published by the wise harmony of intelligence for the government of all things. […] According to this law, i. e. fate, all things are ruled, each according to its own nature: all heavenly phenomena, by a blessed necessity and an unchangeable perseverence. […] What is ruled by this law, is ruled by reason and order, without violence."

122 "It is true that God knows all things, but that He knows everything according to its own nature: that which is subject to necessity as submissive to necessity, the contingent, however, as provided with such a nature that deliberation opens way for it. For God does not know the nature of what is contingent in such a way as that which is certain and bound by necessity (for

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Such an important issue in Neo-Platonic philosophy as that of providence and fate is present, albeit at different scientific levels, in Macrobius and Martianus Capella. Macrobius (*Comm.* I 21,27) hints at the possibility that providence assigned to the planets their order at the creation of the world. More interesting is a passage from *Saturn.* V 16,8: "*philosophi, qui eam* (scl. *fortunam*) *nominant, nihil sua vi posse, sed decreti sive providentiae ministram esse voluerunt.*"[123]

Even here, however, it does not appear to me that the distinction between providence and fate (indicated by the term *decretum* in Macrobius) was as clear for Macrobius as it was for Boethius. For the concept of fate in Macrobius one must consult *Comm.* I 13, in which he examines the problem of suicide. In this passage, after speaking of a fixed and determined numerical calculation that unites souls to their bodies, Macrobius says that fate, or rather, "the time allotted by fate to life", is what determines the dissolution of this union based on a numerical calculation.

Not even Martianus Capella studied thoroughly the concept of fate: in *De nuptiis* V 494, fate is primarily understood as a dispenser of life and death, starting from a commentary on a verse by Virgil (*Aen.* IV 314). Elsewhere (*De nuptiis* VI 567) Martianus calls Pallas "*mens et sollertia fati*": with this attribution of fate to Pallas, who Platonists identified with the mind of God, Martianus Capella probably intended to trace fate to the rationality of God, but he does not elaborate on the problem.

3.9.10 The astral body

Another possible point of contact between Macrobius and Boethius could be the concept of the ὄχημα or 'astral body' of the soul. Boethius refers to it in *Consol.* III, metrum IX 18 – 20:

Tu causis animam paribus vitasque minores / provehis et levibus sublimes curribus aptans / in caelum terramque seris […].[124]

These verses exhibit a certain analogy with the doctrine set forth by Macrobius (*Comm.* I 12,13):

Hoc ergo primo pondere de zodiaco et lacteo ad subiectas usque sphaeras anima delapsa dum et per illas labitur, in singulis non solum, ut iam diximus, luminosi

in that case He will be deceived and fail to know), but in such a way that he really knows the contingent according to its nature."

123 "The philosophers who discussed the problem of fortune asserted that fortune can do nothing by itself, but it is the servant of the divine law, that is, of providence."

124 "You then bring forth, with the same bases, lesser living souls, / and giving them light chariots fitting their heavenly nature, / broadcast them in the heavens and on earth […]."

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corporis amicitur accessu, sed et singulos motus, quos in exercitio est habitura, producit.[125]

Thus, we may conclude that some of the Platonic issues discussed by Boethius in the *Consolatio* were also known by other Latin Platonists, like Apuleius, Calcidius, and Macrobius, whose philosophical capabilities, however, were far inferior to those of Boethius.

125 "Therefore the soul, which is obliged by the burden it received in the beginning to descend from the Zodiac and the Milky Way to the inferior spheres, not only is covered, passing through the spheres, as we said, by a dress she takes in each one due to the addition of a bright body, but it develops the energies of the movements it will have later."

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4. Boethius' Christianity

After examining the matter and the philosophical doctrines of the *Consolatio philosophiae* it is necessary, in correspondence with the aim of our research, to remark on a problem that has been discussed since the Middle Ages: the Christianity of Boethius. We refer to the fact that the *consolatio* Boethius sought while imprisoned and almost certain of his approaching death, was provided to him not by Christian faith but by philosophy. This fact has induced some to doubt Boethius' true Christianity. In this regard, Courcelle advances a problem to which (in our opinion) he assigns excessive importance.[1] He thereby rehashes ideas already expressed in the past about the contrast between Boethius' Christianity and philosophy, which Alain Galonnier has recently adeptly reconsidered.[2]

Courcelle mentions a *Histoire de Boèce sénateur romain* (published in Paris in 1715), which interpreted Philosophy as Jesus Christ, author of the Christian revelation. Courcelle then adds: "le contraste entre les traités théologiques de Boèce et sa Consolation apparut bientôt." This *bientôt* does not reflect the real situation of Boethius' *Nachleben* in the Middle Ages, but rather exposes Courcelle's method, a scholar of great erudition who sometimes risks attributing disproportionate significance to a secondary detail. Then Courcelle cites the interpretation of Charles Jourdain (1890),[3] who denies the Boethian authenticity of the *Opuscula theologica*, acknowledging as genuine only the secular works, as well as that of Nitsch (1860),[4] who suggests that "Boethius might have been Christian in his heart," but also denies the authenticity of the theological tractates. This apparent contradiction between the *Consolatio* and the *Opuscula theologica* was refuted a few years later (in 1877) by the assertion of the *Anecdoton Holderi*, which we examined above, where the *Opuscula* are explicitly attributed to Boethius.

Then Courcelle considers medieval commentators of the *Consolatio* to defend his opinion that the contrast between Boethius' Christian faith and philosophy was a problem discussed since that age. In so doing, he reexamines his important study written almost thirty years previously on the medieval commentaries on Boethius' *Consolatio* (up to the fifteenth century).[5] In the meantime, R.B.C. Huygens had published critical editions of three commen-

1 Courcelle (1967), 7.
2 Galonnier (1997), 34 – 40 and, for the discussions caused by the discovering of the *Anecdoton*, 40 – 52.
3 Jourdain (1860), 336.
4 Nitsch (1860).
5 Cf. Courcelle (1939).

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taries in 1954, among them those produced by Courcelle himself, who had originally had to rely on the *Patrologia Latina*. The authors of these commentaries exhibited deep interest in *Consolatio* III metrum IX, a poem positively imbued with Neo-Platonism: they were Bovo of Corvey, an anonymous commentator of the *Consolatio,* whom Courcelle and Huygens labeled 'Anonymus Einsiedlensis,' and Adalboldus of Utrecht. We, too, shall briefly re-examine their considerations about the Christianity of Boethius' doctrines, according to the topic of our study.[6]

4.1 Bovo of Corvey

The comment by Bovo of Corvey is dedicated to Bovo, the bishop of Châlons-sur-Marne (916 – 947). Bovo asserts that he was worried by the argument of the *Consolatio*, because he found that it contained some tenets that appeared to be contrary to the Christian faith, but he was not afraid that such pagan doctrines could inflict any moral damage on the reader.

III. *In primis admonendum est non solum in his versibus, sed et in multis locis eiusdem operis, quod Consolationis Philosophiae titulo praenotatur, quaedam catholicae fidei contraria repperiri; quod ideo mirum est, quia libellum quendam eiusdem auctoris de sancta trinitate*[7] *valde praeclarum legi, et alium contra Euticen et Nestorium haereticos, quos ab eodem esse conscriptos quisquis aliis eius libris legendis operam impendit, ut ego ab adulescentia feci, ex ipso elegantis stili quodam proprio nitore indubitanter agnoscit. Quod tamen utcumque se habeat, certum est eum in his libris nihil de doctrina ecclesiastica disputasse, sed tantum philosophorum, et maxime platonicorum dogmata legentibus aperire voluisse.*[8]

According to Bovo, Boethius behaves not only in the poem that he is commenting (i. e. *Consolatio* III metrum IX) but in the entire *Consolatio* more like a Platonic philosopher than a Christian. Bovo says this even though he knows that Boethius wrote some *Opuscula theologica* whose elegance consecrates them as undoubtedly genuine. As a consequence, Bovo confines

6 For a thorough examination of these commentaries see Courcelle (1939) 66 – 76. We have limited ourselves to a selected few of these tenets.

7 This is the title of the opusculum in the *corpus Floriacense*, which we adopted in our edition.

8 "First of all, it must be observed that not only in this poem [i.e. III metrum IX], but also in many other passages of the work which has the title *The Consolation of Philosophy* it is possible to find some tenets which are against the Christian faith: and this is strange, since I read a very beautiful book of the same author about the Holy Trinity, and another against the heretics Eutyches and Nestorius. Everyone who dedicates himself to reading those books (as I did since my youth) will recognize without any doubt, due to the particular brightness of their elegance, that their author is the same. Be it as it may, it is certain that the author in these books did not discuss the doctrines of the Church, but only wanted to open to the readers only the tenets of the philosopher, and mostly of the Platonists."

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himself in the next pages to expounding Boethius' poem by recurring to the Platonic doctrines that he knew, especially thanks to Macrobius' *Commentarius in Somnium Scipionis*. But everything ends there: Bovo does not question Boethius' Christianity, but simply confines himself to interpreting a certain part of his work with those philosophical instruments that, in his opinion, it required.

Also, while setting out to explain a delicate passage in the Boethian poem, namely that concerning the existence of different souls in the universe, which he interprets as a reference to the *anima mundi*, a universally widespread doctrine at that time, Bovo writes:

XII. *quapropter etiam sequentia istorum versuum, quibus philosophia velut ipsam divinitatem invocando alloquitur, cum ingenti scrupulo tractare adgredimur, maxime quia haec ad instructionem religiosae conversationis fideique non pertinent. Et quoniam a scrutandis divinae legis archanis, quorum dulcedine piae mentes in hac vita satiari non possunt, his inutilibus vel ad modicum intenti praepedimur, tamen si dulcissimae dilectionis nostrae voluntati satisfecero, nequaquam inutiliter laborasse me existimo, praesertim cum sicut saepe dicenda sunt salutaria quae teneantur, sic interdum dicenda sunt etiam noxia quae vitentur.*[9]

That is, Bovo warns the reader against doctrines dangerous for the soul of a Christian.

Bovo continues (c. XIII), commenting on the verses devoted to the soul, and observes that philosophers taught the existence of a cosmic soul "*non secundum veritatem sed secundum opinionum suarum commenta. Quae quoniam, ut dixi, a nostris dogmatibus aliena sunt, prout necessitas huius expositionis exigit, strictim attingenda et transeunter commemoranda sunt*".[10] It is necessary, at this stage, to refer only to the famous verses by Virgil (*Aen.* VI 724 – 34), constantly quoted throughout the Middle Ages to support the doctrine on the existence of the cosmic soul. So Boethius intends with the term 'soul' what Virgil defines as 'spirit.' Such is Bovo's explanation "*de Platonicis figmentis*" (XIV end).

Commenting (c. XXI) on the verses: "*tu causis animas paribus vitasque minores / provehis et levibus sublimes curribus aptans / in caelum terramque*

9 "Therefore we set about to examine with great care also the context of the following lines, in which Philosophy turns in prayer to the Divinity itself, mostly because they have nothing to do with the instruction of how a religious behaviour must be and of Christian faith. And since we cannot examine the mysteries of the divine law, by whose sweetness the pious minds cannot be satisfied in this life, if we pay even a little attention to present useless distractions, I am sure not to have worked in vain if I am able to satisfy the desires of you, whom we warmly love, so much so that, as healthy doctrines have to be proposed many and many times, sometimes also the dangerous tenets, which still must be avoided, are the object of our consideration."

10 "Not according to the truth, but to the inventions produced by their personal opinions. Since such doctrines, as I said, are alien to our faith, they must be briefly touched upon and mentioned in passing, due to the necessity of our exposition."

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seris, quas lege benigna / ad te conversas reduci facis igne reverti" (III metrum IX, 18–21),[11] Bovo observes that one must avoid dedicating oneself to the explanation of these lines, since Boethius after proposing the existence of the cosmic soul now introduces the existence of the particular souls ("*explicita ratione de maxima mundi anima nunc de statu minorum animarum incipit loqui*"), which is absolutely denied by Christian religion. Pagan philosophers, indeed, invented absurd tales about the descent of the souls to earth, which presupposes their preexistence, but every intelligent reader will exclude it. It is possible, however, that these doctrines are useful when interpreted as if they meant a different doctrine, while beguiled to error by the sweetness of the poem. Boethius himself, when he says: "*humanas animas liberiores quidem esse necesse est cum se in mentis divinae speculatione conservant, minus vero cum dilabuntur ad corpora, minusque etiam cum terrenis artubus colliganturtur*"[12] (V 2,8) seems to contradict what had been said above about the descent of the souls to the earth (c. XXII).

Bovo concludes that it is certainly not believable that human or angelic spirits join the stars or dwell among them (XXIV). It must be admitted that:

quaedam in his verba philosophicum redolere venenum; sed quoniam ea catholicae aures rectius accipere et in meliorem partem interpretari solent, et ob hoc fidei non nocent, id gratanter accipio atque de his censui reticere.[13]

He repeats that some of Boethius' doctrines do not respond to Christian faith, but are similar to the inventions of the philosophers; yet he has no doubt that Boethius was truly a Christian.[14]

4.2 The *Anonymus Einsiedlensis*

This anonymus commentator is called *Einsiedlensis* because the most ancient and reliable manuscript containing his observations on Boethius' *Consolatio*

11 "You then bring forth, with the same bases, lesser living souls, / and giving them light chariots fitting their heavenly nature, / broadcast them in the heavens and on earth, and by your bounteous law / make them, turned towards you, with returning fire come back."

12 "But human souls must indeed be more free when they preserve themselves in the contemplation of the divine mind; less free, however, when they slip down to the corporeal, and still less free, when they are bound into earthly limbs."

13 "Some words among these sting the poison of philosophy, but since the ears of Christians can understand them rightly and interpret in the better way, and for this reason they do not damage the faith, I am glad to accept this fact and I decided to pass them over in silence."

14 Courcelle's judgment of Bovo is partly true, partly too enthusiastic: "Un tel commentaire dénote des qualités vraiment surprenantes, et certains très modernes: une intelligence peu commune, qui pose et résout les problèmes avec acuité; un souci d'impartialité inouï au Xe siècle ; une sensibilité religieuse assez éveillée pour discerner immédiatement et rejeter avec horreur toute théorie qui menace la foi." Cf. Courcelle (1939) 70–71.

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III metrum IX belongs to the Abbey of Einsiedeln (Stiftsbibliothek 302, *saec.* X). He was, according to Huygens,[15] "ein grosser Geist wie Bovo"; unfortunately, only a fragment of his work has survived. The Anonymus appears to have been a scholar more interested in Platonism than in Christian doctrine, and very familiar with Platonic philosophy (according to the possibilities of his age). He may perhaps have read Calcidius' commentary on the *Timaeus*.

The prayer of Lady Philosophy, he says, depends completely on Plato, because Plato in the *Timaeus* asserted that "to find the creator and the father of the universe is difficult, and, if you have found him, it is impossible to explain him to others".[16] Plato had stated as well that all things come from God, that there is only one beginning of the world and that such a beginning lasts for eternity;[17] also, that there is a difference between *aevum*, which is perpetuity everlasting in simplicity, and time, which is change and eternal recurrence on itself: as such, time is the image of eternity. The material world, in which we live, is the sensible image of the intelligible world, which resides in the mind of the creator. And the cause of the creation of the world is simply the goodness of the divine will. The Anonymus appears to have rightly understood the doctrines of the *Timaeus*, as far as he could know them.

After this summary of the Platonic philosophy, the Anonymus continues his commentary of Boethius' lines. Like Bovo, he explains that the cosmic soul gives life and movement to the world, according to Virgil's explanation (*Aen.* VI 724 – 34): the world, therefore, is a living and rational being. And the world soul is threefold, because a part of it is composed of the indivisible and the same: this part has a divine origin; a second part is composed of the divisible and the different, which is the soul that is in the bodies and thanks to its vital energy gives them their form and enables their growth. This is proper to animals, to which it provides sensation, imagination and a kind of memory, lacking in reason. The third kind of soul is intermediate between the indivisible and the divisible one and is a mixture of both: it is the soul of humans. The world soul is composed of these three kinds of soul, "*id est ex vitali et rationali et immortali*": animals, humans, and angels (I suppose). The explanation of the nature of the three souls comes from the *Timaeus* (34c–36d) and it is likely dependent on Calcidius.

After a short description of the sky, the planets and their movements, the commentator again explains the nature of the cosmic soul, which, in the poem of Boethius, is interpreted according to the *Platonicum dogma.* The cosmic soul turns to itself in a circular movement: such movement is free from any

15 Huygens (1954) 399; a very favourable judgment is also given by Courcelle (1939, 71 – 72).
16 Cf. *Tim.* 28c.
17 Therefore this commentator interpreted the so-called 'creation' of the world in the *Timaeus* not as a beginning in time, but as a dependence from a higher principle – as most of the Platonists did.

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error and the soul is not visible as it passes through the world. The creator chooses the souls which have to be inserted into the single stars and assigns them a vehicle. The stars, animated by their souls, take care of the universe and of all things it contains; they produce the fruits of the earth. After death, the souls of the humans, if they lived in an honest and upright way, will be granted the return to the stars. All this seems to be taken from Macrobius' *Commentary on the Dream of Scipio.*

Here the commentary is interrupted. We do not know if the commentator attempted to justify somehow, as Bovo did, Boethius' clearly Platonic (and pagan) doctrines. He appears, however, to characterize Boethius as decidedly more pagan than either Bovo or Adalboldus do.

4.3 Adalboldus of Utrecht

In a very refined style, Adalboldus (tenth century) remarks on the first verse of the poem:

huius […] *lectionis*[18] *paleas Hermes et Plato, caecus uterque, discussit, sed interiora neuter eorum penetrare potuit, quia ad opus ferventis fidei molas non habuit. Uterque eorum caecus sub tenebris palpavit quod Boetius exerto veritatis lumine vidit. Vidit mundum perpetua ratione regi, quia intellexit illum per sapientiam Dei, id est per Filium Dei, non tantum factum esse, sed etiam gubernari. Haec est ratio quae apud Platonem benivolentia, apud Hermetem bona voluntas, apud Psalmistam* (Ps. 84:13?) *vocatur benignitas.*[19]

This taken into consideration, Adalboldus then praises Boethius' *Consolatio* and nowhere in his entire commentary does he reject Boethius' doctrine; on the contrary,[20] he comes to the conclusion that his doctrine is sound. He repeats the assertions of Bovo that it is not possible to conceive of the fall of the souls from heaven, and with regard to the origin of the souls he refers, like Bovo, to the discussion of the problem between Jerome and Augustine (see Augustine, *Epist.* 165 – 7).

18 Of the first line of III metrum IX: "*O qui perpetua mundum ratione gubernas.*"

19 "The straw of this expression has been shaken by Plato and Hermes (Trismegistus), both blind men, but neither of them could penetrate in its inner meaning, because neither of them had the millstone of a fervent faith [to grind it]. Both in their blindness grasped in the darkness what Boethius saw thanks to the clear light of the truth. Boethius saw that the world is ruled by a perpetual rationality, because he understood that the world not only has been created, but also is governed by God's Wisdom, which is God's Son. This reason has been called by Plato 'good providence', by Hermes 'good will', by the Psalmist 'God's benevolence'."

20 "Adalbold est un prudent, un modéré, dans son admiration pour Boèce" (Courcelle (1939) 75).

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4.4 Christian faith and philosophy

Scholars have searched for the presence of quotations from Holy Scripture in the *Consolatio*, mainly in vain. The most evident seems to be the allusion to Wisdom 8:1 (III 12,22: "*Est igitur summum* […] *bonum quod regit cuncta fortiter suaviterque disponit*"[21]). In *Consolatio* IV 4,23 the reasoning touches upon the problem of hell and purgatory, but Philosophia adds that "*sed nunc de his disserere consilium non est*".[22] On the contrary, in III 12,35 Boethius praises Philosophy for having demonstrated her doctrine "*nullis extrinsecus sumptis, sed ex altero altero fidem trahente insitis domesticisque probationibus*," i. e. through strictly philosophical arguments, which had not been taken "*extrinsecus*," i. e. (supposedly) from theology.

But more recent scholarship has demonstrated that the presence (or absence) of elements of Christianity cannot be considered as proof for the Christian faith or the paganism of a writer in the fifth and sixth centuries. Still more important, it may occur that a Christian writer or poet regularly incorporates elements of pagan culture in his work, such as the gods, the Muses, the mythology.[23]

The problem of Boethius' faith, therefore, must be formulated in a different way, not in the sense of an opposition between Christianity and Platonic philosophy, but in a manner appropriate to the cultural reality of his time. In Late Antiquity, in fact, the opposition between philosophy and religious faith was not conceived with the same precision to which we are accustomed in the wake of the Enlightenment, nor did a possible separation of them involve elements of contrast, which we believe need resolving. To do so is to interpret Boethius' spiritual perspective in an anachronistic way, inspired by the liberal doctrines of the nineteenth century, namely as if dealing with a separation of the religious sphere from the rational sphere of human activity.[24]

Such was Momigliano's interpretation, formerly widely acclaimed. Still influenced by the dichotomy between Christian faith and philosophy, he concluded that at the end of his life Boethius, after having been a Christian, turned to pagan philosophy.[25] The *Consolatio*, he says,

> however prepared by long meditation in earlier life, went beyond anything Boethius had done before: it must have taken the author himself by surprise. Many people have

21 "It is therefore the highest good […] which rules all things firmly, and sweetly disposes them."

22 "But it is not my design to discuss these now" – i. e., to discuss the punishments of the wicked, whether they are penal or purifying, i. e., whether they are the punishments of Hell or of Purgatory, according to Christian doctrine (yet we must keep in mind that the doctrine of Purgatory had not yet been established in Boethius' times).

23 Cf. Tommasi (2012), 82 – 85.

24 The separation between faith and philosophy had been rightly rejected by Obertello (1974), 770 – 4.

25 See Momigliano (1960), 191 – 229, at 201 – 2.

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turned to Christianity for consolation. Boethius turned to paganism. His Christianity collapsed – it collapsed so thoroughly that perhaps he did not even notice its disappearance. The God of the Greek philosopher gave peace to his mind. The arrogance with which he had dealt with Christian theology was replaced by a new humility. This may show that his earlier attempt to harmonize philosophy and Christianity was on unstable basis.

It is difficult to concur with any of these peremptory and ill-informed assertions.

Boethius had set out to write a consolation of philosophy, that is to gather all the arguments that philosophical reasoning could provide, in order to situate in a thoroughly cosmic vision those painful events he had personally experienced. Therefore, he had no reason to seek elsewhere, not even in Holy Scripture, the arguments he found in philosophy. Boethius believed, as did the tradition of philosophical consolation, that philosophy might provide him with the explanation of the universe, of man, and of his existence; that it might allow him to understand the meaning of evil, that is, to answer the question he had asked himself. In philosophy he sought so much, and he found so much, so he evidently did not feel the need to look for those answers in Christian religion, even though he certainly professed it.[26] A similar case is that of a much less important and known author than Boethius. Calcidius wrote in the fourth century, and therefore in a fully Christian age, a commentary on Plato's *Timaeus*, that is a scientific work of a strictly secular and pagan nature (except for a few allusions to Christian doctrine). Yet Calcidius was certainly Christian, possibly living in the milieu of a Christian bishop, Ossius of Corduba. In the Greek Christian world we can observe the same problem – similarly formulated in a too radical manner – with regard to Synesius, who was even a bishop, but explained Trinitarian doctrine by resorting to Neo-Platonic philosophy rather than Scripture or Christian philosophical speculations. Again, Dionysius the Aeropagite, certainly a Christian, proposed an entirely Neo-Platonic theology.

On the other hand, the opposite hypothesis, that is that the *Consolatio* might be a pagan work in the style of Greek Neo-Platonism contemporary to Boethius, is also invalid. The *Consolatio*, in spite of its philosophy, is definitely the work of a Christian. Courcelle, criticizing Carton's opinion that Boethius is deeply influenced by Augustine, asserts that the *Consolatio* "ne prouverait nullement l'augustinisme de Boèce," but, if at all, "un christianisme qui rappellerait surtout les hardiesses platonisants d'Origène."[27] We object, first, that Augustinianism has permeated the *Opuscula Theologica*, although not the doctrines of the *Consolatio* (see however Crabbe's interpretation of poetry in Augustine and Boethius). Second, that Boethius in the *Consolatio* (but only in the *Consolatio*), could be Christian without being Augustinian. The God that

26 My opinion is actually confirmed by Troncarelli (2012), 68 – 82.
27 Courcelle (1967), 230.

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Boethius invokes, even though he shares many characteristics of the demiurge of the *Timaeus*, is not the impersonal god typical of Greek philosophy, but the Christian God, on whose existence and beneficial activity, and love for human beings Boethius meditates: the concept of divine love is quite frequent in this work. He follows Neo-Platonism, but reinterprets it in a Christian sense, in a way not unlike Marius Victorinus before him. In addition, Boethius in his work certainly agrees with Augustine on many issues, as we saw. Lastly, the 'hardiesses' to which Courcelle refers were considered heretical in the sixth century, and were condemned by the Concilium Constantinopolitanum in 553 AD.

The best interpretation has been formulated by Henry Chadwick:

> Today it is accepted by all scholars that the attentive Neo-Platonic logician who tries in I – III and V to unravel logical tangles for the use of the Church is nobody else but the author of the *Consolatio* and the commentaries on Aristotle, with which they show many parallels in thought and expression. Those tractates, with the exception of the IV, contain even more Neoplatonism than the *Consolation of Philosophy* itself. […]
>
> The *Consolation* is a work written by a Platonist who is also a Christian, but is not a Christian work. Nevertheless, I think it a work written with the consciousness of Augustine standing behind the author's shoulder, so to speak. The argument that Boethius intended a Platonic confession of faith which he knew to be incompatible with Christianity fails against the observation that there is nothing which one can also find accepted in the philosophical dialogues and the *Confessions* of the young Augustine.[28]

Following Chadwick, Crabbe underscores how crucial Augustine is for understanding the *Consolatio*.[29] Once the additions made in the last century are removed, she says, such an interpretation would require little effort of adaptation, and half of the Neo-Platonic refinements suit Augustine equally well shortly after his conversion. Philosophy is described in terms reminiscent of Continence, which Augustine describes in his *Confessions*. "It is difficult to avoid the conclusion that Boethius took the scene from the *Confessions* in order to unite it to those parts of the *Dialogues* so as to make it one of the most important models for the opening of his work."[30] Finally, Boethius also uses – consistent with Augustine – the themes of autobiography, memory, and of *conversio*. There is, however, another point in common, that of design. Both works are very one-sided dialogues. Augustine rejects any intermediary; his interlocutor is God. Boethius keeps God at a distance: Philosophy provides him with the link. It would be an exaggeration to claim that Augustine is the one who executes the entire dialogue, and that Philosophy does the same in the *Consolatio*, yet this is not far from the truth. Crabbe concludes that the

28 Chadwick (1981), 174.
29 Crabbe (1981), 241.
30 Crabbe (1981), 254 – 5.

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Confessions must be counted among those works that have influenced Boethius the most.[31]

A recent interpretation by D. Shanzer points in another direction.[32] She observes that Momigliano believed that Cassiodorus had also been a pagan, just like Boethius in the *Consolatio*. She inquires into the reasons for an author, living in the sixth century and certainly Christian, to entirely avoid biblical language without discussing this problem. How could a theologian concerned with theological problems display no interest in the *verba* of the Bible? Boethius "rewrites and de-Biblicizes," she states. What did he seek to accomplish with this "socio-linguistic strategy of neutralization?" Evidently, it allowed him to maintain a certain barrier between his philosophical language and his religious writing.[33] He was moved by the desire to separate faith from reason, as demonstrated at the end of *Cons.* III 12,35, where he insists on the necessity of arguing only through internal proofs, without availing himself of "*rationes extra petitae.*" Other examples of this non-Christian re-writing may be found. Rand observed[34] that Boethius' situation is similar to that of Dracontius, who also wrote while in prison. In the case of a theodicy written from the perspective of impending death, we should expect some form of theological-religious reaction. Shanzer places Boethius in the cultural climate of fifth- and sixth-century Italy, which she considers to have been much more secular and less religious than Gaul. Examples of non-Christian language are also found in Cassiodorus. The *De anima* itself is a good example of a paraphilosophical text, enabling one to study a writer during his religious transition (the work dates from 538 – 540 AD). In Cassiodorus' *De anima* Christ is mentioned only six times. The statistics concerning words pertaining to God in the *Variae* are equally revealing. Yet an almost literal quotation from the book of Wisdom (8:1) is present in the *Consolatio* (III 12,22). This is the only moment in the entire work in which a biblical signal is intentionally given. The passage had been quoted rarely by Christian writers previously, until it was discovered by Augustine. The syntagm "*haec quibus uteris verba*" must be intended in the sense, "these words from Sapientia that you use."

Philosophy, defined by Boethius as *amor sapientiae* in *Isag.* 1,3, quotes a verse of the Old Testament concerning personified Wisdom and identifies it with the *summum bonum*. The importance attributed by Boethius to Wisdom corresponds to that found in Oriental theology and its doctrine of Sophia as the Holy Spirit. In support of this interpretation *Consol.* I 1,3 may also be mentioned, where Philosophy, alluding to her dress which she has woven with her own hands, is implicitly identified with the Neo-Platonic Athena, Il. V 733 – 5, quoted by Proclus and identified with Wisdom in *Comm. Parm.*, p.

31 Crabbe (1981), 261.
32 Shanzer (2009), 57 – 78.
33 Courcelle (1967), 342.
34 Rand (1928), 160.

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851,36 and *Comm. Tim.* I 167,18. This to my mind is speculative. Shanzer hypothesizes that Boethius aims at the lowest common denominator between any theistic system (*religio*) and Christian religion, which is the cause, for example, of the absence of Christ. By doing so, he intended to preserve the tolerance that had endured for so long in Ostrogothic Italy. An extremely difficult aim, in my opinion.

This conclusion Shanzer reiterates in a second article.[35] She observes that the Christianity of the *Consolatio* is a peculiar form of Christianity: it is not based on the New Testament, but is of a sapiential and philosophical kind, which has a parallel in the syncretism of a much older period, that is, in Hellenistic Judaism, making tags like "Christian" or "pagan" inacceptable; very appropriately, Shanzer draws a comparison with the figure of Synesius, whom we introduced earlier as another example of a Christian Platonist like Boethius. The world of the *Consolatio* includes a *summum bonum*, who is God, and also personified Wisdom, but does not include Christ. For this reason, she considers Boethius to be more a learned man of Late Antiquity than a philosopher, a learned person very familiar with Latin poetry – for me a statement difficult to accept. Shanzer claims that the *Opuscula Theologica*, written earlier, also reflect a different *Weltanschauung*, that is a Christian one, while the *Consolatio* proposes something new. She concludes with this audacious explanation: Boethius, "if he is not an actual apostate, was certainly exploring an alternative way," which was that of establishing a common ground between philosophy and religion, suggesting a secular form of Christian religion.

Fabio Troncarelli attributes to the philosophy of the *Consolatio* an emblematic meaning.[36] The reason why the *Consolatio* does not aim at being an openly Christian work, but at the same time appears as a work extremely well crafted on the literary plane, is that with it Boethius intended to confirm the validity of Roman culture and civilization, in which he had always believed. This attitude is also found in Ennodius and Cassiodorus. The prerequisite for the interpretation of the *Consolatio* is the acceptance of Platonism and, more generally, of philosophy as a precious ally of faith, and the notion that, at least in principle, the Boethian theories are not incompatible with Christianity per se, even though they may provide material for discussion. This persuasion is common to many Fathers and, in particular, to Cassiodorus, who wrote the *De anima* almost without naming Christ; only in this way was it possible to call effortlessly Plato's god-demiurge *kyrios*. Actually, in Troncarelli's view, worries about orthodoxy did not trouble the first readers of Boethius' *Consolatio*, as they were less suspicious than our contemporaries and more tolerant, forbearing, and eclectic in matters concerning faith. In the same spirit Cassiodorus accepts, with all reservations

35 Shanzer (2009b), at 240 – 4.

36 Troncarelli (1988), 501 – 50, at 516 – 22.

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imposed by diplomacy, Origenes into the citadel of monastic culture, when confessional scruples would be more severe than before. It is enough to distinguish the good from the wrong, and to be able to grasp the first, he writes (*Institut.* I 18). The *Consolatio*, therefore, is not only a philosophical-theological tractate expressing the outcome of a serene meditation, a quiet discussion with a friend on the main problems of man: it is a text generated by the urgency of a dramatic situation, which replies to the concussion of reality by transcending it through an intellectual reworking. It establishes its own ethical and theological program.

Interesting observations about the presumed Christian faith of Boethius were proposed by Alessandra di Pilla.[37] She examines the passage of the *Consolatio* (V 3,33 – 6) devoted to the function and meaning of prayer, as a type of relation between humans and God. The problem had been previously examined by John Magee, who concluded that Boethius' "belief in efficacy of prayer is not in itself sufficient to separate him from pagan Neoplatonists."[38] Di Pilla, too, examines the Neo-Platonic texts, which show that Boethius, in his interpretation of prayer, follows, as usual, Neo-Platonism as well as Roman tradition, from Cicero's *De divinatione* down to Martianus Capella's *De nuptiis* (IX 892 – 3), a passage in which Martianus asserts that the seven virgins who are at the suite of Philologia "*inter divina humanaque discidia solae semper interiunxere colloquia.*" This is typically Neo-Platonic: the virgins, who are intermediary between gods and humans (i. e. they are the arts of divination permitting the contact between the human and the divine), alone ('*solae*') permit such a contact. In contrast, Boethius underlines the personal character of the contact between God and humans: prayer is a '*commercium*' between them. Boethius does not think (as the Neo-Platonists did) that prayer permits a 'connectio' with God, but the addressing of Him. This could be a sign of his Christian faith.[39]

As a conclusion, we briefly summarize: the *Consolatio*, despite all efforts to interpret it as the document of a non-Christian attitude or of a *sui generis* Christianity, is indeed the work of a Christian Platonist, who was seeking in philosophy the consolation he needed. It is the work of a Christian in toga.

In spite of a few isolated critical opinions, the *Consolatio* was highly esteemed not only because of its moral and metaphysical doctrine, but also because of the dramatic death of its author, who was considered a martyr of the faith, unjustly condemned by a barbarian and heretic king.[40] Boethius was "l'anima santa che '1 mondo fallace / fa manifesto a chi di lei ben ode," that is, through the consolation of philosophy, Boethius had taught those who were

37 Di Pilla (2003), 507 – 29.

38 Magee (1989), 149.

39 Di Pilla (2003), 526 – 9.

40 Boethius was revered as if he were a saint: confusion of Boethius with St. Severin was not unusual in the Middle Ages. On the topic see also Galonnier (Boèce (2007), 96 – 100. Boethius' remains are preserved in the church S. Pietro in Ciel d'Oro in Pavia.

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able to understand him the vanity of all human things. His life is likened to an exile of the soul in the earthly body; here, Dante employs the motif of earthly life as exile and peregrination away from the heavenly homeland, which is found several times in the *Consolatio*. Thus, although Boethius has been martyred, only his body remains on earth, while his soul, together with that of other doctors of the Church, enjoys the peace of heaven: "lo corpo ond'ella fu cacciata giace / giuso in Cieldauro; ed essa da martiro / e da essilio venne a questa pace" (*Parad.* X, 124 – 6).

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Beiträge zur Europäischen Religionsgeschichte (BERG)
Volume 3

Boethius is apparently the first Christian writer who was not engaged in dogmatic and theological problems from an ecclesiastical point of view. Boethius hadn't any ecclesiastical office, but was engaged in politics under King Theoderic in Italy, and from his youth he had devoted himself to Aristotelian and Platonic philosophy. Some of his medieval commentators noticed the unchristian, simply Platonic character of his philosophy. Claudio Moreschini, on the basis of Boethius' »Opuscula Theologica« and »Consolatio Philosophiae«, shows how he combined Christian faith and philosophy in order to solve theological issues, most notably the Christological debates of his time or the question of the Trinity. Moreschini further examines Boethius' work from the point of view of Latin Platonism, highlighting the aims of his poetry and his philosophical tenets.

The author

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